When the Music Stops

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Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Mutual Pining, Enemies to Friends to Lovers, Childhood Friends, Drug Abuse, Prostitution, Violence, Alternate Universe - Police, Praise Kink

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by thethingsnobodyasks

Summary

Catra is a stripper involved in unsavory business. Adora is a cop who's just been promoted to detective and moved back to her home-city district. What could possibly go right?

Notes

I have NO IDEA what this will turn out to be. I just love the concept of Adora as a cop and Catra as a delinquent.

Save the Last Dance for Me

Chapter Summary

> After 7 years, they meet each other again in an unexpected place.

t hurt. W atching her actually hurt, but Adora couldnt pull her eyes away. Tey traced every line and curve on display as the woman danced -mesmerized by the fluidity of her movements. And there were a lot of lines and curves on display...Her body wanted to squirm in the seat, wanted to do something to disrupt the slow turning sensation in her belly, but she was held firmly in place by the heterochromatic eyes, gleaming their beautiful colors in the flashing lights.

Or maybe it was all the feelings that weighed her down -so heavy that she couldnt move. Tat could be it. She was sad. She was angry and hurt -still devastated, really. Tere had been no closure. But also, she was definitely more than a little nervous as Catra drew closer with those 'come-n-get-me' eyes. And she was still a little bit possessive. How many people had come here to watch her dance? How many people came here and thought nasty things while watching her? How many people touched her? Adora wanted to drag her off that stage, kicking and screaming or otherwise, and take her away from it all.

Catra had always joked about being a stripper when they were younger, but Adora never thought she'd actually do it. Yet, here she was, making an entire crowd drool. She always did like that kind of attention. She moved back towards a pole center stage, pulling herself up with ease -twisting and turning and somehow not missing a beat. She was...really impressive. Her movements were graceful but strong and so, so sexy. Every once in a while, Catra's eyes would fall heavy on Adora again, satisfied, as if she knew the effect she was having.

Suddenly, Adora regretted letting herself be talked into going to a strip club, and letting Mermista and Seahawk choose the seats. Of course they'd pick the spot right by the stage. But the performers before this were fine -it was just Catra. Then the song ended, she collected a few bills and walked off the stage, all eyes following.

"Whoa." Bow sat forward to look at her. "Dude she was totally eyeing you."

"Adora?" She was years away, back to being a teenager, full of all kinds of this frustration, nervousness, and excitement.

From somewhere behind her, she heard a guy say, "Bet she cant do all that with my dick in her."

"She totally fucking could, man."

Adora stood from her seat so fast that her feet left the ground for an instant, ready to punch somebody's lights out. She stood glaring at the group of men behind her. One of them was wearing a crown - must be a bachelor party. They looked like a bunch of squares, all dressed in the same business-like attire. They were staring back at her, as were many people around them. She realized how ridiculous she probably looked in her own little sash.

Glimmer pulled at her arm, "Girl, chill. Sit. What's gotten into you?"

She moved slowly, sinking back down as she remembered how heavy she felt a moment before. She had to talk to her. "Adora, did you know her?" She just sort of shook her head dumbly. "Really?" She had to talk to her.

"I've gotta talk to her." She stood up again, weaving through tables, looking for a way around the stage. Her heart was pounding in her ears, faster than the music. What would she even say? She didnt know. There was a man standing in front of double doors. A waitress went through and she could see dancers in the hallway. Adora took a step forward but the bouncer held out his arm to bar her way.

"Sorry Ma'am, no entrance." He seemed to be sizing her up, questioning her motives. How often did people try to get back there?

"I really need to speak with the dancer that was just on."

He shook his head. "I can't let you back there." He seemed annoyed that she wouldn't just walk away.

"Can I wait for her out here? How can I talk to her?"

"Lapdance."

Shit. Well, if she had to pay to talk to her, she would. "How do I do that?"

He lifted up a large arm and snapped his fingers. Another waitress came around from the bar. "Watcha need hon?"

"I would like..." she looked back at the bouncer, "... a lapdance from one of your dancers."

"Got any in mind?"

"Yes! Her name is Catra."

The woman shifted her weight from one leg to the other, sticking her hip out. "Sorry hon, nobody here by that name." Still, something about her eyes said she was lying. Somehow that made Adora feel at least a little bit better. They were trying to protect her in their own way. That was nice.

But wait. What was her stage name? The announcer said it but she was so baffled when she saw Catra walk out on stage that she just sort of shut off. "She was just on." How could she describe Catra in a way that would be unmistakable? "She's got a slightly darker complexion," dances like it's just for you, "...with some freckles on her shoulders and her cheeks," gorgeous smooth skin, "one golden-brown eye and one tealy blue," a laugh that stops your heart. "Oh, no, don't say that. "wavy brunette hair and... and a belly button piercing."

The woman eyed her once more, thinking. "She's with somebody right now. Wait by the bar, I'll send her out when she's done." With somebody? She was already giving somebody else a lap dance?

"Okay. Thank you."

She walked back to the bar, getting increasingly nervous. Did Catra really recognize her? Adora hadn't changed all that much - neither has she. But also, kind of. Her hair was longer, and it looked like she had dyed it a bit darker. She was definitely in good shape - not that she was ever in bad shape. It's just that she was a bit more muscular now, clearly strong enough to do pole tricks. She was either using a tanning bed or laying out in the sun a lot - nobody had an even, full-body tan like that. Whenever she got tan, the cool metal of her belly button piercing stood out more - tonight on stage, it sparkled.

Adora couldn't help but wonder if her personality had changed. Had she lived in the city this whole time? Why hadn't she ever reached out or responded to Adora's texts? How did she end up doing this?

Her eye was caught by the wave of Glimmer's hand, looking back at her quizzically. Adora shrugged and pointed to the side doors. She mouthed 'I'm waiting.' Glimmer didn't seem to get the message. Adora pointed to her chest and then tapped her wrist, as if she was wearing a watch, drawing the syllables out, 'wai-tinggg'. Glimmer nodded and then started waving her hand, saying something. Something - something - you? Spinning. Turning?

"You know, you never were good at charades." The honeyed voice made her freeze, goosebumps rising on her arms and neck. She turned around slowly, eyes wide, to find Catra in a very sheer, silky black robe with bright orange flowers on it. "Hey, Adora."

That's all she needed to hear to know that Catra hadn't changed. She nodded her head for Adora to follow her. Without thinking, her legs obliged. Adora gave one final 'wish-me-luck' look at her friends, who were giving her a thumbs up. The bouncer let them pass into a hallway lined with doors to private rooms. Catra opened a door and

let Adora in. It was kind of dim, except for string lights on the ceiling giving off a warm glow. She followed them from the back of the room to the door, and back down to Catra. Suddenly she felt claustrophobic -it was a very small room.

"So-"

"Twenty bucks for 5 minutes. No touching." She thinks I actually want a lap dance? She groaned internally, hearing her friends' voices. I mean, I guess we did come here for the strip club experience'. She reached into her pocket and grabbed her wallet. She pulled out a twenty and some ones -Seahawk said it was polite to tip them a little bit. She held it out meekly to Catra, who gave that gut-wrenching grin. "Well, what are you waiting for? Aren't you gonna give it to me?" Why did she have to say it like that? So breathy... Catra's rasp always took a serious toll on Adora's mental capacity and she knew it. Adora's throat made a noise when she swallowed, bringing a fresh wave of embarrassment. What does she mean? I'm already holding out my hand…

"First time at a strip club, princess?" That nickname...Catra used to call her that all the time. It had transformed over the years they had gotten to know each other, starting as an irksome and somewhat demeaning word. But by the time they were in high school, it had become a term of endearment, recognition of Catra's praise and affection.

She nodded -barely -and Catra rolled her eyes. Adora watched her hand move to pull gently on the string of her robe, causing the silk to just sort of fall open for her eyes to drink in the sight of the strip of sun-kissed skin from her neck all the way down to the top of whatever black underwear she had on -God, Catra was a beautiful woman. It was maddening that even after all this time, she was just as enthralling without any effort. Her hand raised to play ever so lightly with the now-plunging neckline of the fabric, threatening to expose a collar bone.

Adora's eyes were torn in so many directions, wanting to see all of her. When she finally forced them back up to Catra's face, she felt her heart skip a beat. Catra was motioning for her finger to 'come here', eyes mimicking that single dare: closer . They'd played this game of chicken before. Adora never won, but it was always fun playing. AH! Keep your head. She' s just teasing you. Play it cool. Just talk. That' s what you came for. Things are dif ferent now. You're different.

She stepped forward until only a few inches remained, enough to reach out and touch her. Is that what she' s waiting for? I thought she said no touching? Catra pulled her robe on one side, showing of f a black thong and a lace bralette -both very small. Adora licked her lips. "W ell? Put it where you want." Where I want? Where do I want?

She reaches out, ashamed of how shaky she feels. Her eyes fall to the thin base of fabric between Catra's breasts and she considered it only for a moment. Instead, one hand reached for Catra' s wrist, and the other placed the money in her hand, meeting her gaze with as much confidence as she could muster. Catra laughed. "Boring as ever." She puts the money in the pocket of the robe and nods to the chair. "Sit."

Adora takes a few steps back and look at the chair, wondering how many people have sat there and received a dance from her in this room. Music starts, drawing her attention back to the front again. She turns and is chest-to-chest with Catra -it takes her breath away. "I said sit." She pushes Adora back into the chair with a pur , starting to dance. Hardly anything has happened yet and Adora feels like she's ready to explode as Catra lets one side of her robe slide down her shoulders. Adora can see her nipples through the lace of the bralette. Gulp.

"So, what' s the occasion? I dont see a ring." A ring? Oh, did she think I was engaged? That did make sense. Strip clubs were often places of bachelor/bachelorette parties...Did she care? I mean, enough to notice I didn't have one, so I guess that's something...

Catra threw a leg up on the chair between Adora's thighs, her body glistening slightly in the light. Was it just Adora, or had the temperature increased significantly? The air was stuffy and -Catra let the other side of the robe fall, dropping it to the floor -hot. I'm -it's my -work." Adora mentally chastised herself. The corners of Catra's lips curled and she cocked an eyebrow before turning around and continuing to sway, starting to run her hands over her body. Adora's eyes followed her fingers.

"Work?"

Catra whipped her hair around, hitting Adora with a waft of whatever sweet-smelling shampoo she used. "Mm-hmm. I got promoted." Whatever Catra was doing with her hips right now was churning her insides like a blender. She suddenly realized it'd been almost a year since she had sex -no wonder. How long had it been since she'd been this turned on by somebody? 7 years - right before Catra left.

"Congrats." She bent at the waist to grab an ankle, traveling slowly to the other. God, her ass...

Adora kept going back and forth between gawking hopelessly and staring at the distant wall. "Thanks. My ...friends dragged me here to celebrate." Catra turned around and literally crawled over, exaggerating every step closer.

"Poor baby, forced to endure such horrible-" She put her hands on Adora's thighs and pulled herself up, drawing far too close to Adora for comfort. "-torture." The truth was, it caused discomfort because it was too close to be a normal conversation, but she wasn't nearly as close as Adora needed her to be.

Her tongue felt like it was getting tied in knots. "Well I saw you and then." Catra lowered her hands to the floor in front of the chair. The heat between Adora's legs was rising to unbearable temperatures. "...came to find you so...we." She went up into a handstand. "Could." Her legs fell apart into the splits, presenting a very close to

clear view of her pussy. "Fhuuck." A quiet groan escaped with her exhale.

Adora immediately sucked her breath back in, praying she could take back the words. But it was too late -Catra definitely heard. She giggled -which only increased the pounding in Adora's fingertips - and did a back-bend onto Adora's lap, her weight cementing the mental fog over her brain. "Unfortunately , that's not on the menu." She sounded vaguely disappointed when she said 'unfortunately'. So she still felt it too? The intolerable tension that had been between them since puberty.

"I -talk! I came to talk with you." Catra started grinding down on Adora's thighs, popping and rolling her hips into her, sending pulses straight to her core. Then she rose and pushed her chest into Adora's face -she smelled so good, like summer and sweat. Adora knew what that tasted like and it made her mouth water. Catra grabbed Adora's hands and put them on the sides of her hips. She was so soft... she'd kind of filled out a little bit since the last time...

"I thought you said-"

Catra's hands moved up her arms, over her shoulders and neck to her hair, pulling gently, drawing another small sound from her throat. Goddammit. Keep it together. Catra gave a triumphant smile, leaning in next to her ear, nibbling gently. "This is an exception." Exception? Does that mean... I can touch her? Adora gave an experimental squeeze of the flesh under her hands. Catra didn't pause. "This is okay?" One hand moved back just enough that she was cupping Catra's ass. "Good girl." She cooed. It made Adora feel like she was going to bust out of her clothes at any moment -say fuck it all and take Catra here in this room.

Her skin now had a thin sheen of perspiration making her shine. She stood up, pulling away and dancing around to the back of the chair. Adora's body was aching, immediately consumed by the loss of pressure on her lap. She heard movement behind her before Catra's hand extended in front of her, holding out the black lacy bralette. Oh

no. This time, Catra sat facing away from her -Adora just gaped at her back, alternating between watching the muscles of her back play under the praline skin, and watching her ass jiggle a little bit and she moved.

She leaned back, giving Adora a view of her perfect breasts -round and firm, just big enough to fill her hands. Her nipples were hard...Once again, Catra guided Adora's hands onto her body. She brought one up to her exposed throat, applying pressure to Adora's fingers. Her skin was hot to the touch. The other started at her shoulder and slid down slowly, pausing briefly over her breasts before continuing to rest on her flat stomach, just above her thong. Catra's hands were back to playing in Adora's hair again. "I was thinking about having my tits done. What do you think?"

"Don't!" The words left her mouth before she could stop them. "I mean...you don't need it" She only had enough resolve left to control one hand -the one on Catra's throat slid down to fondle her chest, revelling in how taut the peak was. She lightly pinched and flicked the little gumdrop between her fingers, making Catra's hips jerk as a moan escaped, rattling through Adora's body.

"Easy tiger ." She stood up slow , turning around again before sitting back down, pressing her body into Adora's, whose hands immediately went to grab at Catra's ass again. "At least one of us needs to be in control." Catra' s nails on the back of her neck were drawing goose bumps up and down her arms -their noses touching.

"I am...in control." She had somehow managed to not throw Catra on the floor and rip what tiny little fabric remained from her body. THAT was goddamn control. Catra pulled away and Adora followed, eyes glued to those lips. Then Catra leaned back in and they moved again -together. It was like a last-ditch ef fort to maintain the gap between them, even though it was suffocating. Back and forth again, that cruel smile twisting the corners of Catra's gorgeous mouth. Jesus, please, just a little bit further . Adora moved forward this time, pulling at her ass, trying to draw her in closer -Catra pulled away at the same speed. Fuck. She's "...such a bitch."

Catra laughed again, softer this time, pulling close to Adora's ear. "What's that Adora? I can't hear you over the sound of all that heavy breathing." Adora didn't have the mental energy to be embarassed about it. She was too focused on trying to pull Catra closer. Just close enough. It had been so long... "Don't worry, baby. You can always come back when you want more."

The words make her stop for just a moment and Adora's face flushed a deeper red as she became painfully aware of how shaky her breaths really were. It was always like this. She was always a horrible tease. "Fuck you." I know you feel this too. Catra was wet - she could smell it. But still she would pretend she was above it all, that Adora's feelings didn't mean anything, that she didn't reciprocate. Adora felt like she was ready to blow.

"You wanna fuck me?" Catra's tongue flicked at her earlobe the same time she moaned a high-pitched sound into her ear. Adora knew it was fake but it didn't matter - the smoke and fire of her voice was enough. Adora's insides clenched and she heard a snap.

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She walked on that stage like she did every other night, pretending the crowd didn't exist for the first bit - she was alone, dancing in her room. Usually, she was able to brush the lecherous eyes off her oiled skin there were always eyes on her - greedy and pretentious. But tonight, for some reason she just couldn't. Somebody's eyes were boring into her, right through the shield she'd created as a child, exposing her. There was only one person whose eyes could do that, but there was no way she...was there. Adora was sitting right there, watching her every move. Catra could practically see their childhood playing back through Adora's eyes - her one and only best friend, her on-and-off-again foster sister, her something more…

But there was hunger there too, she could see it in Adora's expression, the way her eyes followed every move. Sometimes her

eyebrows would raise slightly, but her mouth stayed open. For the first time in a long time, butterflies took flight in her stomach thinking about dancing. She wasnt dancing for an audience -not a crowd of mostly old rich men who liked their pretty toys, no -she was dancing for Adora and Adora only. Every little trick seemed to make Adora fidget in her seat just a little, making Catra' s excitement grow. She was always so easy, so deliciously teasable.

Then the song ended, she collected a few bills, 10' s and 20's mostly, before she walked off the stage, Adora's eyes following helplessly.

Rob, the manager handed her a bottle of water. "What the hell was that?"

Catra shrugged, taking a sip. "Fun."

"Well, whatever it was, the crowd went ape shit. Ineed you to have fun like that every show sweetheart. We've got five parties of six and up between ten to midnight. Ill schedule you a dance for then."

"Catrina." The head waitress came through the back door . "You've got a private session in room 3. He paid for one song."

Rob let her through. "After a performance like that, you're gonna have a busy night."

Every night was a busy night for Catra -it was all too easy to tease men out of their wallets. She didnt even have to work hard to make it seem like she was interested. She could walk around them naked and, poof, they were enchanted, willing to throw away whatever bill they had on hand for the chance to stick it on her -to make contact with her skin. Sometimes they were crumpled ones, and sometimes they were fitfies.

Catra walked into the room to find a man who couldnt have been more than 35, probably worked an office job, and was otherwise just like the rest. She cued the music, fighting the urge to yawn. As she danced, she wondered what Adora could be doing here. She was

such a goody-two shoes, and so easily embarrassed, there's no way she makes a habit of going to strip clubs. She wore a sash...she's not getting married is she? Catra felt a twinge of something akin to disappointment at the thought, barely aware that the man was slipping bills into the waistband of her sheer lingerie. It didn't say Bride on it, but then again, Adora always did things just a bit differently than anyone else. She looked good, wearing some kind of black and white jumper - classy. It suited her. Catra remembered her blue eyes, gleaming brighter than the stage lights - they hadn't changed at all. Had she changed though?

Even though she had been deep in thought, Catra knew the song was coming to an end - she always kept track of when the song would end. It was all an act and she could turn it off or on with the click of a button. She could count the seconds down every time and get the last beat right. And she did. The song ended, she ushered the man out and went back to the changing room, putting the new bills into her pile. "Catrina." Stace knocked on the doorframe. The older woman was one of the first girls to work here, and she was arguably the reason that the place ran so efficiently as a business - well, as businesses. She always knew who was coming in or going out, and what service they received. She was too old to be a successful stripper now, so she just waitressed and ran an empire. "There's some girl out there asking for a private session. Nervous little thing. Seems like she knows you - she used your name."

The butterflies erupted again. It had to be Adora. "You've already got a few more gentlemen in line after so...only give her what she pays you for, yeah? I'll let you go get her. She's at the bar." She was a wise old woman.

Catra looked herself over in the mirror. This just wouldn't do. She fixed her hair and reapplied highlighter. But she was still missing something....ah. She dug around in her makeup bag to find a matte lipstick just one shade darker than her natural color. Now, what to wear...pretty much anything she had here was bound to make Adora go ga-ga, but she was always just a bit more uncomfortable with

nakedness, so...She decided on a little black thong and a bralette that didnt leave anything to the imagination. Ihat should do it. She smiled to her reflection. f Adora wanted a dance, she would get a dance.

She put on her sheer robe and started for the door. Why the fuck am Inervous?She chastised herself. But Adora always did that to her - made her confidence waver ever so slightly. How long had it been now?8 years?Shit. She passed the doors and saw her across the room, leaning against the bar. She looked fine as hell. Ihe jumpsuit tapered at the middle to accentuate her long legs. She still looked really, really fit. Adora had always been an athlete -soccer during the winter and track during the spring. Catra used to love watching her throw javelin or run -she was so powerful but there was so much grace.

Adora was making strange gestures with her hands. Catra followed her line of sight to the booth her friends were sitting at. A woman with short pink hair must have noticed her coming. She was waving at Adora to turn around', saying 'she' s coming'. Adora scratched her head, clueless. Catra laughed.

"Y ou know, you never were good at charades."Adora turned. "Hey , Adora."

Sparkly blue eyes gazed down at her -damn. She was still a few inches taller. She nodded her head for Adora to follow her and turned back toward the door, suddenly anxious. She could feel Adora's eyes appraising her from behind, and she could practically hear all of the questions she was going to try and ask. How are you? How have you been?How did you end up working here. She sighed inwardly. lol. SHE was going to be in control here. She was going to have Adora in the palm of her hand. She flipped the In use'tag at the top of the door and let Adora in.

She walked in, staring up at the lights. Catra knew which song she wanted to put on -the longest one she had in her cue. She stepped forward as Adora turned around, barely pushing up against her.

"So-"

"Twenty bucks for 5 minutes." That would be enough to keep Stacey off her back if they went long. Not touching. "Adora's eyes searched hers for a moment, and she wished she knew what about. Then her hand dipped into her pocket and pulled out a leather wallet. Of course she had a men's wallet. She was still such a Tomboy. Catra watched her hands search the wallet -she always had such nice hands, strong hands. And Catra was relieved to see there was no ring on her fingers. Adora reached out her hand, now holding bills.

She just stared at Adora, expectantly. "Well, what are you waiting for?" She dropped her voice the way she knew made Adora blush. "Aren't you gonna give it to me?" A smile spread across her face when she heard Adora swallow, but she made no moves to put the money anyplace.

"First time at a strip club, princess?" There was a split-second moment where they both seemed to share some nostalgia at the nickname.

Adora nodded weakly and Catra rolled her eyes. Of course it was. Adora wouldn't be caught dead doing anything haughty. That was always Catra stick. Until they were older, that is, and raging hormones were too much for Adora to handle -then she was much more...pliable. You and I are gonna have fun, then, princess. Damn the consequences. I always wanted to be your first everything. We can add this to the list.

Catra pulled gently on the string of her robe, causing the silk to slide open all the way down, Adora's eyes following the motion, clouding with want. She was the same -golden blonde hair up in a ponytail, square jaw, pink lips, proud posture on a well-build frame -but she did look older. She still looked like she was hell-bent on always doing the right thing. Even now, Catra just couldn't resist tempting her to be bad.

She motioned with her finger for Adora to move towards her, keeping her gaze the whole time. Playing with Adora was always Catra's favorite game. She could already feel heat pooling between her legs imagining all the ways she could make Adora squirm underneath her -push her the point where she would FALL Y cast her moral high ground, say fuck the rules, and roll in the mud.

She stepped forward until only a few inches remained, enough to reach out and touch her. C'mon Adora. You can figure it out. She waited, watching Adora's gears work. Or?

"Well? Put it where you want."

She reaches out -Catra notes the slight tremble of her fingers. Adora's eyes fall to her breasts and Catra's impressed. Ididnt expect you to actually have the balls to-

Instead, one hand reached for Catra's wrist, and the other placed the money in her hand, meeting her gaze. There it is -that self-righteous sense of justice. Catra laughed. "Boring as ever ."She puts the money in the pocket of the robe and nods to the chair. "Sit."

Catra starts the music and draws close again, feeling her heart beat a little faster. "I said sit."

She pushes Adora back into the chair, sending a thrill up her spine. This was going to be so much fun. She starts to dance, watching Adora freeze up and sit on her hands. She lets one shoulder of the robe fall, revelling in the attention Adora's eyes give her chest. Clearly she made the right choice of clothing. Adora swallows loudly again.

"So, what's the occasion? I dont see a ring."Adora seems oblivious. She hasnt changed -it's a loving thought.

Catra threw a leg up on the chair between Adora's thighs, really starting to feel the music as if it was actually colorful, instead of the dreary black and grey feel it had every other dance. The more

tension she felt, the more exciting it was. Adora was her pretty captive in this chair. "I'm -it' s my -work." God, I love when she stutters.

The first time she ever stuttered like that was the first time they showered together. They were fifteen and Adora had asked her to change her 'shower schedule' -whatever that was -because she had morning practices and needed to shower in the morning. Of course, Catra wasn't about to let anyone make her do anything she didn't want to do, so she continued showering at that time, whether Adora was there or not. And, she was always there. She waited till she heard Adora get up and start the shower, then she picked the lock and got in with her. Adora was so painfully shy, stealing glances between fingers and apologizing profusely . Catra loved every second of it, occasionally brushing up against her just to see her freak out. But after that first time, Adora stopped locking the door and she stopped freaking out whenever they accidentally touched, so Catra had to find new ways to get a rise out of her. The touches very quickly became purposeful, calculated, and they were always -always -effective.

The corners of Catra' s lips curled and she cocked an eyebrow before turning around and continuing to sway, starting to run her hands over her body, imagining they were Adora's.

"Work?"

Catra whipped her hair around. "Mm-hmm. I got promoted."

Sounds about right. Adora was always such a hard little worker. "Congrats." She bent at the waist to grab an ankle, traveling slowly to the other, giving Adora a full view of all she had to offer.

Catra could tell she was doing it again -trying so hard to pretend she could look away. "Thanks. My ...friends dragged me here to celebrate."

Catra dropped to her knees, crawled back to Adora, slowly. Adora's eyes were heavy-lidded looking down at her. "That's the look. "Poor baby, forced to endure such horrible-" She put her hands on Adora's thighs and pulled herself up, drawing close. "-torture." Clologne or perfume, whatever it was, Adora smelled fucking good. That neckline suited her, plunging just low enough to be alluring, but not so low that it was purposefully flashy. It would be so easy to just do what she wanted right now...if only they weren't here. Catra wanted her at home, alone, away from any and all time constraints. Shit, she was getting wet. Too bad I can't take you home with me tonight, princess.

"Well, I saw you and then-" Stop talking. Catra lowered her hands to the floor in front of the chair. "...came to find you so...we-" She went up into a handstand. Adora's struggle was so rewarding. "Could-" Her legs fell apart into the splits. "Fuuuck-" A quiet groan escaped with her exhale, lighting Catra's body on fire. Making Adora curse was one of life's simple little pleasures.

Adora immediately sucked her breath back in. Catra giggled, pleased with herself, and did a back-bend onto Adora's lap. "Unfortunately, that's not on the menu." It really was too bad. She hadn't been laid in a while, and she hadn't had really good sex since...well...Adora.

"I-talk! I came to talk with you." Mmm, talk? I don't think so. Catra wanted to tease her endlessly. She started grinding down on Adora's thighs. Then she rose and pushed her chest into Adora's face. Will she try anything? She waited a moment, hopeful. Nope. Adora was still being so careful not to let her hands slip, trying to be so good. Catra grabbed them and put them on the sides of her hips, rocking just a bit harder for good measure.

"I thought you said-"

It was like sparks flew from Adora's fingertips, fueling the fire Catra was trying not to get lost in. Her own hands felt up Adora's arms, over her shoulders and neck to her hair. She had such sexy arms...she pulled gently on Adora's hair, drawing another small

sound from her throat, which went straight to Catra's insides. Fuck. I missed her voice.

Catra gave a triumphant smile, leaning in next to her ear, nibbling gently. "This is an exception." You're special Adora -to me. She felt Adora's fingers give an experimental squeeze. You can touch, idiot. Do what you want. One hand moved back to squeeze her ass, sending another tingle up her spine. "Good girl." She whispered, feeling Adora tense underneath her. Come on, Adora. Relax. Let go.

She was sweating a little -it was starting to get really hot. Or maybe it was just them. She stood up, pulling away and dancing around to the back of the chair. Adora whined after her. Time to lose the lace. Catra shed the bralette and dangled it in front of Adora before throwing it on the ground. She let Adora anticipate her coming back for a moment, staying behind her. This time, she sat down facing away from her -feeling Adora's eyes moving over every inch of her back.

She leaned back, putting her head on Adora's shoulder, giving Adora a full view of her breasts. Once again, Catra guided Adora's hands onto her body. She brought one up to her throat, applying pressure to Adora's fingers, feeling her pulse quicken. She'd never actually told Adora she liked this before, but she could tell by the way Adora's breath hitched that she liked it too. The other hand started at her shoulder and slid down slowly. She felt Adora's arm resist and pause briefly over her breast before continuing to rest on her stomach. Her confidence wavered for a moment. Did Adora still like her smaller breasts? The other two women in her party tonight weren't as lean as she was. Was one of them her girlfriend? Was Adora dating somebody? Catra's hands went back to playing in Adora's hair again, tugging -feeling a bit more possessive. "I was thinking about having my tits done. What do you think?"

"Don't!" It was authoritative, as if she had some kind of say in the matter. She still cares. Catra felt relieved. "I mean...you don't need it" The hand on Catra's throat slid down to her chest. Fingers lightly pinched and flicked her nipple the way she knew Catra liked, making

her hips jerk as a moan escaped. Shit. That was so good. She's starting to break down. But goddammit, so am I Some small voice said, 'maybe you should put the breaks on'. Fuck no. I want to watch her fall apart. 'Okay, but you can't fall apart with her.' Fine.

"Easy tiger." She stood up slow, turning around again before sitting back down, pressing her body into Adora's. Two hands immediately reached for her ass, kneading greedily. Keep it together Catra. Suddenly it was taking willpower to not dissolve into a puddle on top of Adora. "At least one of us needs to be in control." Catra was fighting the urge to really tangle her fingers in Adora's hair and kiss the shit out of her until neither one of them could breathe.

"I am...in control." Liar. Adora's tongue was practically dancing behind her teeth. Her eyes had been closed for a while now, eyebrows knit together with determination. Her hands were pushing and pulling Catra back and forth, gently adding pressure to her own movements. They were both so close to losing it. But I'm still in control...Catra pulled away and Adora followed, eyes open again and hungry, glued to her lips. Then Catra leaned forward and Adora moved back, as if she was desperate to maintain that last painful inch of space between them. She's still trying so hard. Adora's muscles were so tense under her clothes -she was fighting everything -herself, Catra, the heat. Catra pulls away again. Adora moved forward this time, pulling at Catra's ass, trying to draw her in closer. Oh yeah? Catra pulled away at the same speed, feeling herself get wetter as Adora sort of shakes her head. "...such a bitch." She lived for this game.

Catra laughed again, content just being in Adora's lap like this again. But still, something tells her to keep pushing -see how far you can take her. She draws in close to Adora's ear. "What's that Adora? I can't hear you over the sound of your heavy breathing. Don't worry, baby. You can always come back when you want more."

"Fuck you." So close. Whenever Adora drops the F-bomb, she was close to giving in. Just admit you want me too. She never swore very often, and Adora seldom seemed to mean it -but she meant it right

now, which was exciting as hell. This game was actually getting a bit dangerous.

Catra got a wicked idea. She knew just what would push her over the edge. "You wanna fuck me?" She flicked her tongue over Adora's earlobe and gave a loud, high-pitched whine in her ear -the same one she used to win their first bet, the start of their sexual escapades.

Everything happened so fast. Adora gave a groan, standing from the chair so fast it got knocked over, holding Catra up by her ass. She slammed Catra's back against the wall, pressing her hips forward, making Catra gasp and her insides clench, now desperate for attention -her clit was throbbing. Adora's lips immediately closed over a nipple and began torturing it into oblivion with her tongue - Catra pulling at her hair, whining. God, how the fuck did she do that? Catra could totally get off like this, pinned helpless against the door. Adora placed her knee against the door and let Catra slide her body down on top of her thigh. Catra's hips immediately started grinding, hungry for release. Adora's mouth finally found her lips as a hand took her mouth's place on the other breast. Now Catra was moaning and gasping against Adora's tongue, sounding more and more pathetic by the second. How did this happen?

Adora's hand drifted back up to her neck again, sending a lightning bolt through Catra. Her fingers starting to squeeze lightly. "F-fuck." She missed this -missed her more than she could fathom in this moment. Catra felt her knees buckle as fingers made their way up the side of her thighs. She opened her eyes to find Adora's staring back at her intently. They were confident. They were full of lust. They were...angry? Catra couldn't even think straight -shit, she could barely breathe -she didn't care if Adora was pissy about something. She needed Adora to touch her, right fucking now. The hand grabbed her thong and pulled it hard enough to pop the seam, seemingly with ease. Two fingers traced her opening. Please. Back and forth. Cmon, Adora. Fuck, "Please." she breathed. They slipped in with ease. She felt them curl and press that magic spot -

the spot that only Adora ever found. The pressure built immediately and her eyes rolled back. Adora pulled her fingers out and pushed back in, curling, pressing. Again and again. Slowly -too slowly. Catra's legs started shaking. "Adora, please." Faster. Faster. Until her fingers were just there, rubbing that spot. She was so fucking close. Catra started to claw at Adora's back -it felt so good. She was gonna cum so hard-

Adora pulled her fingers out and stepped back. Catra nearly fell to the floor, quivering. "Whuh? Why the fuck did you stop. You -you cant just-"

Adora cocked an eyebrow and played with the slick on her fingers in front of Catra before licking it off. Shit. That was something she didnt know she needed to see. "Dont worry baby, you can always come back when you want more." Catra's jaw dropped. Adora pulled her close again, kissed her forehead, and slipped out the door, leaving Catra alone in the small silent room.

Silent room. The music had stopped. When had the music stopped?

Conflict of Interest

Chapter Summary

Adora decides what to do about her conflict of interest.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora was incredibly thankful she felt such a strong urge to splash cold water on her face. Had she not gone to the bathroom before re-entering the main lounge, she would have made a fool of herself -her friends never would have let her live it down. Her ponytail was pulled loose and to the side, the back practically out from all Catra's needy hands. She had lipstick smudges around her mouth that clearly weren't her own, and there were two small wet spots on her pants where Catra had been grinding on her -one near her crotch and one just above her knee. She took a dampened towel and wiped them clean. At least her pants were black. Next she tried to get the lipstick off, which mostly worked, and she just threw her hair up again, in a much less 'cute' ponytail this time, as Glimmer would have put it.

The water did make her feel better but didn't do much to lessen the trembles of leftover excitement. She'd almost totally lost it there. Catra almost had her, but not this time. This time, she held the cards. It felt good. Catra hadn't changed a bit, which was both a relief and maddening. That said, she patted herself on the back for being able to walk away like that. The blonde walked out of the bathroom a little bit taller than when she had lumbered in.

Her friends sized her up as she approached the table again, turning away from the darker-skinned women on stage performing what Adora would describe as acrobatics. "You were gone for like thirty minutes! Did you get to talk to her?"

She shrugged. "Kind of? I'll tell you guys about it later."

They stayed and watched the next several dancers. Adora got nervous in the brief moments while the stage was empty, wondering if Catra wouldn't saunter back out to make the next few minutes of her life living hell -in public this time. But she didn't. Seahawk and Mermista got lap dances -quick, normal ones - and then they left. The group split and Bow, Glimmer and Adora went home.

It was a cute little three-bedroom house in a residential area with a white picket fence. Now that she was working in the Fright Zone District, the commute would be much better. It had been worth it though -living with these two had brought some of the best times in her life. Every once in a while, she felt strange about being almost 30 and still living with friends from college, but she definitely did better having other people around -she learned that the hard in undergrad living in a single. Plus, she was saving to be able to buy a house whenever she finally met somebody to settle down with -eventually.

She told herself that the last several years of her love life were so boring because she didn't have any time for a good relationship. She'd dated a few women -none for more than a couple months at a time. She told herself that she was too busy for a relationship, and it was partially true. At twenty-one, fresh out of college with a double major, she enrolled in the police academy to become an officer. She spent the next two years working any and all night and weekend shifts she could so that she had time for classes during the weekdays to earn her Master's. That's how she had met Seahawk - working nights. They'd had a couple shifts that were near-disasters as rookies that sort of cemented their odd friendship.

Speaking of disasters and odd friendship...Adora's mind wandered to the Catra encounter. Car rides were always reserved for loud, off-key singing and good vibes, but the second they got in the house, Adora knew any questions were fair game. She was right.

They'd just barely stepped through the door when..."Soooo." Bow hung the car keys on the hook by the door. "How did your talk go?"

Adora sighed. She knew she was going to have to tell them about it, but still, she procrastinated. "It went nowhere at all. It went."

Glimmer hung her jacket up. "You know you've got lipstick by your ear, right?" She pointed.

Adora's face lit up as she reached to feel for anything. Sure enough, one finger came back with a redd-ish brown tinge. Glimmer gave her the look. "Mm-hm."

Adora let her hands fall to her sides, exasperated. "Apparently the only way I could talk to her was if she gave me a lap dance, and it got...heated." And that was the honest truth. The whole entire encounter had been very, very hot.

They migrated to the living room. "So who is she?"

God. Who was Catra Mendoza? Where to even start. How do you tell people about your best friend but also kind of rival who was also a foster sibling -sometimes -but also your first girlfriend? She was...everything, for so long. She supposed it was best to start with the most important explanatory bits first. "Remember how I said that I had a lot of foster siblings growing up?"

Bow's jaw dropped as he flopped onto the couch. "Shut up. She's one of them?"

"Wait, you and your sister got heated?" Glimmer sat down next to him. "Spill."

"Uh, well, yeah." Adora pinched the bridge of her nose. "Obviously she's not REALLY my sister." Oh boy, the number of times she had to tell herself growing up a mantra she apparently had to keep repeating. "My mom took her for the first time when we were both pretty little. We only had her for a few months that time. Then for a few months at a time once every other year for a couple years. Then when I was about fifteen we had her for just over a year. Then after

that it was back to a couple months at a time until my mom got Gaurdianship."

"Isn't that kind of unusual?"

"Yeah, the case worker always gave preference to my mom because Catra always seemed to be better with us than with anywhere else. My mom never refused -she liked Catra." But she always had to go back home in the end. Apparently her family never committed any crimes so horrible -except for child neglect, of course -that they were seen as truly unfit for childrearing. Sometimes Adora hated the legal system.

"But you two were, you know ...kind of...what, exactly?"

Adora sighed, slightly embarrassed. She still had mixed feelings about it. How could she not after the way things ended? "Well, when we first met, she hated me. She used to pick on me a lot, even though she's a year younger. But I think that was the only way she was capable of expressing feelings at the time. The only way she could get attention was if she was doing bad things." Adora waited for any more questions. Both Bow and Glimmer sat, just watching her. "During her longer stay with us as teenagers, I think she kind of finally figured out that she didn't have to act out. She still teased me a lot but it was different." It was a lot of unexplored and naive sexual tension. "She started to actually open up and we got really close that year. I think we realized it was just that we had...a thing."

"Did your mom know?"

Adora nodded. "I think she had suspicions for a while. But by the end, that last time Catra was with us, I think she overheard some arguments that made it pretty clear something was going on." A blush spread over her cheeks, "...if she didn't overhear other stuff, that is."

"A-do-ra!"

"You fiend!"

"In your mother's household?"

"She's never asked me about it, so I don't know what she thought, if anything. That was all before I came out, which also didn't seem to surprise her."

Bow nodded. "But it's good that she was so supportive."

"Wait, so if Catra was so great with you guys, then why did she leave?"

Adora bit her lip. "Great question. Hell if I know." "Because she's self destructive and insecure? Because running away is all she knows how to do when things get hard? I never really had the chance to talk to her about it. She never responded to my calls or messages."

"Maybe she got a new phone? Or didn't have her phone if her life has really always been so touch-and-go."

Adora raised her eyebrows and let out a dry laugh. "They're on read, so"…

"Oh."

"Yeah."

"So...tonight was the first time you'd seen her in how long?"

"About seven years. Right after I got my associate's. She just took off one day." Seven years and two and half months -if somebody were to count. Which Adora had done many times.

"Wow."

"Yeah, damn."

She continued chewing on her lip as time passed, all of them thinking to themselves. "So are you going to see her again?" Adora shrugged. Who knew. Fate always did seem to bring them together - just on opposite sides of life. The old adage did say opposites attract. Who knew the proverbial magnets they'd apparently swallowed would have lasted so long? Bow and Glimmer eventually went off to their room. Adora sat there on the couch debating whether or not she was glad she ran into Catra tonight. She looked at her phone for a long time before going to messages and typing in C-A-T. Catra's contact popped up with a little heart next to her name. She stared at it with an ache in her chest. I should have changed her name. She breathed a heavy sigh. What's the point? To talk to her... She never did know when to quit. Adora started typing.

It was nice to see

Delete.

I hope you're doing well

Delete.

I hope you learned your less

Delete.

You've never responded to my messages, but

Delete. She probably wouldn't answer this one either…

Is this even still your phone number?

Send.

Delivered. Read: 11:46

Wow. Okay.

Thanks for clearing that up.

Delivered. Read: 11:47

She put her phone down and tried to go sleep, now feeling deflated. It was already going to be a restless night for her , tossing and turning. She always slept terribly before something big, even if she wasn't upset about something the night before. Upset? Was she upset? Guh. She didn't know . She had a LOT of feelings about their encounter, but she wanted them to just go away for the night. Tomorrow -er...maybe by now it was already today, she hadn't looked at the time in a while -was her first official day as a detective. She couldn't really afford to not be on her A-game. She twisted of the covers, her leg going in and out, unable to choose whether to be too hot or too cold. Finally, she drifted off.

It was like she blinked and was wide awake again though. She looked at her phone. 6:37. I should try to go back to sleep...She woke up every ten minutes for the last hour before her alarm. Might as well get up now…

The blonde took care in putting on her new dark grey suit today . She'd had it tailored to accommodate her side arm and everything - even got orthotics for her dress shoes so that they would still be comfortable if she ever needed to chase down a perp. You're gonna help people today. She never wore much makeup, just a bit of mascara. She already got enough sexist comments about her work as it was. What to do with her hair today...up or up? Up. Glimmer showed her how to do a braid at the top -that would look good with this.

When she walked through the precinct doors, people were clapping her on the shoulder, congratulating her. They'd smile and say "Detective." Angella was already waiting in the conference room to brief her. There were two other people waiting as well, who stopped to appraise her as she entered. One was a hardened-looking woman who had to have been at least six-foot, and the other was a man with cropped hair that probably served in the military.

"Ah, Detective Ether ." She smiled at the word too. She had seemed almost eager to promote Adora to detective. "Right on time, as always." She was a proud, intelligent woman. Adora only hoped that she could one day be as gutsy as her.

"Good morning, Chief."

Angella motioned to the other two. "This is special Detective Thornbrush, she' s with the DEA." The taller woman grasped Adora' s hand firmly.

"Please, call me Huntara." Wow, what a name. The woman smiled, seeming to read her mind. "I know what you're thinking. My parents were dead set on having a boy named Hunter."

Adora nodded, "Ahh, I see."

"And this is Agent King. He' s part of the Anti-Trafficking Coordination Team for the FBI"

He gave a warm smile, but Adora could tell by his eyes that he'd seen some shit. "Micah."

"Adora." They all sat down. Adora felt somewhat uneasy . The DEA and FBI on a first case? What the hell did I get myself into? You can handle it. You're good at what you do.

She tossed a file on the table in front of Adora. She grabbed it. "This city has its fair share of circles of sins, like any other." She seemed to just be talking to Adora. "That being said, it has been revealed that

our circles likely coincide, and that's why the three of you have been brought together on this." She waved her hand. "King, Thornbrush, would you care to explain your respective interests?"

Micah, turned towards Adora. "Sure, sure. Now, we've known the central eastside was part of a larger trafficking circuit for a couple decades -namely bringing people in and exporting them. But it's all very well covered so we've never been able to nail down exact locations or big name players -only a couple renegades here and there."

He exchanged glances with Huntara. Adora was beginning to think she was walking into an already well-established project. "Which is why we've been in contact with the DEA, hoping they might be able to dig something up." That made sense. The ones who weren't coerced into it were otherwise forced using drug addiction as motivation -they often had common connections.

Huntara cleared her throat. "And we recently got a lead, somebody in the middle eschelans of the opium ring, who was willing to talk in exchange for protection. They told us that the ones traf ficking are the same people supplying local drug lords around the city."

Adora was trying to put the pieces together. "I'm sorry, I don't quite understand why I've been assigned to this team."

Huntara gave a deep rumbling laugh. "Because you brought Diego in, kid."

Click. Wait...what? "Diego was your lead?" He was a paranoid, small-time drug lord who had somehow been able to avoid arrest for years, supplying both sides of the city's largest gangs with laced drugs and ammunition from a basement. He didn't exactly seem like the talking type...

"No, no. Of course not. That crazy bastard's been nothing but trouble. No. But one of his people came in the EXODA Y -said they didn't have to be so afraid of getting of fed with him locked up. As

long as they still did their job for whoever was next in line, they would be willing to give us information." For a price, of course.

Adora bit her lip. "So they've agreed to be an informant." The others nodded. "That didn't seem right. Diego was so hard to find because they couldn't get anyone to talk. Sure, it was possible that people were scared to come out, but those people protected their own just with just as much resolution as when they mercilessly killed each other to keep things hush-hush. Talkers talk -everyone else stays locked up tight. None of the people working around Diego struck Adora as talkers…

"How much?"

"Starting, three-hundred fifty-K."

Adora opened the folder and looked at the file. "This them?"

Huntara scoffed. "Yeah. Goes by the name of Double T rouble'. Can you imagine?"

The person's gender was ambiguous, leaning towards effeminate expression -they wore a lot of makeup. Adora didn't recognize this person. They had questioned A LOT of people -nobody mentioned this person. So either they were a lot higher up the food chain than they let on -which would indeed be alarming, it could only have been out of self-interest that they walked right into the police station, which would also be alarming. Something was going on -Adora could feel it in her gut.

"They identified The Gentlemen's Club on the East side as a crucial facilitator."

Adora's heart stopped. "The strip club?"

"Uh-huh."

The strip club she went to go visit just last night. The strip club where she saw Catra. The strip club Catra works at. "You okay, kid? You look kinda pale." She did feel a little bit in shock, like she could just wake up any minute. Or vomit. One of the two.

She wiped a hand down her face. "Yeah. Yeah, I just, uh...I was there last night." Her friends had begged her for three days prior - 'it's gonna be so fun', they said. 'It's an actual nice strip club'. 'It's clean', they said.

Huntara laughed. "The dancers are great, aren't they? Go out to celebrate the pay raise?" Adora was surprised. Shouldn't it be bad that she was there? The others didn't seem nearly as appalled as she was.

Adora smiled meekly. "Yeah."

"It's too bad. According to our lead, a lot of those women end up getting scoped and trafficked."

Adora's heart came back to life, beating hard and fast. Catra. "I...seemed clean." She heard Catra's voice in her head. 'Unfortunately, that's not on the menu.' Catra didn't know she was with the police, did she? If she was being forced to have sex with people for extra cash, wouldn't she have done it? Adora was otherwise 'safe' for her. She totally would have done it, right?

"We haven't had reason to suspect it before. Whatever they're doing, it's not on site. But now that we've got reason to believe Diego was getting his supply from them, we can get a warrant for their surveillance footage to try and place him there."

"Give me today." They all looked back at her. "Let me go in with a cam. I'll try to ply one of the girls with a bit of money and see what's what. If we're lucky, she does and we have clear-cut evidence that the place is dirty." Her stomach churned at the thought. If she doesn't, tomorrow we'll have to do this the hard way. But the second

we ask for their tapes, theyll work twice as hard to put on a smile and cover their tracks."

Angella smiled as if she'd been hoping for Adora to say that.

Huntara was sitting back in her chair, appraising her. "Spoken like not a rookie. Ill set us up to meet with Double T rouble in the next few days, see if they've been able to dig anything else up."

"I'll read through this and maybe comb back through Diego' s file and see if there's anything else we can dig up on the people who work at the club."

They hashed out a few more details before exchanging phone numbers. "May Ibe dismissed?"

Angella gave a nod. She was out of her seat and halfway through the doorway by the time she'd verbalized "yes." Before the door closed, she heard King say , "Gets right on it, doesnt she?"

"Oh, yes. She's." The door closed and she was gone.

She had only one thing on her mind: Catra. Of course. Of course she would have gotten herself involved with some sort of criminal organization. Did she even know she was in trouble? W as she in denial? Adora couldn't tell if what she hoped more for: that Catra was higher up or lower down on the food chain. On the one hand, she was potentially subjected to violence and forced drug use. On the other hand, she was likely part of the reason other women were subjected to those things. Either way , she was trapped and she needed out.

Adora moved towards her desk, passing people without seeing them. She unlocked the file cabinet drawer and pulled out a thick file -one of the few things inside the drawer that would someday maybe look like Mara's. t was a copy of all of the paperwork compiled by the now-retired senior detective. She was the person actually working the case -Adora had just been part of the squad who finally

made a rush to grab Diego. Sure, she contributed -her and Mara were very similar. Mara trusted her, talking with her frequently about the case. They used to shoot ideas back and forth, trying to problem solve together. Adora knew Mara's word to the chief was part of the reason she got promoted. She couldn't help but wonder if she would really ever be up to the job -she certainly wasn't a replacement for Mara.

Names, photos, dates. She sifted through the papers again. No sign of a Double Trouble' anywhere. Not even a passing mention. The final tip-off came from a neighbor who said she thought her neighbor was 'cooking drugs'-Sherry Weaver. They moved in on a regular bust only to find that it was Diego himself. He didn't say a single word until they got outside, then he erupted into furious curses and laughter. 'That old bitch, she finally fucking did it -she got me good' was the only intelligible sentence. When he got in the car, he just stopped, locked eyes with his neighbor and made threatening gestures. It was eerie, to say the least. Adora was thankful that it didn't seem to rattle the woman

She read and stared at the photos until her eyes hurt. She should probably eat lunch. She could just take this stuff home...she needed to be ready to go back to the club tonight anyways. She should probably also try to get in touch with Catra before...She pulled her phone out, thinking. If Catra had been at work till the club closed, she probably slept in until who knows when.

Call me when you wake up

Delivered.

On the very fast drive home, Adora was suddenly hit with the realization that if anyone found out her history with Catra, she'd be removed from the case for a conflict of interest. Maybe that would be better? Catra would be a liability to her -she always was. But she also couldn't just do nothing. Either way, she was going to get Catra out of there...might as well take down a trafficking ring while I'm at it, right? She made up her mind.

Tension had crept into her muscles throughout the day, laying roots to stay until this was all over. Adora parked and slammed the door just a bit too hard, mentally apologizing to her car, sighing. This was going to be a long night.

Chapter End Notes

I'm earlier than I said I'd be in the comments :) There should be another update by next Friday for sure. After that, I have no idea.

I should note: I have NO insights as to what it's like to be involved in law enforcement or really any of the hard stuff talked about in this story. I apologize for any inaccuracies. I'm just a sap for some anxty Catradora.

Keep an eye on my IG (@help_ive_caught_shera_fever) as you never know when I'll do a more realistic sketch of the characters from my AU's.

The Colors of You

Chapter Summary

> Catra's been standing in deep water for years. Finally, the sharks have come.

Chapter Notes

> Honestly the way this story is developing is surprising even me.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Every second she stood there -mouth open, staring at the door, feeling horribly empty -more and more of her built excitement converted to anger. The AUDACITY. How dare she say that and just fucking walk away!She wanted to scream. She wanted to throw things and cry and find some way to get back at her -to make her so goddamn crazy she grovelled on her knees. She fucking hated losing the game. That game was stupid.

She felt like her ears were blowing steam all the way back to the dressing room, but it didn't resolve the pressure in her abdomen. She cleaned herself up again and changed outfits. Her whole night was ruined. Goddamn fucking Adora Ether. She comes in here and colors music for me again, and then walks out. The music had felt grey for song long -monotonous, muted tones even on the best days. But now, now it was a vibrant, hot red.

The next three poor schmucks she danced for felt her wrath -her dances were like hate-fucking. Two nearly climaxed, which she denied them -cold and hard -but it gave her no satisfaction. If only it had been Adora. That would have made her feel better, to watch her squirm and try to hold back. She walked back to the dressing room to find Stace and Rob talking in hushed tones by her mirror, looking like a married couple squabbling in front of the kids. They really could have been good for each other if they weren't so stubborn and

mistrustingand running a drug cartel. They certainly made excellent business partners. Catra was sure they'd slept together many times before at the beginning. They stopped talking abruptly when they noticed her coming.

Rob opened his arms, smiling a bit too wide. "Catrina, babyyyy . You're doing fabulous tonight." Something was up.

Catra rolled her eyes. "What do you want?"

"Right, listen. I've got a client here -no, no, no, an INVESTOR OR, if you will -a very important guy. He really loved your last routine and he wants a private session of that routine. Can you do that?"

Catra blinked at him. "He wants a full routine?"

"No, he wants THAT routine."

What the hell. "Like I even remember that routine. I told you, that was just fun. That wasn't a routine. I couldn't recreate that if I wanted to -which I don't. Besides, I would need the whole fucking stage to do that over again. The private rooms are way too small."

Rob gave a nervous laugh. "That's weird. Rob was never nervous. Rob would walk and talk like he owned the world even if he lived out of a cardboard box under a bridge. His life motto was, "talk out your ass and somehow you'll come out fine." He was the sleek car salesman that never sold cars but still somehow made money. "Well it's-it won't be in a private room, it's going to be on the stage. We're going to give him a series of private routines -his eyes only - tomorrow early in the evening. We'll open to the public afterwards."

The fuck? Who was this guy that Rob was willing to be "closed to the public". And how much money did he pay? They had clients come in all the time looking for girls. But that's why Rob had "auditions". The regulars were always safe -that's what Stace told her when she first found the Club. Catra was a dancer -not a prostitute. She'd received a lot of interest over the years, but he had never even considered

losing her. Besides, Stace would never let him do it. She was their favorite...That still doesn't change the fact that it wasn't a routine. I was just dancing."

Rob yelled. "Well you're gonna fuckin' do it again!" Then his thin veneer of pleasantness returned. What the fuck is he so worked up about? "I mean, you're gonna have to try , sweetheart. Okay?"

She glanced at Stace, who wasn't saying anything. She looked somewhat concerned and...almost sad. "I'm gonna let you go home early tonight so you can get some rest and come back fresh tomorrow so you can dance your little heart out, yeah? In the morning, I want you to get your nails done, the hair -kit 'n caboodle - I'll pay for it, whatever . Alright?" He clapped his hands together . Normally , Catra found it kind of endearing, but at the moment she was irked and uneasy. "Be here tomorrow no later than four o'clock. We'll go over details then."

With that, he turned and walked out the door. Stace brushed some hair away from her face. "Listen, baby . Listen good." There was a bit of softness in her voice that wasn't always there -only with Catra, but still rare. Something was very wrong. "Hordak is a mean, nasty sonofabitch with a lot of blood on his hands. Do what he says and none of it will be yours."

A pit formed in her stomach. Hordak. As in THE Hordak, a.k.a, the man on the throne? HE was the client? Catra nodded meekly , coming to grips with her situation. "Your nails are fine -they look great. You might wanna get your hair done though. You're getting some split ends. She tipped Catra's chin with her fingers. "Head up, hon. Everything is gonna be fine." There was determination in the older woman's eyes. Stace had been the closest thing to a mother she'd ever had. Well...second closest. She wouldn't let anything bad happen, right? "You're on in ten, then go home for the night."

She collected herself enough to give one final routine on stage. Already the colors had begun to drain from the music again. Now all that remained was faint grey-blues that came along with uncertainty -

not that the audience could tell. They were all enjoying their drinks and the flash of the show nonetheless. She went back to the dressing room to collect her laundry and money before heading out for the night. On the drive back to her apartment, she remembered the first time she had ever danced for anyone -how vivid the experience was.

She was five and a half. She'd taken Adora' s walkman from their room and was dancing behind the big garden shrub. There were lots of good places to hide here at this mansion house, but this was her favorite. Okay, it wasn't a real mansion -but it was certainly bigger and more extravagant than her parents' house would ever be. The closest thing they had to flowers were dandelions. But here, listening to the music, dancing between the raised beds and rows of flowering bushes, there were purples and yellows and greens patterned to the beat of the music and she just couldn't help herself. She closed her eyes and got lost in the colors she heard. When she opened them again, Adora had her head peeked out from around the edge of the shrub, blue eyes watching carefully. Catra was horribly embarrassed, feeling trapped, and she just knew she was going to be in trouble for taking something that wasn't hers. Nothing was ever hers.

Adora shyly came out from behind the shrub. "I didn't mean to spy . You're a great dancer ."Catra was mad. She didn't know why she was mad, but she was. She ripped off the headphones quickly . "Oh, no. You don't have to stop. Y ou can use my music player if you want."

Catra threw it on the ground -hard. For some reason, that seemed to take the edge off. The back popped of f and some small screws too. There seemed to be a big crack on the side. Adora' s shoulders slumped and she walked over to pick it up. She looked like she was about to cry.

"It' s..it'. s broken. It' s ruined. All your fault."..it' s okay. I know you didn't mean to."She started reaching to pick up the small pieces that had scattered. "I..I think I can fix it."

The words infuriated Catra. The only thing she could think to do was shove the bigger blonde girl as hard as she could. With a surprised whimper, Adora fell back, dropping the walkman again, scraping her knee against the edge of a plantar box. Stealing one last look down at her before going inside to hide from punishment was a mistake. Adora didn't even have to open her mouth -her teary eyes spoke for her: Why did you do that?

Catra hid under the bed -her safe place, thinking about it. She didn't know why she did it. She was just too angry to do anything else, or to not do it. And she waited. She waited for somebody to come and scream at her, to throw her into a closet and lock the door, but it never happened. She eventually crept out, down the hallway to the end of the staircase where she heard Adora and her mother talking.

"-got to be more careful honey ."

"I know . I'm sorry ."

"Well, we can get you a new one."

There was silence, except for a hiss of breath. Catra poked her head around just enough to see that Adora was having her boo-boo treated. There was a lot of red on that white cloth. She returned to safety behind the wall. "Where is Catra?"

Here it comes. "I don't know . She doesn't like me."Adora sounded sad.

"It's just going to take her some time to warm up to us. She'll come around."

More silence. Then: "Mama... can Catra have dance class?"

Catra felt her eyes widen. Dance class? Her? Perhaps. "We don't know how long she'll be with us"…

"But she' s really good. Ithink she would like it."She waited, digging her fingers into her legs. "Y ou said to be fair and it's not fair if Iget to have soccer but she cant have dance."

"Y oure right, that just wouldnt be fair . Iguess well have to find her a dance class."

And they did. She started with ballet and contemporary. Because of all the back and forth, she was never in enough consecutive classes to be in a formal recital until she was a teenager, but they would have their own recitals for some neighbors and family friends at the house. Adora would clear the furniture away, leaving the smooth hardwood floor open, and she would always put her chair in the very front. Even though Catra was so horrible to her for the first few years until she felt secure there, Adora was always her biggest fan -her biggest supporter. Whenever she was there, watching so captivated, Catra felt like she was giving a real recital, even if it was just the two of them. Catra loved to dance, but she soon found that she loved to dance for Adora even more.

t wasnt until middle school that Catra discovered her proclivity for hip-hop dancing and her naturally -less angry -playful nature. By the time she got to high school, her dance prowess gained her new popularity, mostly with boys, which Adora hated. When she moved, she could be aggressive and sensual and confident and fun, and best of all, she could do things that would make Adora's cheeks turn so red that they matched her Christmas sweater. She always looked forward to when her parents would break probation again so that she could go live with the Ethers.

Catra parked the car. She had almost forgotten some of that. After all, it was practically a lifetime ago. But she would never forget that look in Adora's eyes - Why did you do that?t was the same look she gave when Catra pushed her down the stairs when she found out she had to leave the second time;the same as when Catra drunkenly kissed somebody else at a party;the same before Catra ran away that last night.

"I don't understand, where is this coming from?"

"It doesn't matter where it's fucking coming from! I won't go back. I'm not staying here without you. I just need OUT."

"Then don't stay! Come with me!"

Catra scoffed. "What, and piggy-back off of you my whole life like everyone expects? No thanks."

"Catra." Adora's voice broke, tears brimming, making her eyes actual pools of blue. "I think... I think I'm in love with you."

She felt the knife twist in her chest as the walls started to squeeze tighter. "Sounds like a personal problem." She knew better. She knew not to look, but Adora was blocking her way to the door and she met her gaze - just for a second. The tears had started spilling down her cheeks. She might as well have been on the ground with a scraped knee - her eyes held the pain of a wounded child. But Catra's emotional vocabulary had vastly expanded since childhood - since learning from this family. Now she knew that look didn't really mean Why did you do that? It really meant, What have I done to deserve this? Catra still didn't have the answer. There was no good answer. Nothing. You've done nothing.

She walked away and never looked back. That was a different time in her life and she really did make a new one for herself - a better one. She drove the car of her dreams, lived in a penthouse apartment with a view of the city, and she had a job she was good at that made her enough money to afford it all. What else could a girl ask for? She checked her phone. Only one message. Scorpia, the bartender:

How about that drink this week?

Catra replied: Can't. Sorry.

Scorpia was nice, but Catra didn't feel anything. In fact, she hadn't felt anything for somebody since she left. Well, that's not true. Tonight she felt a lot of things. So it was Adora. Maybe she wasn't over Adora yet. Scratch that, she was most definitely NOT over Adora yet.

Her phone buzzed again. Sister-wife' popped up on her screen and Catra's heart stopped. She hadn't seen that contact come up in several years.

Is this even still your phone number?

She knew that she knew words, but she couldn't for the life of her come up with any. She just kept staring after the screen, trying to form a sentence, for about a minute. Buzz

Thanks for clearing that up.

What the hell? Oh...shit. My read-receipts are on. Well fine. If she's not even going to give me a chance. There was a little voice in the back of her head, calling her a bitch. Catra could still see all the previous messages from Adora from those first few years. She went to the beginning and scrolled through them, thankful she'd deleted the really early ones. She knew those would break her heart all over again.

Please call me back.

Catra, please.

At least text me and let me know you're okay.

Goodnight.

Why wont you answer me?

Ireally miss you.

After the first year, the messages were sparse and expressed less emotion, except random drunk texts. Catra had received a few calls like that from her too -voicemails where Adora was trying to have conversations about 'unfinished business'.

Happy Birthday.

Happy Thanksgiving.

i wushicouls see yoi dance one more time
Im sorry . Ireally dont remember writing that. t wont happen again.

Merry Christmas.

Happy New Years.

Happy Easter.

id gibe anything time hokd you right noq
Imiss th way your smell

Happy Birthday.

i Sdtirol think you loved ne back but now Idont know
But mayne thats okau
Loving you was worth it
Yoll just be my on that got away

Happy eaw Y ears.

Yeah. And youll always be mine. t was a bitter thought. She tossed her phone on the couch and went to the fridge. She pulled out a container of leftovers and a bottle of wine. She poured what was left of the bottle into a large glass and placed the food container in the microwave, thinking about what the hell she was going to do tomorrow. After dinner, she did laundry, and got ready for bed, trying to distract herself a little with instagram and twitter, scrolling for what could have been eternity before finally putting her phone down.

She slept restlessly, which meant she needed to give herself a few extra hours of beauty rest for good measure, even though that always seemed to make her feel groggy. She finally got out of bed around 10:30. She switched her laundry and made coffee and a small breakfast -neither of which settled well. She was going to perform for Hordak today, who no doubt was interested in buying her out from under Rob. N, just relax. Dont even go there. t' s never gonna happen.

Catra took care in doing her makeup, accenting her eyes with a bit more color than she usually would. Fuck going to a hair salon, she was way better than doing her own hair. Besides, today she wanted it straight -she wasnt going to pay somebody money to do that. Then she mentally rehearsed, trying to vaguely remember what she had done. Center stage, front, back to center, pole, front, and finish with the pole again. She could adlib that.

She checked herself over a few times in the mirror, lacking her usual confidence. Maybe she needed a little boost today? Nah, gotta take it easy with that shit. Dont make yourself an easy target.

Rob was looking nervous again when she got to the club, looking her up and down. "I thought you said you were gonna wear the red outfit?"

What? No, I-'

He threw up his hands. "Nevermind, nevermind. Y ou look good. You look great."

"I almost didnt put any ef fort in. Sounds like this guy isnt worth-"

Rob grabbed her arm, stopping them both. "No, you're gonna go out there and dance that magnificent ass off, and you're gonna put on a fuckin' show ." He was deathly serious. "T rust me. t' s for your own good. Dont do it for me, y understand? Do it for yourself. Idont care how you do it, but you do it. You make him sweat sitting there just watching you. Whatever you did that night, we both need you to do it again." He waited and watched for her to give a nod, then released her and they continued on their way.

They walked into the dressing room where two of the other newer girls were waiting, also looking nervous. Poor things, they had no idea what this was all about. They thought they were being scouted by some bigshot talent' scout. "Alright ladies!" He clapped his hands. "Here' s the order: Sheana, Hailey, Catrina. Make sure you're all warmed up and ready to go in 30. Go ahead and grease yourselves

up a little beforehand if you want but no glitter tonight, okay? Great. I'll see you out there."

Great pep talk, boss. Even though the performances were each about 15 minutes, it felt like Catra blinked and it was her turn. As she walked towards the stage, Stace nodded at her. "Remember what I said." Catra nodded back. She stepped out into the stage and there he was. A tall man in a pinstriped suit, a cane resting under ringed fingers and a heavy watch. Very old fashioned. He had two other large men on either side holding firearms. The music starts and Catra panics for a fraction of a second -this performance was going to be nothing like the one he saw before -she didn't feel anything. Everything was grey and white -no colors. She needed to fix it, fast.

She closed her eyes and imagined she was nineteen again, dancing around that viewpoint under the stars for Adora -remembering how closely she watched, eager to touch at the soonest given chance in the backseat of that car. There were colors -muted by the passage of time and a lack of real stimulation, but they were faintly there. But whenever she opened her eyes to look at him, they disappeared and she knew her eyes betrayed that. This was not the performance he wanted. The song ended. She bowed, breathing slightly heavily .

"Girl." Hordak's voice was like gravel and sand. "Come here." She glanced at Rob, who motioned for her to go. She complied, stepping carefully off the stage. He stood and stepped closer, towering over her. Up close, she could tell that the end of his cane was a small pistol -some kind of revolver, probably loaded. She straightened her posture as his eyes appraised her, feeling increasingly more irked. He wreaked of cigars and dirty money. Behind them, the stage lights dimmed enough that she could see the expression on his face, watching her like a fighting dog eyes a piece of meat. Easy Fido.

"Hm." He brought the tip of his cane up to the underside of her breast. Without thinking, a hand moved it away. Even though she caught herself halfway, turning it from a slap to a gentle push, she could still tell she'd made a mistake. Whereas before his face held some manner of amusement, now it was very cold. Ice cold.

"This was not the performance I requested." He looked at her expectantly. "Why?"

"W -"

"Why is it that you keep your eyes closed when you dance for me? I should see passion and desire in you. You should be dancing like you're desperate for my cock. When you look at me, it should be as if you are asking me, begging me." Oh you are so barking up the wrong tree. He just stared down at her , expectantly but already somehow already disappointed. "Well? Go on. Beg."

Fuck you. She had barely opened her mouth, taking the breath to form the words -suck your own fucking cock -when his hand made contact. He struck hard enough to knock her off balance -harder than her step-father ever hit her. His thick gold signet ring crushing her lip against her teeth and splitting it. She still heard the sound echoing in the almost empty room as she grabbed her face, tears stinging her eyes. She tasted blood. Fuck it.

Catra turned slowly, moving her hair out of her face, getting her footing again. She spat on him. "You hit like a bitch."

His cane blurred and struck her thigh hard enough to make her leg buckle. It wasn't a whip -she knew what that felt like. It was like he was trying to make it go through her, like the swing of a bat. Okay, FUCKING HURT -understatement of the century . A couple more tears fell from the pain but she wouldn't let him see them. He pulled a handkerchief from his pocket and wiped the bloody spit from his face. "Robert. I'm afraid you were mistaken. This one is NOT a good dancer -certainly no good for your business. I will take her off your hands. A beautiful mouth like hers should be put to work, don't you think?"

Catra was thinking of all the things she was going to say to him, but she knew if she opened her mouth, a cry of pain would come out. It was like the initial strike was painless, but every second after, her body got more and more awake to reality and was not shy in telling

her that somebody hit her leg really fucking hard. Hordak bent over just slightly. "I do like your spirit. But I'm afraid I will have to break it. Robert. Come. Let us discuss the arrangement." And then he was gone.

Then she could finally let go. "GOD-DAMMIT. Fucking hell." She breathed in, cupping her jaw, which was also now starting to kind of throb. "Jesus."

Stace ran over to her side, helping her stagger up. The thigh muscles on that side really didn't want to work. "Just couldn't keep your mouth shut, could you? Just like me."

Catra laughed, which hurt her bleeding lip. "You were right. I didn't do what he said and now my blood is on his hand."

Stace cupped her cheek, gauging how bad the cut was. "...not gonna need stitches." She actually had tears in her eyes. Catra had never seen her cry before. "Christ's sake, Catra. Someday the fight in you is gonna be real trouble."

"Stace, you know the fight in me is all I have." The other woman nodded, putting her other arm around Catra. They cried together for a few minutes.

"What do I do, Stace?"

"Well, we're gonna start by getting you cleaned up, baby."

They hobbled to a private room in the back where she could lay down for a while on a yoga mat. Stace brought a gin and tonic -a stiff one. She rested the cold glass gently on her lip. "I'll be back. I'll get a towel for that."

Catra lay there feeling small with no way to ease the stinging pains. Stace came back quickly with a small hand towel. "Hordak offered something he couldn't refuse, but I bought us a little bit of time. You've got a couple days to figure out where you're gonna go."

"Where I'm gonna go?"

"We've gotta get you out of town hon."

Jesus. "That bad, huh?"

"I'll just be damned if I'm gonna watch him hand you over ." She shook her head.

Catra felt a couple more tears blur her vision but she didn't let gravity take them. "I want you to lay low here for a while. I'll come back and get you when they're gone." She returned once more with Catra's phone and some regular clothes to change into. Her phone buzzed. Sister-wife.

Call me when you wake up

Ugh. She really could not deal with Adora right now. Still...she wondered what it might be like to just talk to her again, to catch up. By the time Stace finally came back, she may as well have wasted the time talking with Adora. She spent at least three hours in that dim room, thinking of where she would go. She always wanted to go to Tokyo. Maybe Paris? She scrolled through Instagram and Facebook -feed after feed. Rob must have offered to let them stay and watch the regular show too. How hospitable of you, Rob. Now she was getting angry. He was really about to sell her off? To some gorilla no less? So much for being the fucking favorite.

"The door opened and Stace came back. "They're gone but your friend came back. "The blonde. She came back with her friends for a bit. She asked for you again, but when I told her you weren't here she asked for a dance from somebody else." She did WHAT? She asked for a lap dance from somebody else? "After they left, I saw her out back checking out your car." Busted. "She some kind of stalker?"

Catra laughed, imagining the look on Adora's face when she saw the car. She remembered when she first announced she would have it. "They were sitting on top of the roof, sunbathing. "I may not live the

life of luxury most of the time now, but just you wait. Someday I'm going to have a place with a view better than this, and I'll drive a bright red Porsch with a license plate that says bad bitch', only the first B will be a 3."And she did it.

"She' s a friend."

"Y ou trust her?"

The question was unexpected. Catra thought about it for a moment. Yes, even now. "With my life."

"Good. Go stay with her ."

"Y eah, right."

"I mean it. Rob knows where you live. He doesn't know where this random girl is."She lay there thinking about it. W as she really going to run away?Absolutely . I'll think about it."

"W ell, why don't you go home for now and I'll call you tomorrow . It may be from an unrecognized number ."

Catra nodded, sitting up slowly and letting her body adjust to being vertical again. When she finally stood, her leg still hurt like a bitch - like the muscles were locked up or something. "Y ou okay to drive?"

Catra nodded, "Y eah. I'll be fine. Thanks again, Stace."She kind of hobbled down the hallway, getting a bit better each step, trying to hide the gimp. She had wiped most all of the blood away from her lip, but it was still kind of swollen. The other girls were too busy excitedly talking about something to notice her.

"...Right?I mean, Ifeel like we've all had plenty of guys of fer that before but never a woman."Catra rolled her eyes. Carmine was always talking about somebody asking to hook up with her. "I'm not into girls or anything but she was just so...yummy ."

"I can't believe she wanted to pay you."

Catra couldn't help it. "Oh shit, Carmine. We're strippers. People offer to pay us money to do things."

"Duh, not prostitutes." Most of us, anyways...

"So anyways. She had on this sexy black suit." A woman in a suit? "...and it's not like she was masculine, per say. Like, yes she had really strong features but she wasn't butch or anything. And she had these amazing blue eyes that just went right through me, you know?"

Catra heard Stace's voice: 'your friend was here'. Fucking Carmine!? Carmine gave Adora a lap dance? Adora offered to pay Carmine extra, for what? To fuck her? Oh way. Oh fucking way. "...and the way she touched me just really kind of...got me going. Idunno. It was hot. Maybe I'm into women? I was sad that I had to turn her down..."

Catra turned around. "Tall? Blonde hair in a ponytail?"

Carmine shrugged and nodded. "Y up!"

GOD-

Could this day get any worse? She definitely needed a bump when she got home. She grabbed her makeup bag and headed for the car, not giving a shit who saw her gimp. She was too pissed off. What the hell kind of game was Adora playing at? Coming and getting a dance from another girl. Trying to sleep with her! You know what? She could sleep with whoever the fuck she wanted. It didn't matter. Whatever. It's fine.

She screeched to a halt in the one open curb-side parking space on the block, and took the elevator upstairs, thanking whoever invented them. She wouldn't have made it up the stairs. The first thing she did after locking the door was cut herself a line. Then she poured a double shot of whiskey and waited for the blow to lift her up. The change was gradual, partially because the sensitivity also made her more aware of the pulse in her lip and the ache in her thigh muscles. But it did make her feel more confident -happier. She was going to

be fine. She'd get out of this. Just as long as she kept things simple. Just up and leave. She'd done it before and she could do it again. Simple.

There was a knock on the door. For a moment, it almost sobered her. She walked slowly over to the door to look through the peephole. And hello complication.

It was Adora. How the fuck-

"Catra. I know you're in there." Maybe she really is a stalker. "You can either open the door and let me in, or I'll break in." Whoa. Okay. That was new. Was she drunk? Adora would never do something like that. No, she wasn't drunk. Catra contemplated her option for a minute. Adora looked really, really serious, which meant she was either about to have a really bad night, or have a really bad night and need to owe her landlord fifteen hundred to put in a new door.

She knocked again, harder. "I'm serious. I know you're there."

Catra unlocked and cracked it, turning her face so Adora wouldn't see her lip. "Why are you here."

"Open the door."

"Tell me why you're here." This was really killing her mood.

"Open the fucking door, Catra."

Jesus. She used the F word. Okay. She walked away from the door, towards the kitchen to grab the counter and her drink. She was going to need another one of these. She heard Adora step in behind her and close the door.

"Catra I need to talk to you."

"How do you know where I live?"

Adora was coming closer. How could she look natural and hide her lip at the same time? "I had somebody trace your license plate. Nice car."

Catra had to fight the smile so she wouldn't open her lip again. Wait...traced her plate? "What're you, some kinda cop?"

As Adora stepped into view, Catra took the shot and held the glass to her lips, leaning over the counter trying to look, thoughtful rather than beaten up. Adora was still very solemn. And why the hell did she look so good? She was in a black pair of fitted slacks and jacket over a white button down and an emerald green tie. Catra got the strongest urge to throw the glass at her as she imagined Carmine dancing on top of her, pulling the tie loose.

"Yeah. I am." Adora pulled the coat of her jacket aside, revealing a holstered pistol. Catra's almost-smile fell. What. Really? She was really a fucking cop? Of course she would be. Miss do-good. "If anyone finds out I'm here, I could lose my job." Catra's eyes appraised Adora with a new lens. She was staring so hard, that the glass lost contact with her lips. "What happened to your lip?"

Adora stepped forward, colored with alarm and...anger. "Who did this?" Definitely anger. She looked just like the time Catra picked a fight with a much larger girl in high school and lost.

"Doesn't matter. It's never gonna happen again." She put the glass down and started to fill it again.

"Yes. It does matter. It matters to me." Yeah, right.

"How nice." She went to pick up the shot, but Adora grabbed her hand. Their eyes met.

"Are you...are you high...right now?" Disappointment. Anger. Sadness. Hurt. Catra despised how transparent Adora's eyes were.

"Fuck off." Why are you even here?

"No. Are you fucking high right now? Answer me."

"Yes! Okay? Fine. You caught me, officer!" She put out her wrists. "Take me in. Throw me in the slammer!" She was starting to feel progressively smaller and smaller.

Adora was not amused. Good. "What is it? Huh? What are you on?"

Catra subconsciously rubbed her nose, and immediately kicked herself. Adora nodded, knowingly. "Okay." Then she disappeared around the corner.

"Where...where are you going?"

"Bathroom." Old habits die hard. Adora used to find her cigarettes in a bag taped to the inside of the toilette. Catra closed her eyes and downed the second shot as the toilet flushed, standing straighter but still putting pressure on her good leg. Adora came back around the corner.

She steeled herself so as not to show the shame that was creeping into her veins. "That was worth a lot of money, you know?"

"Yeah, worth some jail time too."

"I had a shit day at work, and I needed a little pick-me-up. Get off my back." Adora's eyes softened. She probably looked like hell -wearing mismatched booty shorts and a ratty old T-shirt, a busted lip. Thankfully the counter hid the mark that was developing on her leg...

"Yeah I bet you did. Did some guy get handsy with you at work?"

Catra raised her eyebrows. "You could say that." Anger flashed over Adora's eyes again. Catra reached to pour herself another drink. "But why the fuck would you care? Sounds like you get pretty handsy yourself."

Adora shook her head. "What?"

"The girl who gave you a lap dance was raving all about it -the hot blonde who was all over her. You asked her to sleep with you?"

"I was just doing my job-"

"Oh, bull-shit." Catra took the shot.

"What, are you jealous?"

"Look, are you-"

"You are, aren't you? You're jealous." Catra hated that her face felt hot. It made her mad.

"Are you gonna arrest me for doing a little bit of coke, or are you gonna leave? Cause the door is right-" She took a confident step back -on the wrong leg -and the muscles complained. She winced and inhaled sharply, catching herself.

"Catra! No, stay over there. Don't come over here. Goddammit."

"No, I'm fine-"

"Why are you limping?" A hand started to turn her . "Catra -what happened!?"

They both looked down to see the thick, darkening red line formed on her mid-thigh. Without warning, Adora scooped her up and carried her to her bedroom. Catra let her, her resolve melting away with her anger, leaving only a frightened woman and she hated that. Catra couldn't help but be impressed by the ease with which she was carried, nor could she help the sense of deja-vu butterflies it wrought remembering the last time Adora carried her to a bed like this. God, what she wouldn't give for another night like that…

Adora set her on the bed carefully, propping her up on pillows. "Is that okay?" Catra nodded. She couldn't tell if she was dizzy because the alcohol was starting to kick in, or because the smell of Adora's perfume was turning her world upside down. She watched as Adora

left and came back with an ice pack. "This isn't going to feel good." Great. "But it's important. I'm going to move your leg." Oh, she did not like the sound of that. The last thing her leg wanted to do was move.

Adora lifted the back of Catra's knee and pushed her heel towards her body as far as it would go -her muscles in pain the whole way. "Goddammit. Why -" She bit her knuckle. "Why does that hurt so bad?"

"Because you bruised the muscle really bad, and there's a lot of bleeding in there. If you don't let it rest and heal properly, and if you just lay in the same place without stretching it out, you could end up with myositis ossificans."

"Bless you."

Adora smiled. For a moment it almost felt like Catra had never left - that they'd been together this whole time. "A big name for something you don't want. So we're going to have to ice you like this a few times every hour or so." Adora had gone through a phase where she really thought she wanted to be a surgeon -until she found out that she couldn't handle cutting people open -it was impressive that she still retained so much of the medical mumbo jumbo. "Do you have any first aid wraps?"

Catra shook her head no. Adora gave her a disapproving look. "Of course you don't." "Scarves?"

Catra cocked an eyebrow. You know the answer to that. She nodded. "Top drawer, on the left." Adora walked over to the dresser and pulled it open, hesitating for a moment. Oops. Catra forgot' she kept her scarves with the sex toys. Adora closed the drawer and returned with a long grey scarf in hand, cheeks pink. "Oh please. Nothing you haven't seen before."

An awkward silence passed as Adora began to tie the ice pack to her thigh. The pressure of it hurt. "Ow." Adora cinched it tighter.

That's cold."

It's ice." Adora held back a laugh. "You'll get numb" Catra scoffed. She'd been trying to get numb for years and nothing seemed to be working.

"Where are your headphones?"

Catra looked at Adora, surprised. "Should be on the table in the dining room. Why?" Adora left and came back with headphones plugged into her phone.

"Here." Catra took the ear buds, tentatively. She wants me to listen to music? "You used to try to justify smoking by saying you got high so you could see colors when we were apart." Catra's heart leapt. "I don't think it's right." Adora seemed so sad. "...but I understand." Her eyebrows furrowed. "If I had something that could make me feel alive again without you, I would do it." But her eyes kept talking. 'I just wish this wasn't your thing.'

'If I had something'...is she saying that she still misses her? Catra put one in, immediately feeling the tears start to well up. This was their summer playlist. "You've got about twenty minutes. Just relax while we ice you. Then we're leaving. You're being followed."

Followed? Shit. "By who?" She felt her stomach give a sickening twist. Hordak probably had guys out to 'collect' her. Stace maybe got Rob to agree to wait for the payout for a few days, but Hordak didn't exactly seem like a patient man.

"You tell me." Catra thought about it...maybe she should. "Relax for now."

She put the other ear bud in and lay her head back. Adora sat down next to her, close enough to make her heart race. Even with her eyes closed, she could see them -bright, vibrant colors dancing in shapes and swirls with the music. She was too touched to care that she was crying, or to open her eyes when she felt fingers brush lightly

through her hair. The alcohol had definitely kicked in, mixing with the heightened sensation from the cocaine - this was turning into the best buzz. This was the most colorful day she'd had in years.

Chapter End Notes

Is anyone else STILL sobbing about season 5? I will definitely be venting some of my feelings via art and writing, so keep an eye on my IG for sketches and on here for wordy stuff fs.

Date Night

Chapter Summary

> Adora has a plan to catch Catra's to-be kidnappers. Hint: it involves being reckless and eating pancakes.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora felt immense relief when the blonde girl turned down her offer. Sure, it meant they were going to have to play hardball with the owner to get surveillance tapes and scrape together enough evidence to prove this joint was facilitating, but it also meant that Catra wasn't selling...services to people. The girl gave her a phone number, which Adora crumpled and threw away the second she was out of sight. Flattered, but not interested in the slightest. She walked back out to where her friends were seated. "I'm ready to head out whenever you guys are."

"I think Bow and I are gonna get a drink and see maybe one or two more, but then we'll head out. If you need to leave early though, we understand."

Adora put her hand gently on Glimmer's shoulder. She never could have asked for better friends -there couldn't be more unconditionally supportive humans out there. They came along without even asking why. They just understood without any explanation that it was both work-related and personal. "I think I'm gonna head out now then."

She made her way to the door, eyes immediately drawn to the two black escalades leaving. Both had windows tinted way more than was legally allowed -neither one of them had license plates. Okay, that's not suspicious at all. If that' s the kind of vehicle they use to get people or drugs in and out, surveillance cameras wouldn't even be much help. Damn.

Adora thought back to her conversation with that waitress as she pushed open the door. She could tell she was lying when she said Catra wasn't here. But why? If Catra was going to continue ignoring her calls and messages, she needed to find another way to get to her. Sneak passed the body guard, sure. But open all the doors in that place snooping for her? Bad plan. But still... She needed to know for sure…

Adora glanced around and didn't see anybody else outside. She turned left out the doors and started around the back side of the building to the side parking lot. There was a big sign on the side of a gate: Staff Only. Not trespassing. Yeah, I bet they don't want other people coming back here if they're exchanging goods. She kicked herself -this was reckless. What are you even looking for? It's been so long -you have no idea what Catra is driving these days. There was a mishmash of vehicles -a beat up old truck, some small Hondas, a Corolla, a Tesla, a Ford sedan, a minivan -of all the places, honestly -and…

There. THAT was Catra's car. She would bet nearly anything on it. It was a small, fire-engine red porsche. She walked closer. Custom license plate: 3ADBTCH. Definitely Catra's. Adora remembered the day she told her that was her dream car. It was a hot afternoon, mid spring. Adora came home after practice to find Catra on her roof, sunbathing -topless. They talked on the roof until dinnertime. Catra said someday she'd have a place with a view and a red porsche, a license plate that said bad bitch'. Adora never doubted it for a second -whatever Catra wanted, Catra got. She made things happen that way.

They kissed for the first time that night. Of course, neither one of them would admit that's what it was. They were too afraid the other would think it was weird, so they chalked it up to a simple competition to see who was the most chicken-shit. Adora lost. It wasn't until months later -things had escalated to handsy makeout sessions and heavy petting in the shower -that they decided to talk

about it. Correction. Adora decided to talk about it. Catra just laughed and tried to brush it off as fun, practice, a way to vent.

Turning away from the car, she pulled out her phone. "Hey , it's Ether. Can you do me a favor?"

There was a horrible cacophony of sound from the other line. "Ah! Sorry. Im working on a project."Of course. She was always working on something. "What is it?"

"I need you to get me an address for a plate."

Something akin to drilling must have been happening. Entrapta yelled over the noise. "EASY!"

Adora plugged one ear. "Great, thanks."Out of the corner of her eye, she caught movement. That waitress was coming out of the building, watching her. Shit. Who would you be on the phone with right now? Make it sound inconspicuous. "Oh and, Ill pay extra if you could make the flowers out of fondant."She' s definitely coming to talk to me. Way to not be suspicious, Adora. Who the hell calls a bakery? "Y eah, Ill come pick up the cake tomorrow ."

Entrapta was still working on something. "WHA T ICAN HEAR YOU. EX ME."

Adora smiled into the phone. Look natural. Look natural. "Sounds good. Talk to you soon then, and thanks again. Iowe you one. Bye bye."

She hung up the phone just as the older woman stopped in front of her. "This is the staf f parking lot. Can Ihelp you?"

"Uh. Im so sorry , Ididnt mean to trespass. Iwas looking for a better signal. Big office party tomorrow."She didnt ask you, dumbass

The woman was eyeing her . "W ell, Im going to have to ask you to head back around to the front. Staff only back here."

Adora held up her hands. "I understand completely. Thank you." She put her hands in her pocket and walked back around to the front of the building. Once she was safe in her car, she sent a text to her tech gal with the car model, color and plate. Then all she had to do was wait. She drove to a nearby parking lot to avoid any further suspicion. Entrapta got back to her quickly.

The vehicle was registered to a Catra Mendoza.
1400 Parkview Ctr.
Apt. 28
Brightmoon, 496839

Perfect. Here we go. She both was and wasn't surprised to find Catra lived on the east side of town. This part of the city was where a lot of people in the tech industry lived - a lot of expensive boutiques and all organic grocery stores. She always did have champagne tastes; she just never had the financial stability to live that way growing up. Adora pulled up to the high rise apartment building. It was a very modern-looking grey color with a lot of glass - big windows that probably offered quite the view at the top. But a lot of parking...most people probably took public transportation and didn't need to park. Adora crossed the street and used a restaurant's lot.

She checked her watch nearly every five minutes, watching, waiting to see Catra's car. She might not park right out front. Maybe she parks elsewhere and walks. Adora laughed to herself. No, Catra definitely doesn't do that. Sure enough, a little red-hot Porsche came speeding down the road, tailgating somebody's Subaru, and parallel parked right in front. Adora's heart stopped when she noticed the car behind hers, slowing way down as it passed her parked car. A black Escalade - windows tinted black, no license plates. Adora watched the car turn around the corner. Catra had already gotten out of her car and must have gone inside while she was staring after the Escalade. Don't jump to conclusions. Maybe it's just a friend...but the car circled back. A bull of a man in slacks and a black polo stepped out on the phone. He circled Catra's car and bent to look in the

windows, a gun tucked into the waistband of his pants. He's definitely not a friend.

Adora's heart started racing. Catra was being followed by somebody who was at the club. Did she know them? Adora had to get there first. But what if these guys saw her coming? They couldn't suspect her of anything. She glanced back at her kevlar vest in the back seat under a blanket. She would have to risk it. She got out of the car and made her way to the building. She created a group message to Agent King and Detective Thornbrush:

Long story short. Tailing a lead who's being followed. I think shit's about to go down. Standby.

The man walks towards the corner of the building, watching her wearily as she approaches. She smiles and he gives her a once up-and-down, winking at her. She pretends to return her attention to her phone. As she reaches for the door handle, she can see the car pulling up to the building again in the window reflection. She can hear the man get back inside as the car pulls away again. Were they just here to watch Catra?

She looks at the directory near the elevator. Fifth floor. The inside of the building feels smaller than she expected, but then again, that probably meant the insides of the apartments were larger. The hallway felt incredibly long though, like the elongating halls in the Shining. The further she got, the longer it seemed it would take to get there. What was she even going to say? Catra wasn't going to just come with her. Not without incentive. Well...if meatheads toting guns at her door wasn't enough to convince her, then all hope was lost. She knocked on door 28. Waited. Nothing.

"Catra. I know you're in there." There was a chance that those men would come up here at any second. "You can either open the door and let me in, or I'll break in." Open the damn door Catra. Come one.

She knocked again, harder. "I'm serious. I know you're there."

There was a click and the door opened just a crack, the way people do when they're hiding something. Adora couldn't see her face fully. "Why are you here."

"Open the door ."

"Tell me why you're here."

She was losing her patience. "I'm trying to help you, woman!" "Open the fucking door, Catra."

The door opened and Adora stepped through, glancing both ways in the hallway before closing and locking it. Catra's apartment was very chic, with high ceilings -too high -and bright lights and angular furniture. It looked cold. She was leaned over the countertop, resting a glass against her mouth. Something was off about her...but she still looked really good. Her hair was straightened, cascading down her shoulders -the makeup around her eyes bringing out their colors.

"Catra I need to talk to you."

"How do you know where I live?"

"I had somebody trace your license plate. I saw the car ." There was no reason not to be honest at this point.

Catra looked disbelieving. "What're you, some kinda cop?"

"Yeah. I am." Adora pulled the coat of her jacket aside to show her pistol. "If anyone finds out I'm here, I could lose my job." Catra's almost-smile fell and Adora watched the gears turn slowly. Her hand relaxed and revealed a swollen, split lip. What the hell? "What happened to your lip?"

Adora stepped forward, furious. "Who did this?" The thought of somebody striking her was unbearable.

"Doesn't matter . It's never gonna happen again." The hell it doesn't! Catra put the glass down and started to fill it again.

"Yes. It does matter. It matters to me."

"How nice." She went to pick up the shot, but Adora grabbed her hand, forcing Catra to meet her gaze. Her eyes were slightly bloodshot, pupils dilated. Adora's heart sank.

"Are you...are you high...right now?"

"Fuck off."

"No. Are you fucking high right now? Answer me." What is she taking? Is somebody making her do drugs? Is she getting roped in?

"Yes! Okay? Fine. You caught me, officer!" She put out her wrists, mockingly. "Take me in. Throw me in the slammer!" Catra always did this when she got defensive.

"What is it? Huh? What are you on?"

As if to answer her question, Catra's finger rubbed her nose. Cocaine.

"Okay." Where's her bathroom? She didn't even have to think about what she was doing. She'd done it many, many times before.

"Where...where are you going?"

"Bathroom." Adora knew it would be there. She took off the lid to the back of the toilette. Sure enough. A small bag of white powder taped to the underside. She emptied the contents and flushed it.

When she returned, Catra was still standing at the counter, looking irritated but also...disheartened. "That was worth a lot of money, you know?"

Adora scoffed. "Yeah, worth some jail time too."

"I had a shit day at work, and I needed a little pick-me-up. Get off my back." Yeah, I guess I wouldn't exactly feel sane either if I had a job

like hers.

"Yeah I bet you did. Did some guy get handsy with you at work?"

Catra raised her eyebrows. "You could say that." Another wave of anger rushed through her at the thought of Catra being trapped, stuck in a room with somebody... Catra reached to pour herself another drink. "But why the fuck would you care? Sounds like you get pretty handsy yourself."

Whoa. Adora shook her head. "What?"

"The girl who gave you a lapdance was raving all about it -the hot blonde who was all over her. You asked her to sleep with you?"

"The girl I got a lap dance from? She heard about that? I was just doing my job-"

"Oh, bull-shit." Catra took the shot.

Catra was such a pain sometimes when she was territorial. Wait...when she was territorial. "What, are you jealous?"

"Look, are you-"

She still cares. "You are, aren't you? You're jealous."

"Are you gonna arrest me for doing a little bit of coke, or are you gonna leave? Cause the door is right-" Catra winced as she took a step back, reaching for the counter again to stable herself.

Alarms sounded in Adora's head. "Catra?" She made her way around the counter.

"Ok, I'm fine-"

"Why are you limping?" She grabbed Catra's shoulder and started to turn her, looking for signs of injury. "Catra -what happened?!"

They both gazed down to see the thick, darkening red line formed on her mid-thigh. Somebody fucking beat her!Adora scooped her up and carried her to her bedroom, glad that Catra didnt fight or squirm, but instead relaxed in her arms. They certainly couldnt make a run for anywhere like this. Without knowing how many men were in that car, it was hard to know what the right call was going to be. They didnt necessarily have time for this, but she needed Catra to be calm, and maybe numb that leg a little bit so she could move around better.

Adora set her on the bed carefully, propping her up on pillows. "Is that okay?"Catra nodded.

She walked back out to the freezer for an ice pack. "This isnt going to feel good, but it's important. Im going to move your leg."

Adora lifted the back of Catra's knee and pushed her heel towards her body as far as it would go, watching her face contort in pain. "Goddammit. Why -"She bit her knuckle. "Why does that hurt so bad?"

"Because you bruised the muscle really bad, and there' s a lot of bleeding in there. If you dont let it rest and heal properly , and if you just lay in the same place without stretching it out, you could end up with myositis ossificans."

"Bless you."Catra was smiling at her , softly.

Adora smiled back, knowing she was actually impressed whenever she used medical lingo. "A big name for something you dont want. So were going to have to ice you like this a few times every hour or so. Do you have any first aid wraps?"

Catra shook her head no. Of course you dont. Catra has never exactly been the prepared type. What else could they use? "Scarves?"

Catra cocked an eyebrow and nodded. Guess she's still into that..."T op drawer, on the left."Adora walked over to the dresser and pulled it open, hesitating for a moment. "There were a handful of long silky scarves on the left hand side of the drawer. The right was littered with dildos and small vibrators of different colors -one of which Adora recognized. She'd used that one plenty of times. Adora closed the drawer and returned with a long grey scarf in hand, cheeks pink.

"Oh please. Nothing you haven't seen before."She looked pleased with herself. Yeah, that's why it's exactly why it's a problem. I can't UNsee it, which means I can't stop thinking about it...

An awkward silence passed as Adora began to tie the ice pack to her thigh. Catra inhaled sharply "Ow ."Adora cinched it tighter . "That' s cold."

"It' s ice."She held back a laugh. "Y oull get numb"Catra scof fed in response.

Adora felt bad that she had to be in this much pain. It was pretty swollen...somebody hit her with something really hard. She sighed. "Where are your headphones"?

Catra's heterochromatic eyes looked back at Adora, surprised. "Should be on the table in the dining room. Why"?Because I know what will make you feel better. She went to go find them and came back, already a playlist in mind to give her.

"Here."Catra took the ear buds tentatively . She seemed almost like she was waiting for an explanation. "Y ou used to try to justify smoking by saying you got high so you could see colors when we were apart."Adora' s heart started to ache, remembering that conversation."I don't think it' s right"."I wish you weren't abusing drugs. "...but I understand."Her eyebrows furrowed. "If I had something that could make me feel alive again without you, I would do it."The world has been grey for me too since you left...

Catra put one in, pausing. Recognition flashed over her eyes. She remembers it... "You've got about twenty minutes with the ice, then we're leaving. You're being followed."

Alarm took its place, an expression Adora rarely saw on her. "By who?"

"You tell me."She seemed to think about it. "Relax for now . Tell me after."

She put the other ear bud in and lay her head back. Adora sat down next to her, watching her face change as she drifted off into her world of color. Silent tears fell and Adora let her fingers brush play lightly through her hair. It was still so soft...she shook herself out of it. It was time to come up with a plan. "They couldn't just be sitting ducks here all night. "Those guys were either going to make a move and come up here, or tail them. Regardless, she was going to need backup.

She stood and called Agent King.

"King."

"Micah, hey . I'm with one of the girls from the club -she' s mixed up in this somehow. She's being tailed by a black Escalade with tinted windows and no license plates. Isaw it earlier at the strip club. One of the guys has a gun, Idon't know how many there are but I'm sure they're up to some shady shit. Ineed you and "Hornbrush to lay low across the street from this address in case they come up here and things get out of hand. Make sure that anybody who comes is in an unmarked car. We can't af ford to tip them off. Try to keep visual but don't let them see you."

"Got it."

She hung up and sent the address. It should have made her feel better, but for some reason she was more on edge. "The timer goes off. Catra pulls out the ear buds and sits up, wiping the last of the

tears away, looking refreshed and...nostalgic. Adora feels a sense of satisfaction as she unwraps Catra's leg, trying not to put too much pressure. She was glad she was able to give some sort of pleasantness to this experience, but now it was time to be serious.

"Catra, listen to me. There's some men who followed you to your building." She watched Catra's features change from serene to fear. She knows she's in trouble...almost like she was expecting it. "They could be coming up here at any moment. Do you have any idea who's out there or what they want?" No response. Adora could see she was struggling with herself. "Please. I can't protect you if I don't know."

Tears started to brim in her eyes and she turned away. "Catra... Let me in."

She inhaled slowly and turned back to Adora. Let me in. That's what she would say whenever Catra was being closed off and self-destructive at home. Adora would drive to her parents' house at any hour of the day or night, and just take her away for a few hours. It wasn't much, but it helped. Sometimes she would bring her back home with her, which also meant Catra skipped school that day, but the time they spent together was worth it. Sleeping next to her was worth it.

"Me." She sniffed. "They're here for me." Adora's heart dropped. "I'm...my boss, uh." Catra cleared her throat. "I guess you could say I'm being transferred." "Transferred?" No.

"You mean sold." Something akin to embarrassment flashed in Catra's eyes and Adora knew it was true. So they really were looking to grab her. They hadn't come up yet. What were they waiting for? Were they waiting for her to go to sleep? She felt nauseous at the thought. "I already know your club is involved in human trafficking." Catra looked away again.

"Yeah well." She sniffed again, wiping the corners of her eye so tears wouldn't fall. "I guess they're here to... collect on behalf of my

new...boss.”“You mean owner. Adora felt a pain in her hand and realized she’d been clenching her fist too hard. Something about the way Catra said ‘collect’ made her feel like she could kill with her bare hands. Catra was nobody’s possession.

“You’ve never belonged to anyone or anything a day in your life.” Not even me.“You’re sure as hell not about to start now.” Catra looked at her quizzically.

“But...they knew I was going to run.”

“But they don’t know I’m here, and they don’t know the police are watching.” If they hadn’t come by now, they were probably anticipating she would come back outside to try and run away, and that’s where they were planning to grab her. It would be less risky than the possibility of somebody dragging her kicking and screaming through an occupied apartment building. The more she thought about it, the more she realized she needed them to actually make a move, as frightening as the thought was.

Adora had a plan.

They had to catch them in the act. They would need to be vulnerable for a while. “I’m not going to let anything happen to you.”

A few tears spilled over and Catra laughed. “You’re such an idiot.” It was a term of endearment from her.

“Get dressed.” No time for laughs.

“What?”

She started to take off her own jacket, Catra watching her, confused. “Put on some regular clothes.”

“Why?”

“We’re going on a date.”

She laughed. "What? Are you really THAT bad at reading women?"

Adora removed her holster and loosened her tie, feeling Catra's eyes follow her hands. "I've got some people on the way in case things go south here-"

"Oh, great."

"But if my guys approach without cause, they'll know we're onto them. We need to catch them in the act, which means we need to let them catch us." She started unbuttoning her shirt. "Do you have anything that will fit me?"

"What do you mean, catch us? Like, let them take us? Like bait?"

"Well, yes and no. We need them to make a move so my people can actually arrest them on rightful charges so we can hold them, but I'm not leaving you alone. If I'm dressed like this, they might get suspicious, or at the very least be more aggressive." Catra was just watching her, thinking. "If what they see instead is two totally helpless, oblivious women, they probably won't hesitate as long as they can get us in the open. So yes. We're bait. But I'm going to protect you, Catra. And once it's over -when we catch them, we can put your new boss' out of business."

Catra walked over to the other side of the bed, still gimping slightly, and pulled a grey sweatshirt out of the dirty laundry basket. "Here." Adora held it out. It was her old track sweatshirt. Had Catra kept this the whole time? It was in her dirty laundry basket -she still wears it?

Color warmed Catra's cheeks. "It's comfortable. Don't read into it"

Adora smiled and put it on. It was a little tighter in the shoulders than when she last wore it, but it still fit. She slipped it over her head and looked at herself in the mirror. It would still be bulky enough to hide her hand gun. Adora was thankful she always got one size too big for her, even though Catra made fun of her for it. It was probably huge on Catra -the image of her wearing nothing but the oversized

sweatshirt made the butterflies start up again. t smelled like her ... focus!"Pants?"

Catra grabbed a pair of black leggings from her dresser and held them out. "Uhh...Idont think those are gonna fit me."Her legs were a bit more muscular than Catra's, and slightly longer. Besides, Catra always got her clothes to fit very tight. Adora would need to be able to move around easily. Catra looked annoyed but dug around again and pulled out a pair of black joggers -they fit well enough. She put her phone, keys, and wallet in. "Hornbrush had messaged her: here.

Adora struggled not to watch Catra undress and redress again and she called Huntara's phone.

"Hello?"

"W eve acting as bait. W eve dressed in civilian clothes, and well be coming out the main street doors to my car in the parking lot across the road. Be ready to move in case we get jumped on the way there. f we make it to the car , head to the international pancake house on Seventy-fifth and Cooper Ave. f you dont see us come out the main door in five minutes, it means theyve already in the building."

"Ether , what the hell kinda-"

"Five minutes."

Catra was watching her, looking more and more vulnerable to her by the second. Adora put her holster back on and cinched it tight, a bit higher than she usually wore it to keep the base from sticking out the bottom. "Remember , weve posing as totally unaware, carefree women."

"Posing?Idont know about you but Im totally care free."Oftentimes Catra's sarcasm was really nice -this was not one of those times.

"Im taking you on a date, weve having fun, and we LKE each other . Got it?"Catra nodded, still seeming unsure. Im going to get you

away from all of this. Iswear . Her eyes softened again. "And whatever you do, dont look around like youre looking for somebody watching you. Just look at me. Focus on me, okay?" Catra nodded. "Lets go."

Adora took her hand as they made their way for the door. She checked the peep hole before opening it. Walking backwards into the halfway, she pulled Catra against her with a surprised gasp. "Ready for the best pancakes ever?" Adora could tell there was somebody at the very end of the hallway, walking towards them. Catra looked up at her incredulously. Come on, Catra. Play along. "I know the best place for late night eats." She gave Catra a quick peck on the lips, startling her again. She just blinked at her for a few moments before turning away to lock the door.

"As long as it' s greasy and cheap, Im in."

Adora almost sighed with relief. "They could totally play this of f. The person coming down the hallway wasnt one of the men -they stopped and entered an apartment. Another wave of relief. "That means theyre waiting outside for us...

She took Catra's hand and laced their fingers together -a perfect fit. t always was. "Im buying but that doesnt mean it' s free." Catra slapped her arm playfully. Oh yeah, they could totally pull off unsuspecting lesbians.

They get in the elevator and Catra pulled her hand away . She didnt seem happy to be playing along. "How' s the leg?" Fourth floor .

"Doesnt feel great."

"Sorry . Want me to carry you again?"

"I manage. But thanks."

"Alright, just checking." Third floor .

"So why do we have to pretend like we're going on a date? Why can't we just be two regular friends going out?"

"I need an excuse to be close to you at all times. Friends don't stand so close to just friends." Second floor .

They held each other 's stare for a moment. They'd had that conversation several times before, about crossing lines and messy feelings. "Whatever you say ." First floor . The doors opened and Adora pulled her in again, stealing another kiss -firmer this time -and spinning Catra around as they exited the elevator, getting a quick 360 scan of the lobby. All clear. She put Catra down, who was fighting a smile. "Ugly shoes, lover ." Sarcasm painted her voice again, more playful this time. Wow. Adora missed that.

She did look a little ridiculous in sweatpants and black dress shoes. Oh well.

They passed through the glass doors, Adora' s heart pounding in her ears. From her peripheral vision, she could see one of the men still standing against the building -they had been waiting. He didn't make a move. Okay, good. Adora slipped her arm around Catra's waist and held her close as they moved away and waited for the crosswalk signal near the other side of the building, thankful that she let her.

Catra was talking low. "Boy , I sure love taking evening strolls with a target on my ass. Don't you?" Adora squeezed her side gently .

"We're gonna have a great time, you'll see." The crosswalk signal turned and they made their way across the street. "Besides, the only thing on your ass is my eyes."

Catra jumped away and started walking backwards, clearly trying to stifle her limp, that come-n-get-me expression on her face. She was really, really good at playing along to this. Adora's heart leapt. God, I still want her. She couldn't help but lunge forward and take the bait. She grabbed Catra by the waist again and lifted her. Catra wrapped her legs around Adora's hips, low enough that she wouldn't touch

the pistol. She whispered in her ear. "There's a man who just walked around the corner. He's on a cell phone. Looks like one of Hordak's guys."So that's what she was doing, getting a look at the guy...atta girl. But also, damn. Her breath smelled strongly of alcohol. How much had she drank?And who was Hordak?The man trying to buy her?

Adora set her down again and unlocked the car. Catra hiccupped. She was definitely tipsy. "You drive a charger?Sucha douchy car. I swear, your real name is Chad."Adora smiled. She used to call her that every once in a while for being a 'dumb jock'.

"That's Princess Chad, to you. And for your information, that's what I named the car."

Catra rolled her eyes with a soft smile and she buckled her seat belt. Adora unlocked her phone and gave it to Catra. "Call the most recent number. Put it on speaker phone please."

She started the car as the phone rang. Huntara picked up. "We've got visual. Looks like there's just two, but they are equipped and they are following. You sure you want to go about it like this?"

"We need solid charges to hold them on."

"Alright. We'll meet at the location."

"I'll park in the side lot. Just be ready."

"On it."Adora nodded to Catra to hang up. "Oh, and Ether, she's cute."Catra smirked at her. "Maybe when this is all over you-"Click. Adora took the phone from her, trying not to let the smouldering eyes burn her cheeks anymore than they already were. She didn't know what exactly would happen when this was all over, but she was pretty damn sure that Catra wasn't interested -not in the same way Adora was.

"These pancakes better be orgasmic." Catra crossed her arms over her chest and lowered her voice, "God knows I need one"…

Adora found it hard to believe that this woman wasn't getting laid regularly, but she couldn't just ask if she'd been sleeping around… "Well, if the food doesn't make it happen, you've got all those toys for a reason." She tried to sound joking but it came out a bit more serious.

Catra scoffed, "Yeah" but she looked almost...sad. She kept her face turned to the window for the rest of the trip. Adora wished she was better at reading Catra when she was like this. Maybe if she had been, things would have ended differently between them.

She checked her rearview mirror as they turned off the main road into the parking lot. "The Escalade was following closely . Good. "They pulled into a spot just a few spaces over but didn't get out of the car . So they're still just tailing...probably deciding what to do with Adora if they still make a go for Catra. Adora went to Catra's side and opened the door for her to step out, appreciating how well she wore lazy , casual clothes. She could make a paper bag look stylish, and she knew it. "That confidence was something Adora was always so taken with -even now, in this crazy situation, the infatuation only waned slightly.

Adora took her hand again and turned to walk into the diner. She recognized one of the cars on the opposite side of the lot facing the street. King and "Hornbrush were already there. "They walked in and were seated at a booth near the middle. Adora thanked the waitress.

"So...what now?"

"Exactly what you asked for , cheap and greasy food."

Catra leaned forward across the table whispering. "And we just what, wait for them?"

Adora smiled for anyone who might be watching. "Y up. Pretend like you actually want me around. This is just another date for us unsuspecting lesbians."

She was expecting some witty quip, but it never came. Man, Catra had to be really freaked out. Not that anyone could blame her . The waitress came and asked them what they wanted to drink.

Adora started. "I'd like a cof fee, please. Black, thank you."

"Great." The waitress nodded, "And for you, hon?"

"I'll have a strawberry milkshake."

She left again and Adora was still staring at Catra. She used to make fun of Adora all the time -she said strawberry was the absolute worst flavor of milkshake of all time and that Adora was the biggest loser for liking it. "What?"

"Y ou used to say-"

"Y eah, yeah." She crossed her arms. "A girl can change her mind, can't she? I knew she liked it! She used to steal sips when she thought Adora wasn't looking.

Adora held up her hands. "Absolutely ."

Bells chimed as the door opened and two men walked in, now wearing coats to hide their guns. They seated themselves in the far corner. Now it was just a waiting game.

Catra sank a bit lower in her seat, looking frightened. "Is that them?"

Adora took a sip from her water, leaning on her hands, a smile plastered on her face. "Y ep." She lowered her voice, "They won't do anything here. Relax. Focus on me." That did seem to make her feel better. "It' s just you and me, in this" she looked around at the dingy lights and ancient tiled floor that could have been from the fifties "...romantic diner ."

Catra laughed -really laughed -probably partially from build up stress and intoxication, but it filled Adora with such bittersweet joy . It almost made her happy enough to forget the circumstances that brought them here. The smile she gave was genuine. "You certainly know how to treat a lady."

Adora smiled back. "Since when have you ever been a lady?"

Catra blew the end of her straw sleeve back at Adora. "I am a classy bitch."

"Oh yeah. I could tell by the way you pounded those double shots after work."

"Well EXCUSE me for not being some sort of pompous-ass wine connoisseur." She swirled her straw around the cup of water , kind of pouting. "I bet that's the kind of girl you're dating now , huh? She's probably a total wine mom."

Adora smiled to herself. Only for a moment did she consider lying just to make Catra jealous, elated that it was even a possibility . "Haven't been on a date in..." She had to think about it, which made her embarrassed that she started to own up to it. "...seven months, I think?" Catra seemed surprised. "You're right, she was a total wine mom, which is exactly why it didn't go anywhere. She was not you. "...boring."

She could tell Catra was fighting a smile. "Ah." She looked relieved. She really was jealous. Adora's heart leapt, watching her fiddle with her straw thoughtfully. "We've never had a date out in public before."

It was true. They were basically closeted the whole time they were actually in a committed relationship. There were a lot of people who viewed them as family, and to a certain degree they understood that they were supposed to be like that, but it just never was. One time, on their first 'official' anniversary , Adora drove them two towns over so they could go to a nice dinner somewhere as a couple. Catra was practically glowing the whole time.

"I guess that's true."

The waitress came back with the coffee and milkshake. "Thank you."

"Do you know what you'd like to order?"

Adora got the classic hash and Catra ordered raspberry stuffed french toast -she always did have a terrible sweet tooth. Her hot chocolate had to be so saturated with cocoa powder and sugar that it was practically the consistency of melted chocolate. Adora plucked the cherry off Catra's whipped cream and they shared a smile. This was familiar. They were years away in another lifetime where they were comfortable just being themselves in each others' company. It kind of did feel like a date. Maybe when this was over, they really could...She left you. Adora snapped herself out of it.

By the time their food came, the men in the corner still hadn't gotten anything to eat, just coffee for one of them. The other had taken a phone call. The only thing Adora could make out was one mouthing the word 'understood.' She didn't want to spoil this though. They were safe as long as they were in public, so she just drew it out. They ate with pleasant conversation and playful banter, remembering all kinds of shenanigans Catra had gotten them into, which Adora then had to get them out of.

When the food was gone, it was about time. They waved for the check. Adora left a cash tip on the table. Catra's eyes were frightened and unsure. She was asking 'do we really have to go?' Adora gave a small nod with a smile, holding out her hand for Catra to take. "Come on, I'll take you home." Their fingers laced together again as they stood up. Unfortunately, that felt familiar too. Whenever Adora would come rescue Catra for a night, it was magic. She could take away all her troubles, calm her fears, make her laugh, but at the end of the night, she would have to take her back home. Adora hated watching that realization fall over her. Sometimes Catra would squeeze her hand tight enough on the way back to leave marks. Yes, those words always meant the end of something, and tonight would be no different in that respect. But tonight...tonight

Adora was going to put an end to the bad. This would only be the end to a cause of suffering for Catra.

They opened the door and started for the car on the other side of the parking lot. Adora put all of her attention into listening behind them. But twenty seconds later she heard the door open. Here we go. They're coming.

They had to keep the act going. Adora swung their hands forwards and back. "What do you wanna do when we get home?"

Catra was practically shaking. "I dont know . What do you wanna do?"

"I've got some ideas." When this was over she wanted to jump and dance and kiss her for real.

Catra squeezed her hand a little tighter , and Aora squeezed back. We're gonna be fine. She could hear them closing in -heavy , fast walking. The hair on the back of her neck was standing up. So close. I'm ready . I can handle-

There was a jolt of pain in her back and her body went rigid. She felt Catra's do the same next to her as she let out a squeal. T asers. They had fucking tasers. Shit. I'm sorry Catra. Guns, yes. Knives, sure? But not tasers -she hadn't anticipated that. She felt arms restrain her from behind, unable to get her muscles to retaliate for the moment. "Get her to the car!" It infuriated her . The second her muscles came back to life, she tried to gather her wits, forcing her body to do as it was told. She got a leg behind his, twisting out and capturing his head under her arm, squeezing.

She heard car doors in the distance. Yes. Backup. Running footsteps.

"FREEZE! Let the women go and put your hands above your head." it was Huntara who spoke. The thugs' attention was brought to the four officers now standing twenty feet ahead, pistols aimed. A car

with its lights on pulled up and blocked the entrance. Adora rendered her man unconscious before he could grab his weapon, but the gorilla holding Catra started to pull his out. King started to warn him."Put the gun do-"

Adora wasnt going to give him a chance to fire. Her arms reached for it, dislocating his finger in the process of taking it from his grip. He let out a pained yowl. She kicked his knee down from the back, Catra made a sound as her knees hit the pavement too. Sorry. Adora threw his gun away and pulled out her own, aiming at his shoulder. She couldnt risk letting a bullet go through him. "Let her go. Put your hands above your head."

There were frantic gasping noises from the two of them -he was choking Catra. Adora whipped the back of his head with the butt of the gun, causing him to collapse. Catra caught herself with her arms, coughing. The other of ficers moved in and she grabbed Catra by the waist to pull her up. The first man was being handcuf fed and lifted - dragged, more like, as he was still unconscious -by two officers. "You have the right to remain silent. Anything you say can and will be used against you in a court of law"… Another had rushed to roll the other over man. "He' s...he's dead."

Adora looked down. "He' s what?" didnt hit him that hard. No way .

"Looks like he took something." There was a foamy substance in the corners of his mouth. Must have been some kind of capsule…

"Gag the other one then. Cant risk him keeling over when he wakes up.We need him alive."

Detective Thornbrush holstered her side arm and clapped Adora on the shoulder. "Not bad, kid. Crazy as shit, but not bad."

One of the officers had gone to talk to the owner of the restaurant, who was standing outside, concerned. King got off the phone - probably with Angella. "Either , meet us at the station." She nodded.

Catra punched her shoulder, looking panicked -understandably so. "THIS is your idea of a date? Using us as bait! Y ou let me get fucking tased!"

Adora pulled her in close. "I'm sorry ."Catra clung to her , shaking. "I'm sorry . You're safe now . They cant hurt you. I've got you, Catra" They were both breathing shakily , adrenaline still coursing through her veins. "Y ou did so good. it' s almost over, I promise."

Chapter End Notes

This story is coming to a close. Thoughts on how you would like to see it resolved? My plan is to just see where the words go as they come out (that's pretty much how I write all my shtuf f). I'm always open to suggestions.

What Conflict of Interest?

Chapter Summary

The aftermath.

Chapter Notes

So this might be a good time to admit that all my stories (including this one) are un-edited drafts. Please excuse the random errors all over the place. I just re-read the first couple chapters and damn y'all, my eyes MUST have been tired. I think I'll have to go back and edit this one. Definitely not my best writing.

Update: I DREW SEXY COP ADORA (https://www.instagram.com/halpiveicaughtsherafever/)

Stripper Catra is next up

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had a very long bucket list. Surprise, surprise! Getting tased was not on it. Catra couldn't reach the spot where she felt the prongs' sting her skin. She wanted to punch Adora again, but her body still felt uncoordinated. Since leaving this embrace would only be worth it if she could actually punch her and call her an asshole, Catra decided it was best to just stay as long as she was able. That was crazy. They literally just put their lives on the line, and for what? Adora used her as bait! But still...Adora made sure they were okay. Even after all the years they spent apart, Adora felt like safety. Adora felt like home.

She brought Catra back to the car. "We have to go to the station. They're going to have to question you, Catra."

What? Hold up. "What?" Adora was giving her the classic-Adora-apologetic eyes. "You didn't say I was going to be interrogated!"

"Not interrogated - questioned. There is a difference." Catra shook her head. Absolutely not. "You're a witness, and in the eyes of the law, the intended victim of that would-have-been kidnapping." She continued shaking her head. "And, of the inner workings of a part of the larger human trafficking circuit in this city and its sister drug cartel."

Catra crossed her arms over her chest. How long had Adora already known that the club dealt in prostitution? ...well...not the club - Rob. Stace explained that it was her decision to make all of the deals related to prostitution off site, so the business couldn't be connected back. Adora didn't know that part though... She just knew Catra was in trouble. She even traced her license plate and followed her home... Did Adora... plan this? Was she really just using me to catch the bad guys? She felt her face flush with anger. "That's what this is all about, isn't it? You show up out of the fucking blue so you can use me as bait to play the hero?" She felt tears blur her vision and she turned away. "Wow, Adora."

"What? No!" She reached for Catra's arm, who wrenched away, feeling a bit claustrophobic. Such a stupid, small car. Fuck this. Fuck this night. Fuck their date. Fuck this feeling in her chest. Fuck her still-trembling limbs. She willed her eyes to dry. "Catra, no. It's not like th-"

"Let's just get this over with, alright? I don't want to be stuck in this shitty car with you any longer than I have to be."

"Catra, I risked my job to find you tonight -"

The words crept under her skin and found all the old insecurities she'd tried to cover up the last few years. They made her erupt. "Great! So it was another self-sacrificial plan to feed your fucking ego! Why am I not surprised?" She forced herself to look at Adora, who seemed to be struggling with herself - because when was Saint

Adora never NOTstruggling with herself?Catra was angry and her brain told her to just lash out, drunk on the color red -and maybe a little bit of alcohol.

"I'm trying to protect you."

"Oh, chyeah."She scof fed. "Remind me, whose idea was that?"

Adora pinched her nose between her fingers. "It was the only way I could-"

"Get the bad guys?"

"Yes!"She threw her hands up in an exasperated motion.

"I'd say it went well. One of them is dead and the other won't talk. Great work, officer dickhead."That seemed to strike a cord. For some reason, it didn't make Catra feel better . Goddammit. The look of vulnerability passed quickly from Adora' s face and a strange kind of determination took its place. She'd never seen Adora look like that before.

She sounded almost distant. She spoke in a very even, monotonous tone: "It was worth it."Adora turned back to face the wheel and started the car.

"What, risking our lives?"

The car started moving. "I won't let them have you."But I wouldn't'. She said IW ont'. Like she the fight wasn't over . Catra was starting to lose her edge, her anger getting slowly chipped.

"Please, like you had control over that situation. That obviously didn't go according to your little plan. You were tased too. The guy holding me had a gun."She could still hear the shot ringing in her ear , feel his arm closing off her airway... "It' s not like you're bulletproof. What if he shot and killed you?"

Catra studied Adora's face, waiting for the answer, I don't know. But her normally all-telling eyes were like blank slates, unreadable and closed off. "Then I would have died." The calmness of the delivery was eerie -chilling, but not half as cold as the words themselves. They froze the red right out of the world and sent a chill down Catra's spine. What would Catra have done? What if Adora had been shot? What if she was just there, bleeding on the ground? Her chest started to hurt. "And my people still would have gotten you to safety. It would have gone exactly to plan."

It took a moment for it all to set in. I'm trying to protect you." The ONLY thing she cared about was keeping Catra safe. Still. Always. That's how she always was -willing to throw down her life, her future, to get Catra out of a bad situation, even temporarily. And for what? All she ever did was get right back into a different one. Have we really not changed at all? How could you be so fucking stupid, Adora? Why?

Adora leaned one arm against the door, holding her cheek. "Why what?"

"Why are you so fucking obsessed with protecting me? I'm not a goddamn child." I'm not your burden to bear anymore. I can carry my own weight now.

Adora sighed, some of the life returning to her eyes. Catra wished it hadn't. What she saw there now was betrayal and sadness. Her voice was strained, but clear and soft -yet it struck Catra harder than even Hordak's hand. "It's a personal problem."

Fuck. Hearing Adora repeat those words back to her was far worse than anything else that could have gone wrong tonight. She would rather be tased again for an hour -shit, all night! She would rather spend the rest of her life numb and drugged out of her mind, pleasing dick than be sitting here, listening to Adora parrot her biggest mistake back to her with that look in her eyes. Nothing could be worse than facing down this placid-black pit of guilt and shame and regret that threatened to engulf her.

They drove the rest of the way in silence. Catra couldn't tell if that seemed to relieve Adora or not -it certainly didn't make Catra feel any better. But what the hell could she even say back to that anyways? She definitely couldn't tell the truth at this point. Besides, nothing had changed. Adora was still too good for her -it would never work. I'm doing you a favor .

She parked the car, the sudden absence of the road noise pulling Catra from her thoughts. Adora let her out and they went into the precinct together, both pausing to look at the ambulance pulled up to the front. "Shit"…

Inside, the paramedics were shoving a syringe into Hordak' s thug's bare chest "...delivering shock. Clear the patient"…

A tall, lithe woman in a suit walked over towards them -her golden feather earrings glinting in the light. Adora stepped towards her, rubbing her face the way she does when she's stressed. "He ingested some kind of poison. Best we can tell, it was some kind of fake tooth."

Wow. She knew Hordak's guys were ride-or-die, but damn. "Jesus. That' s some James Bond shit." Neither one of them paid any mind to Catra's comment.

"Goddammit!" Adora kicked a nearby trash can, sending it flying. Adora didn't usually get angry about things.

"No need to panic, you've still got a witness -that' s something." Her eyes meet Catra's for a moment and for some reason she wanted to hide. "You'll need to change first -you can use your old uniform -but then go ahead and start so we can all get out of here before the sun comes up. King will be in with you shortly."

Adora hesitated. "I think it' s only right that he and Detective Thornbrush handle the questioning, Chief." This woman was the head of the police department?

The older woman tilted her head. "Oh? And why is that?"

"Conflict of interest." Catra may not know a lot about being a cop or detective, or whatever, but she knew what that meant. She was pretty sure Adora wasn't supposed to admit to it.

The chief's eyes moved from Catra to Adora, and back again, thinking. "I see. That explains your reaction yesterday upon learning about the underground happenings at the club." Just yesterday? "Huntara called and filled me in. When she said you'd run off on your own, I assumed it was because you'd figured something out." She wasn't exactly condescending, but there was something unforgiving about this woman's voice. This bitch was baiting Adora for something. "I have to say, Detective Ether, I'm quite surprised. I never would have expected you to be so rash, running off first thing." She pointed a long finger at Catra. "Had she been a more integral part of their circle, you could have blown the entire operation right out the gate, or worse - gotten yourself killed. I could suspend you."

Catra heard Adora's cool voice echo in her head, "Then I would have died." It made her furious all over again. "That's bullshit!" Adora held up her hand to shush her, a serious look on her face.

"My selfish actions put many people in danger tonight and I will accept the consequences." Selfish? Please.

The woman nodded. "Very well, I am removing you from the case."

Was Adora...getting kind of fired? "I risked my job!" Catra erupted. "What?! You can't do that!" She had the audacity to smile politely back at her.

"Catra-"

"No! Fuck that!" Other officers were looking at them. "Adora is intelligent and ballsy, and if you wanna see this through, you're gonna need her."

The woman didn't even bother to respond to her . She looked back at Adora. "You will be questioned as a witness. If you'd like, you can stay for her questioning."

Catra was livid. Adora must have sensed the coming explosion. She grabbed a wrist with just enough force to tell her to calm the fuck down. The chief looked pleased with herself. Whatever she wanted from Adora, she'd gotten it. What was it? Admission that she did wrong? She didn't do anything wrong! Fucking bitch. She bit her tongue for fear of making things worse for Adora. "Yes ma'am." Adora pulled her past the paramedics and other officers, down a hallway lined with benches and a few rooms. The other two cops who'd been there earlier that night greeted them. The tall woman was watching her carefully -she looked vaguely familiar. Catra was pretty sure she'd seen her at the club before.

"Can I get your name, ma'am?"

She looked at Adora, who let go of her wrist and nodded. "Catra."

The dark-haired man looked at her as if he was expecting something else. "Uh...last name?" Oh, duh.

"Mendoza. M-e-n-d-o-z-a."

He scribbled that down on a pad. "Would you mind coming with me? I've got some questions for you."

Again, Adora nodded to her. 'Answer his questions'. She followed him into the furthest room. Stealing one final glance back at Adora, looking utterly exhausted. She felt another twinge of guilt as the door closed. This was all her fault. All she wanted to do was curl up in a ball and hide away -away from this bad fluorescent lighting and cold metallic-feeling rooms. The man was talking to her like she was some shaken up baby -it was pissing her off. But her anger was stilled by thoughts of Adora, telling her to just be calm and get it over with, then she could go home.

They started with the basics -who she was, her age, where she lived -and gradually transitioned into her work. There was a brief moment where she wondered if she was really willing to give the information up. Doing so would also mean giving up this new life. But then she thought of how many girls she'd met over the last few years who she had to watch fall from the proverbial grace a stripper can have. She would do something for somebody else for once -she would do this for them. And she would do this for Adora.

She told him about Rob, how he was basically the soundboard. Everything went through him. She told him about the so-called auditions for girls that were held at a sister-esque club made from an abandoned warehouse in the south-central area, and how drugs moved from in and out of there as well. He asked if she was ever involved in acts of prostitution and she explained that nothing like that ever happened at the club. He asked if other dancers knew what was going on and she told him no -she was the only one privy to such information because Rob and Stace trusted her. She did her best to leave Stace out of all of it, except to play the plausible deniability card on her behalf. She said that Rob basically forced her to do things for him -which wasn't a lie. After a while, her eyes started to get heavy -the alcohol had finally made her sleepy. Plus it was like two in the morning -that helped. How long had she been talking? This guy had pages and pages of notes scribbled on his little pad.

He excused himself and was gone for a while. Catra looked around the room for a moment. Would it kill them to decorate a little? Jesus, looks like a morgue in here. She watched herself in the long mirror along the top half of the wall. Was that really a mirror? Or was it one of those two-way things like in TV? The man returned some time later with a cup of black coffee. Ew. He set it down in front of her. "Here. I know it's late, I'm sorry. We really, REALLY appreciate your cooperation. I won't take too much more of your time, I promise."

Catra glanced at it again. Oh, not coffee -it was hot chocolate. She held the warm cup in her hands and sniffed. It smelled...perfect. It

cop shows they always bring coffee. How did he know she didn't like coffee? How did he know she liked hot chocolate? She took a sip. It was creamy and sweet with chocolatey goodness. She couldn't help the smile tugging at the corners of her lips. Adora made this for her. She was on the other side of that glass, wasn't she?

"Is it okay?" He motioned to the cup.

"Yeah." She scanned the glass wall, searching for any sign of life behind it. "It's uh...it's perfect. Thanks..." Adora. The thought was only comforting for a moment, and then the coldness of the room seeped back into her body, with that cup in her hands as the only singular source of warmth. Adora was on the other side of that glass. She was listening to all of this...What would Adora think of her? What would she think knowing that Catra knew all of this and stayed despite it? It really was kind of terrible...

"Now, I've just learned that you and Detective Ether were previously acquainted?"

Uh oh. "You could say that."

"What was the nature of your relationship?"

Was Adora going to get in trouble for this? They couldn't actually fire her, could they? "It's complicated."

He must have read her mind. Something about his expression was encouraging, almost like giving her a nudge with his eyes. "Look, she's my partner. I don't want to get her in trouble just as much as you don't. I can't make you answer any questions, but the better I understand, the more I'll be able to help."

Catra took another sip of hot cocoa and sighed. "We've...known each other a long time. We were together, but then we'll...left her because I was fucking stupid. "...split up. That was years ago. Then she was just there at the club one night."

"What night was that?"

"Two nights ago."

"And did she try to get in contact with you after that?"

Catra gripped the mug a little tighter. "Yes. She did."

"But nothing came of it?"

"No." Because I didn't respond to her . I never responded to her .

"And tell me about today . Somebody assaulted you at work?"

Catra shifted in her chair. Fuck. She had to talk about this? "I..there's this guy . I guess...I don't know his real name -he just goes by Hordak. I don't know for sure, but I think he's the one who moves women around. He's super rich and all the wrong kinds of powerful. I'd never seen him before today though."

"And he's the one who did that?" He pointed to Catra's lip.

One finger traced the rim of the cup, remembering how it stung. Her cheek tingled at the thought. "Yeah..."

"Why did he do that?"

Adora was definitely behind the glass. Catra could practically FEEL her eyes, willing her to spill her guts and lay all the shit on the table for everyone to see. "I guess he made an offer to buy me from Rob." Saying it out loud made her cringe. "One he supposedly couldn't refuse', apparently." She sighed. "He wanted me to...recreate a performance from the previous night that he happened to see. But...I couldn't. Well...I didn't. I guess that disappointed him so..." She made a weak gesture to her face. God, how fucked was that?

"And your leg? Adora said there's a mark there."

Of course she told them about that. "He backhanded me and it pissed me off. So...Ispat in his face and said he hit like a bitch..." Adora was shaking her head on the other side of that glass -Catra could feel it. "...thats when he hit me with his cane."

"And then?"

"Then he told me he was going to have to break my spirit." She suppressed a shudder. "Then he and Rob left to talk about...the exchange."

"Do you mind if Iask how that usually works?"

"What, buying?" He nodded in response. "Not like that at all. Usually Rob holds what he calls 'auditions' at another location. It's basically...the best Ican figure from what Ive overhead, it's basically an auction where clients bid on women. "The pretty girls who are already abusing drugs are usually the first to go. But the performers are always safe."She took another nervous sip of the hot cocoa, wishing it would warm her from the inside out.

"What do you mean by that?"

"People...Rob has received of fers before, for me, Imean. But he always turned them down -said Iwas too good of a performer to lose."Her stomach twisted. "I'm a dancer , not a prostitute."In that moment, she wasn't sure who she was saying that to. Herself, this cop, Adora. Maybe all three of them.

"But this Hordak, he made an of fer?"

Catra scoffed. "Chyeah. Like Isaid, Iguess it was one Rob couldn't refuse. He probably threatened to put him out of business or take his knee caps or something. Hell if Iknow ."She waited for the cop to say something else, but he didn't. He just watched her , waiting for her to continue. For some reason, she did. "Stace said she talked to Rob and convinced him to postpone the deal for a few days -she was going to help me run but...Iguess...Iguess Hordak knew

something was wrong with that so...so he sent some guys to grab me."He just nodded silently . "I...Adora hadn't shown up tonight..." She couldn't finish the thought.

"She just showed up at your apartment tonight?"

While she was bleeding and high and drinking. "Yes."Jesus Catra.

"Well, thank you, Miss Mendoza. You've been a great help. I won't keep you any longer but we may call you back if we have any more questions."

He pulled her chair back with a gentle scrape against the floor and helped her up, which at first she thought was dumb, but as she went to stand, she understood what it meant to be bone-tired. Everything ached. She'd been sitting for too long. Her leg was hurting again and both her feet felt like they were encased in cement, almost as if all the adrenaline and anger had gone and left her body limp as a noodle. She couldn't wait to go to bed. Bed. Even the word sounded heavenly. Wait, shit. She couldn't go back to her place -Hordak would know by now that something went wrong. Would he come back for her? Would he send more men? Shit. Calm down, Catra. You'll figure it out. You always land on your feet. You can run home, pack and then just -

They rounded the corner into the hallway where Adora and the other lady cop were talking -Adora was laughing. She had changed into a fitted blue uniform shirt with a badge on the front and a shoulder patch, tucked into darker slack-trousers. Catra had never given a second thought to police uniforms before, but goddamn -she was fantasy fuel. Adora noticed them and turned, her impossibly blue eyes knocking into her. Catra didn't realize she was staring until she spilt the hot cocoa on her foot, drawing her attention away -finally.

Adora raised an eyebrow. "You must be tired. You'd never waste hot chocolate."Catra felt like her brain was short-circuiting. She was too tired and too enthralled by the sight of Adora to human right now.

She was finally able to come up with something to respond when the boss lady came back, interrupting her train of thought just as it was getting momentum. Catra had the strongest urge to dump the rest of her drink all over her nice suit. "Well, we do appreciate you taking the time to speak with us. Detective Ether, I trust you two will get home safely?"

Adora's smile disappeared. "Beg your pardon, Chief? You two? Like, us...together?

The other woman seemed to pick it up. "Surely she'll be going home with you?" They both just stared at her. Adora's mouth hung open slightly. "Well we certainly can't send her back to HER home, what with somebody stalking her and waiting for a good opportunity to move in. Witness protection isn't an option at this point in time and we can't very well offer her regular protection as an adult." Gears were turning in Adora's head. "It would be most beneficial for us if she stays with someone she trusts, apart from their circle of influence, that can keep her safe."

Adora furrowed her eyebrows. "Yes, but I'm...I thought you said -"

"You're off the case, yes."

"So"…

"SO, as far as I'm concerned, there is no conflict of interest. You are off duty. She can trust you. You can keep her safe. I'd say it's a win-win, wouldn't you?" She steps closer to Adora, placing a hand on her shoulder. "Detective, you are quite possibly one of the most responsible people I've ever met, yet tonight, you ran blindfolded into the lion's den, risking much more than your job..." Lady, you have NO idea. Catra rolled her eyes internally. "If you're going to throw caution to the wind to protect her regardless, I may as well try minimize the window of error and place her in your care..." Oh... Oh. There it was, that smug-ass look on her face. She was so pleased with herself...she totally set that up. At least that meant Adora wasn't in trouble…

Adora smiled, almost looking as though she'd received a medal. It made Catra's heart feel full. You're such a dork. "Yes ma'am."

She turned again to Catra, making her heart stop. "I'll take you home." Her ocean eyes were practically glowing against the blue of her uniform. Ba-dump. She had to stay with Adora tonight? Dressed like that? Yes please.

Chapter End Notes

I have no idea how many more chapters there'll be. I'm thinking at least two -potentially three. This whole bit was different than I had originally thought it would be. *shrug*

It just be like that sometimes.

Also, you KNOW Catra sings this song after seeing Adora in that uniform: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MdKCuxD6sA

Taking Her Home

Chapter Summary

Catra goes home with Adora.

Chapter Notes

Note: i know that the "consent" to touch in this is dubious; just know that they both want it because they're gay disasters.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had watched her struggle through a lot of things, but that informational interview was up there on that list for Catra. She was actually telling the truth. It hurt to listen to -to know she lived in such a dangerous world since she ran away. Adora couldn't always protect her, and she knew that. Hell, the reason she joined the force wasn't to play superman. She just wanted to do SOME good…

Right now, she didn't feel right in this uniform. It still fit her perfectly , and she took pride in the little patches she'd earned since joining the force. Each was a reminder of countless hours of physical and mental energy spent to make somebody's life just a little easier . But something was off. Those two men -the men who tried to T AKE Catra -got the easy way out. They didn't have to face the consequences for their actions. It wasn't just. It wasn't fair . It wasn't right. But she was going to fix it, dammit. They couldn't get away with this -with taking people into mental and physical slavery.

The questions were almost over with. Huntara nods to the hallway and they exit the observation room together. "So she' s your ex, huh? Fiery little thing."

Adora smiled. "Y eah...That was a long time ago though."

"What a woman. She takes a hit and then spits on the guy." She whistles. "I dont suppose you still have feelings..."…

Ha! So many feelings. Adora puts her hands on her hips and Huntara sizes her up, reading her mind. "I see. I guess I won't ask you for her number then...She always been like that?"
Adora laughed. Yes. One time she picked a fight with the girl who was notoriously the toughest at her school for no reason -just because she needed her to know that she wasnt intimidated. Needless to say , she lost, but she just kept getting back up, over and over again -taunting her. Yes. She'd always been that way . She just didnt know when to quit, and she was a terrible loser .

Her eyes caught motion from around the corner. Catra and Agent King had finished and were heading towards them. Catra abruptly stopped. She was just standing there, just staring at Adora. What's she looking at? Adora watches as her hand relaxes and the cup of hot chocolate tilts slightly, spilling some onto her sneakers -her eyes follow the liquid down, breaking whatever trance she was in.

Adora raised an eyebrow. "You must be tired. You'd never waste hot chocolate." Catra opened her mouth, blinking, and then closed it again. What's gotten into her? She wasnt usually one to falter with words.

Angella came up behind her, speaking to Catra. "Well, we do appreciate you taking the time to speak with us." She turned to face Adora, looking somewhat pleased. It wasnt totally surprising -now they actually had evidence to support their claim, even if they didnt get to question the two men. They had names they could use. Maybe the car would even give them some other details. "Detective Ether, I trust you two will get home safely?"

Me take her home? Can she even go home right now? Beg your pardon, Chief?"

"Surely she'll be going home with you?" With ME? Both Adora and Catra blinked at her, surprised. Huh? "Well we certainly cant send

her back to HER home, what with somebody stalking her and waiting for a good opportunity to move in. Witness protection isn't an option at this point in time and we can't very well offer her regular protection as an adult."Gears were turning in Adora's head. She couldn't possibly take Catra home. That would be problematic for so many reasons. It would be awkward and messy and dangerous and...and...tempting. It would be so, so tempting. It would be most beneficial for us if she stays with someone she trusts, apart from the circle of influence, that can keep her safe."

I'm...sure Catra has other contacts"…

Angella turned to Catra. "Well? Do you?"Catra looked at Adora, and then back to Angella. She shook her head, no. What? Really? Nobody in this whole city? That can't be. "Good. It's settled then." Or maybe she just wants to stay with you...Oh. Even if that's the case, it doesn't matter. She couldn't fall back into this again. And that still didn't solve the main conflict of interest issue.

Adora furrowed her eyebrows. "Yes, but I'm...Ithought you said -"

"You're off the case, yes."

"So"…

"SO, as far as I'm concerned, there is no conflict of interest. You are off duty. There's no reason you can't be together."Something about the way Angella said be together 'made her almost wince, like she could see straight through Adora. Am Ithat painfully obvious? She can trust you. You can keep her safe. I'd say it's a win-win, wouldn't you?"Catra trusts me...She steps closer to Adora, placing a hand on her shoulder. "Detective, you are quite possibly one of the most responsible people I've ever met, yet tonight, you ran blindfolded into the lion's den, risking much more than your job..."And Iwould do it all over again...If you're going to throw caution to the wind to protect her regardless, Imay as well try minimize the window of error and place her in your care..."Oh...She removed me from the case to keep me from getting in trouble...

Adora smiled, feeling a bit lighter. Angella had faith in her, and so did Catra. She must have or she never would have gone along with it. She could do this. "Y es ma'am."

She turned again to Catra, who was now looking back at her, almost as if she was asking if this was really alright. "I'll take you home." And this time, it will be good. I'll protect you. Y ou can trust me. It' s totally platonic. Ican do this.

She grabs her duffle bag with the spare clothes and they go to the car. Catra hisses as she lowers herself into the seat, using her arms to bend the leg in. "W e're going to have to put more ice on that when we get home."Whoa. Ma'pr Dej'a vu. When WE get HOME. Catra didn't seem to respond to it -maybe she didn't think it was strange. She sat there looking out the window, not quite brooding, but Adora could tell something was bothering her.

"Only if Ican have some more alcohol first. "That ice hurts like hell."

"W ell it's helping."

"I'd rather take a bath."

"Heat will make it worse."

"T sh. So will walking on it, but we did a lot of that tonight."Ugh. She was such a brat sometimes and she knew it.

"Actually ...no, walking is fine and can be really good. "N ow you get to rest, anyways."

Catra turned back to the front of the car, the tiniest upward turn visible in the corner of her mouth. "What...what about massage?" The way her voice dipped slightly was suggestive.

Don't even think about it, Adora. "What about it?"

"W ould that make it better?"

"Well massage directly over the injury would definitely be worse. But elsewhere, I suppose it could help with swelling." Dammit. Now she was thinking about it.

"So just massage everywhere else." She shrugged, "Easy." Everywhere else. Catra always did this. She phrased things that would pique her interest just enough to get under her skin, make her think about things, picture things. "C'mon, please? You give really good massages and I could use one." Now Adora couldn't tell if Catra was just doing this for attention or if she meant it. She'd been through hell tonight, so it was definitely possible that she would be in need of a massage. Plus she did technically have a really physical job…

"Well see."

They pulled into the neighborhood and Adora parked against the frontside curb. Catra eyed the house. "Cute."

"Thanks." They head inside and Adora turns on the upstairs hall light, hoping that Bow and Glimmer aren't up so she won't have to explain things. She's thankful when she sees that the TV is off and the rest of the house seems dark. "My roommates are probably sleeping," she whispers.

She wraps one arm around Catra's waist to help her limp up the stairs -very aware of the warmth of her skin from underneath the sweater she wore. Catra leans against her, pulling herself with one hand on the railing. "The people you came to the club with?"

"Yeah. We met in college."

They get to her room and Adora is glad she keeps it clean. She only panics for a moment when she thinks Catra is eyeing an obscure picture of the two of them as children with Adora's mom in front of their house. But her gaze passes quickly over it and she breathes a quiet sigh of relief. "Do you mind if I shower?"

Shit. Is my bathroom clean? She didn't even think about that. Well, we're good. I cleaned the shower like last week. Not at all. There's clean towels in the closet in there." Catra starts to make her way to the bathroom. "But try to keep that leg out of the water if you can."

"Yeah, yeah. Thanks, mom."

She watched Catra head for the bathroom, marveling at the thought of her getting naked. She tries to brush the idea away, but she can't. She can hear the water through the door, and she can't stop picturing what it looks like cascading down her body, remembering... Adora removes her uniform and her tank top, grabbing her own towel off the back of the door, wrapping it around her waist. She should probably shower too. It had been a long day.

Tomorrow they'd be meeting with their informant, Double T rouble. Hopefully they would be able to give some kind of insights into where this Hordak could be found, where he operated from. Did he use another local business? Or was it some kind of underground railroad-esque system of delivery, constantly flowing and changing? Is that who Diego went through? Did the DEA really have no ideas about the movement of their drugs throughout the city? No clues as to where it was coming through?

Adora's thoughts were broken when she heard the water turn off. A few moments later, Catra came back out and stole all the air in the room. Steam rose off her silhouette. As she stepped out of the doorway, Adora could see water droplets sat on her shoulders and collar bones, and her eyes were sleepy and heavy-lidded. She looked relaxed -and hot as fuck. Adora's muscles all seemed to tense, wanting nothing more than to pull at the towel hugging her body and watch it fall to the floor before drawing her closer to feel her skin. Oh no. She could not be this high-strung if Catra was staying the night. She'd need to...work some of that out.

"I like the tiles in there."

The blonde stood and skirted around her , feeling heat radiating off of her. She always did like hot showers. "Uh, thanks. I do too." She turned around in the doorway. "Do you need to pee at all?"

She crossed her arms over her chest, furrowing her eyebrows. "No, why?"

"Cause I was gonna..." lock... the door. But as she thought it, Adora realized there was no point. Locked doors never stopped her before.

Catra raised her eyebrows, seeming to understand -and agree. "Right." That wicked smirk made its way across her lips, her eyes boasting of past triumphs. "Don't worry , Princess, I'll stay right here. Go enjoy your shower ." She plopped down on the bed.

Adora just nodded, embarrassed, and closed the door behind her . After hesitating for a moment, she didn't lock the door .

As she turned on the water and stepped into the still-hot stream, she felt her heart thumping against her ribs. What if Catra came in? She should have locked the door... She wouldn't, right? But...what if she did? Well then I'd ask her to leave, obviously . But what if she stayed? What...What if she dropped her towel and stepped right back into the shower again, keeping Adora hostage in the heat? Her insides tightened at the thought -imagining that smirk underneath hungry eyes that threatened to consume everything. Those eyes were dangerous...What if she let her? Adora said screw it and let mind and her hands explore the idea.

She'd let Catra push her up against the cold wall, getting on her tiptoes to whisper in Adora's ear. "Cat got your tongue?" Then she'd bite it gently while a hand slides lower to fondle Adora's breast. Adora's body responds immediately, reaching to pull Catra closer -to feel their bodies pressed together again under the water. That's all she wanted, to feel Catra close again. Liar. She still wanted Catra's everything. She wanted to lay claim to every inch of her perfect skin, to possess her. Yet somehow, there was more...she wanted Catra to want her back...

She imagines Catra's body sliding lower on hers, until she sinks onto her knees. Oh God. She's looking up at her, face painted with addled desire. She leans forward and very quickly sets to making Adora lose control -if she ever even had any to begin with. Clearly not. It's been so long since she allowed herself to fantasize, to touch herself -probably because it was always Catra she thought of...Adora knows it won't take much...Instead of the shower stream and her own fingers, it's Catra's tongue she feels. She bites back a moan when imaginary Catra opens her eyes to meet Adora's strained gaze, raking her perfectly manicured nails down Adora's stomach. The thought is enough to send her over the short ledge.

She opens her eyes, somehow irritated, disappointed, and relieved all at once that Catra wasn't really there. Goddammit. Keep it in your pants, Adora. You're supposed to be focused on protecting her - helping her. Once this is all over, you can go back to not seeing each other again...but is that really what you want? She knew the answer was no. She knew it was pathetic, and maybe even a little bit creepy, to hold onto somebody so long after they clearly rejected her. Well...not clearly. Nothing about it was clear. Catra was still giving her mixed signals, even now...it's just because she's insecure...isn't it? Catra just needed attention and validation and Adora was always so willing to give it...but...she just couldn't help it. Catra captivated her like nobody, and nothing, else ever did.

She stepped out of the shower and dried off a little before putting her towel back around her body. Her hand stopped short of opening the door. She mentally steeled herself, preparing to find Catra sprawled naked on the bed, attempting to rile her up somehow only to deny her. When she opened the door and that wasn't the case, she kicked herself for even thinking about it in the first place. She groaned internally. She's already in your head. She didn't come here to seduce you...don't get your hopes up. Catra's asleep, curled up on her good side with her face buried in Adora's tank top -the one she'd taken off and lay on the chair with her uniform.

She still needs to ice her leg...Adora tiptoes downstairs. What was she even doing with it? W as she...smelling it? She used to say she had to do that sometimes to get to sleep in high school when they were apart...but she didn't still do that, right? W ell...she did keep my track sweatshirt...Adora came back upstairs, fingers cold from holding the bag. She threw on a sleeping T-shirt and shorts before trying to wake Catra -that would be a j ob and a half. She reaches for her shoulder, trying to ignore how smooth her skin is, shaking her gently. "Catra...Catra wake up. C'mon, j ust for j ust a couple more minutes." She shakes a little harder . Shit. "Catra."

Catra always was a heavy sleeper. Once, they'd fallen asleep in the back seat of her car. Adora drove her home, carried her inside, and put her in bed without her waking up at all. Sometimes she could even pluck her eyebrows or massage her before she'd stir . t always made for excellent blackmail videos later when Catra absolutely refused to believe that Adora had done anything. There was one time she'd given her a massage and Catra said it gave her strange dreams. The only thing that would reliably wake her was basically j umping on her . I sure as hell don't want to do that right now .

Adora pulled her over onto her back, alarmed as the towel threatened to come untucked near her armpit. Of course. Even in her sleep she was able to put Adora in uncomfortable situations. She carefully rolled the fabric in on itself a little moree, trying her best not to touch her directly. Adora lifted the underside of the bad knee to full flexion and felt a twinge of guilt -it was really stiff, even though she was asleep. Her quads must really freaking hurt. She grabs the other leg j ust above the knee to feel the dif ference. Eh...that side is tight too, but not nearly as bad... Maybe she really did need a massage…

No. Maybe...no...it depends: are you thinking that because it' s a nice thing to do, or because you want to touch her? She thought about it for a moment, grappling with a storm of guilt for putting her through so much, shame for being a little bit of a perv, and fear of Catra's reaction if she woke up. Well...Catra did ask me to earlier...She

sighed. Both. The answer was both. It would help Catra, but she definitely had a selfish interest too. So... she just had to make sure her selfish interest was outweighed by the good intention to make her feel better tomorrow.

The blonde got up again, moving to the cupboard to get massage oil. She'd bought the good stuff, but she never really had an excuse to use it other than occasionally working out stress-knots in her roommates. She walked to the edge of the bed near Catra's feet, watching her sleeping face for a few more cautious moments before placing her hands on Catra's lower leg. Still nothing. Good. The oil spread easily and she set to work, enjoying the process of naming all of the muscles in her head as her thumbs circled and pressed along their lengths. Catra definitely had some knots. Probably from wearing heels at work...

Bodies were so cool...especially beautiful bodies. Nope! Knock it off. It's just a knee. A regular ...knee. Just bones annnnd cartilage annnd tendons...Her hands slid up to massage around the knee, naming those ligaments as well, but her eyes kept going higher... Oh shit. With one leg bent like this, the towel was lifted and she could totally see Catra's pussy. There was...something...she...had a...piercing? There!? Fuck. Adora glued her eyes to the bed. Why would you look there? I didn't mean to! It just happened! It was just...THERE. Hurry up and fix this side and be done with it.

When did she...STOP. Adora got another drop of oil and rubbed back and forth over the tight band of tissue on the side of her thigh, pulling back down slowly, getting progressively more forceful. She repeated it until Catra's leg was pliable and no longer tense, pleased with herself. She'll thank me tomorrow. Well..no, actually, probably not. She looked to Catra's face again, still nothing. She's still such a heavy sleeper, damn. Now the bad leg...Adora gently removed the ice and straightened the leg again with not so much as a twitch from Catra. The mark across her thigh was a deep purple now, the edges tinged with blue and dark red spatterings. Good thing she's numb

and asleep -otherwise this would hurt like a bitch...Ican still be gentle though.

She started the same way on the lower leg, working the oil into her skin and taking her time over the smaller muscles along the sides. Then her knee again, trying to loosen the connective tissue around it. This side was W AY tighter, jesus. She spent a much longer time around the top of the knee, trying to get the fascia to release. Then she went along the very outside of the leg again, making sure not to press where the bruising was. Catra's eyes were shifting back and forth under her closed lids. She must be dreaming...Now came the moment Adora was dreading...She pictured all the vessels overlaying muscles as if it were a diagram. Goddammit. She'd have to push towards the inner thigh to encourage the lymphatic system to absorb some of that fluid…

She wrapped her hand around the top of Catra's knee and made a very light sweeping motion all the way up to the bottom of the towel. That' s as far as Il go. That' s totally PG. Okay V14. She repeated it several more times before starting to move inward diagonally, stopping once to get more oil. Catra's poor leg...again she named all of the muscles as she went, imagining all of the little healing processes happening under the skin right now -all the fluid getting taken away from the injury , ridding Catra's beaten up muscles of the swelling and pressure, one sweeping stroke at a time. A small noise from Catra made her freeze, eyes snapping up to her face. Adora let herself exhale when she found the brunette's eyes closed, her still-wet hair starting to form her usual soft curls around her head on the pillows. She continued on, only adding slightly more pressure as her fingertips reached the inside of Catra's thigh, a safe distance away from the bruising.

Almost done. Ijust have to push it all up...Now ...how to do this in a way that's...appropriate...she placed the outside heel of her hand at the top of Catra's medial knee, gently sweeping up to the bottom of the towel. Catra's breath hitched. Again, Adora looked up and waited. Nothing. Okay ...she did it again, watching her face this time.

Catra's eyebrow twitches. She hesitates, waiting again...no, she still seems out...She does it again, pressing just a bit harder . Catra's lips fall slightly open and her eyebrows twitch together again. Adora's heart rate skyrockets. She knew that face. It almost looks like she...is she having...is this giving her a sex dream right now? Is that what she meant by 'strange'? Adora does it again, adding just a little more pressure at the top, her fingers slipping passed the bottom of the towel. She fights the immense urge to squeeze the soft flesh there. Catra whimpers, her breath hitching again. Adora swallows hard and licks her lips. She feels like a teenage boy. At least I know it doesn't hurt this makes her feel good...

Without giving herself the chance to stop, one hand moves back to the good leg and she strokes up the inside of both at the same time with firm pressure. Catra's breathing picks up slightly. A little voice inside her head warns her to stop, but she does it again anyways, mesmerized by Catra's responses. Another little sound, one that's dangerously close to a short moan. Adora's addicted, heart beat thrumming in her finger tips. One more. One more and then I'm done. She presses a bit harder at the top, again letting her fingers go just a bit further than she should. Catra starts to let out another soft gasp and a half-formed word that tears through the blonde, "A-dor-" Her eyelids flutter and then fly open "-Ahhh. What the fuck are you doing?" My name...she was saying my name. She was dreaming about me?

Adora jumped back, sitting up on her knees. She was embarrassed that she'd been caught, but she didn't feel guilty at all. She could tell by Catra's face she wasn't angry - just surprised and...really embarrassed. She didn't very often blush, but her cheeks were a bit colored and she didn't seem to want to look Adora in the eyes. "I was massaging your leg. You-"

She held one hand over the top of her towel, still refusing to make eye contact. Her other hand still tightly grasped Adora's tank top on the bed. She really was dreaming about me..."I meant that I wanted one when I was awake, creepo."

Says the one smelling my shirt -Adora had to fight the smile from spreading. Catra's mismatched eyes followed her line of sight to the shirt in her fist. She recoiled immediately, throwing it at Adora, cheeks turning another shade darker. Busted. She was cute when she panicked like this. "What? It' s not my fault you leave your laundry in the bed! When did you get so messy?"

Adora caught the shirt and tossed it aside, clearing her throat to keep from laughing. I didn't leave my shirt on the bed and we both know it. She didn't say it though -the other woman was clearly flustered enough.

Catra crossed her arms and lay back on the pillows. "Shut up!" She was such a child sometimes.

Adora's resolve cracked and she smiled. "Catra, I didn't say anything."

"Ugh. Whatever ."

Adora looked her over for a few more seconds before standing up. "Where are you going?"

"Downstairs."

"Why?"

Adora turned back to look at her. "W ell, I was going to sleep on the couch."

Catra rolled her eyes. "My , how gentlemanly of you."

"W ould you prefer I put you on the floor?" She hadn't meant for her voice to do that -to offer a playful challenge. She was still feeling worked up over the massage. If Catra caught the innuendo, she paid it no attention -she always did have a better poker face. Well, no. She was just able to hold it longer and more consistently . Once

Catra lost her composure though -like a few moments ago -she was perfectly transparent.

"I'd PREFER you not be weird and just sleep in YOUR bed."

"Yes, but you're in my bed."

Catra was getting irritated. "And since when has that been a problem?" Oof. Since you ran off. Catra seemed to know that was the wrong thing to say. "I mean, we've shared a bed hundreds of times." And grass fields, and car seats, and floors...but it's different now.

"I'm just here to protect you now, nothing more. Once this is over with, you can sleep wherever you want. "Goodnight, Catra." She turned again for the door.

"Adora, wait." Something about the way she said it tugged at Adora's heart. "Look." She had one arm crossed over her body, holding herself. "I'm...still kind of...freaked out about tonight, okay?" She wouldn't make eye contact again. "Would you stay...with me?" Adora groaned inwardly. Why. Why was she so goddamn irresistible? Why can't I just say no and walk away? "Please?" She never said please.

The sigh was audible this time. "Okay." Catra looked up at her like, "really?" Yes, really. "But...could you put on something that's not...that?"

Catra looked down at her towel, and then back up to Adora. Really? This time, it was a patronizing question rather than a vulnerable one searching for validation. Yes, really. She sighed dramatically and rolled her eyes. The vulnerability was now gone and the usual show of swagger once again in its rightful place. "Fine." Before Adora had a change to get her clothes, Catra strode over to her closet, pulling open the closet door. "You haven't changed a bit."

Her closet was still organized by occasion and color, sure, but her wardrobe had definitely been upgraded. Catra dropped her towel

and Adora almost managed to look away -almost. She reached for one of Adora's more casual button-up blouses. It was meant to be tucked in, so it was a bit longer, but it certainly wasn't meant to be worn without pants, and Catra wasn't wearing any underwear ... "Do you have any spandex I could borrow?" Oh, thank God. Adora pointed to the second drawer of her dresser. Catra pulled out the smallest pair that was always shoved to the back of the drawer because they didn't fit Adora well. She turned around. "There. Can we please go to sleep now? I'm so dead."

Adora nodded, turning out the main overhead light and slipping under the covers on the opposite side of the bed. She felt Catra come in on the other side. Normally her bed felt huge, but right now it was like she was seconds away from being smothered. She didn't know what to do with her hands. Do I normally sleep with them inside the covers or outside? Outside... I think... right? She felt Catra shift and wiggle closer, her hands touching Adora's arm. After a while her pulse settled down again. Then she moved again -another spike in blood pressure -this time, Catra's hand was just over her stomach. Can she hear my heart pounding? She totally can. Adora had to make sure she was breathing regularly. Is she asleep? No. She breathes deeper than that when she sleeps…

Catra shifted again, this time pressing against Adora, draping her arm fully over her body and resting her head on her chest. Badup-badup-badupbadup. Shit. Now she really hears it. She was so warm and soft and she smelled good. Goddammit. How am I supposed to sleep like this? Catra's leg swung over her hips, keeping her knee bent -that's good, at least. Adora felt the moment Catra finally slipped into slumber -Catra's body going completely limp over her, breaths getting deeper and softer. Adora's heart rate came back down slowly, chest aching in spite of the familiarity of the body now on hers. This warmth, the way they fit together so comfortably -she felt calm. She felt at peace. She felt like she was home.

Chapter End Notes

I will be drawing Stripper-Catra at some point. In the meantime, there's this super amazing dancer (Jade Chenowyth, I think that's how you spell it). I imagine Catra dances similarly to her style when she's just kinda in her zone and doing her thang. Check out some of her stuff if you're bored and have nothing else to do. (Hell...you already spent who knows how long reading this :D)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qLzbLF0r8
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q7S96dih0
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AildAQyfs

Let's P ay a Game

Chapter Summary

> tts been a long time since theyve just had a day together . What better way to pass the time than with games?

Chapter Notes

> Smut warning: this chapter and the next will be peak smut, so maaaaybe consider skipping them if you arent interested. I personally feel like even scenes like this add a lot to the development of their story together, partially because it means reconciling with their emotions for/about each other.

A soft pink glow lit her dreams of forever-sunset kisses and dancing under the moonlight. She felt safe. She felt at home. Her mind wakes slowly, and she becomes aware of another person's warmth wrapped around her. She inhales -Adora. t wasnt just a dream. Im really with Adora. She remembers the events from the night before - Hordak. But it doesnt scare her this morning. t feels like nothing could -at least, not right now. One arm is snaked under her waist and wraps around her side. Another folds over the top of her, and Catra has it clutched to her chest. Almost out of habit, she brings the fingers in front of her face the short distance to her lips and gently kisses a knuckle.

Adora's arm tenses. 'A-are you awake?' She whispers.

Shit, what am Idoing? Catra keeps Adora' s hand there, trying not to move and to seem relaxed. She closes her eyes, trying to stop them from doing that twitchy thing they did when she faked it. Pretend youre asleep. Pretend youre still asleep. Catra was incredibly thankful that Adora didnt say anything else, but she still stayed there for a moment. Could Adora feel her pulse qicken against her arm? Shit.

After some time, Adora seemed to relax again, kind of nuzzling into her hair from behind, which made Catra relax. "They fit so well together like this...I just wish we were naked. That's a whole other experience. Ugh. What I wouldn't give for some good morning sex right now...Catra gave a very slight experimental push back against Adora's hips, which responded in the same fashion. She loved the resultant tingle that spread through her body, remembering that blissful dream late last night. God, Adora's hands were magic. She totally would have gotten off in her sleep if that dream continued, but she had to go and say her name out loud...She felt embarrassed all over again.

Adora's hips pressed forward gently again, her hand curling a bit tighter into a fist, almost like she was fidgeting. Goddammit Adora, I'm way too fucking horny for this. I guess she is too..."The hand on the arm that wrapped around her waist was just barely moving, ever so slightly pressing the fingers into the skin over her ribs. Then she stopped, then she started again. Stopped. Started. Catra had to fight a smile -she was always bad at keeping her hands to herself, but bless her heart of gold, she tried. Her hips moved again and Catra pushed back. Could she get away with grinding just a little? She gently pushed back one more time.

"There's no way she still thinks I'm sleeping. If they both knew the other was awake, then it was just a game to see who would give in first -who would admit they weren't just sleeping innocently. Catra would rather die than admit it. Sure enough, after a few strained moments of stillness, Adora rolled away, carefully trying to pull her hand out from under Catra, who continued to pretend to be asleep. Catra cracked one eye barely open and watched her walk towards the bathroom, rubbing the back of her neck, shaking her head.

Catra decided to stay 'asleep' until Adora finished in the bathroom and left to go downstairs. Staring at the ceiling, she wondered what was going to happen now. Realistically...the club would be shut down and she'd have to find another job. It was fun while it lasted...She

stretched, immediately feeling the huge knot across her thigh where her bruise was. Overall though, the rest of her leg felt good...Adora did give good massages. f only shed given me a full-body…

After some time, she stood, trying to bend her leg back and forth a few times before going to the bathroom. She felt a bit hungover - which tends to happen when you do cocaine and take six shots back to back. t was embarrassing for Adora to have seen her like that. She really did have her life together. She took care of herself, she cooked, she cleaned, she even read for fun sometimes -something she wouldnt have been caught dead doing in high school. All things considered, she felt she was very mature. She just wished there was a way to showcase that to Adora better.

She hobbles down the stairs using the railing to make up for her lack of motion. Adora is in the kitchen. She's got two plates out with eggs, bacon on a skillet, and toast with jam. She stops and just watches for a moment, seeing Adora at different stages in their lives, making Saturday breakfast: At seven, getting pancake batter all over the counter;at twelve, making little half-formed shapes for Kyle and Lonnie;at fifteen, bringing it to her in bed;at nineteen, making delicate little crepes filled with all kinds of sweet things for her. And then she saw one she didnt recognize. Adora is there in front of the stove, spatula in hand, a little blonde toddler propped on her hip, smiling down at him. There's a deep aching pang in Catra's chest. When she left, in her mind it was like Adora just stayed behind -in the past, in her memory. t was a very heavy realization -albeit one that should have been obvious -that time doesnt just stop when you arent with a person. Shed never imagined there could be a future without Adora. f there was...standing here right now , she didnt want it....

Future Adora turns to her, smiling. "Morning Catra." The mental image fades to reality. Adora isnt exactly smiling, but she's still filling the room with a comfortable warmth. "Do you want some orange juice?

Catra's chest still hurts. "Uh, yeah." She takes the glass, unable to take her eyes off Adora now. "Thanks."

She's oblivious to Catra's stares, so she makes no efforts to not do it. "How is your leg?"

"Hurts, but." Catra feels her face reddening again thinking about the massage. She didn't want to remind Adora, but she should say thank you. "I think your massage helped, so...thanks."

"I can try again later if you want." Ba-dup. Did she mean that in a sexy way? Or was Catra just hearing what she wanted?

The idea of Adora massaging her thighs again put a tingle up her spine. "Sure." Adora put a plate in front of her at the table. She seemed guarded almost, like she was trying to keep her distance. "Aw uh, look at you being all domestic."

She smirked. "You know me -wifey material." Yes. You really are.

Catra took a sip of her juice. "So...what're we gonna do today?"

Adora finished making her own toast -dry except for butter -and sat down. "Well, I'm technically off duty, but I'm sure I'll hear from somebody this afternoon. I would like to review some more information at some point, but otherwise...I'm just stuck babysitting you."

"I should warn you. You may not have time to do any work. I'm a handful."

"Oh, I know." But I fit in your hands so well…

"I'll have you know that I expect a very fun-packed afternoon. Mac n' cheese and ice cream for dinner, games, fort-building -the works." She leaned over, chin in her hand. "Oh, and I shouldn't be left unsupervised in the bath."

Adora sipped her coffee, doing an excellent job of almost hiding her response. "Do whatever you want, as long as you stay out of trouble."

Catra smirked, imagining all the ways they could get into trouble alone together. She held up her hand, three fingers up. "Scout's honor."

"Tsh. Please. You were never a girl scout!"

"I might as well have been. I'm really good at getting people to pay for what I've got." She winked, enjoying the glow it brought to Adora's cheeks. Whenever she blushed like that, her eyes and her lips always stood out more against the fair, cream color of her skin.

"How did you end up working there?"

Catra shifted in her seat a little, finishing her orange juice. "After I… She couldn't bring herself to say left. "...When I first moved here, I moved in with some random people in this janky little apartment cause I just needed somewhere to stay." She was looking for disapproval in Adora's face, but didn't find any. Adora was just listening. "I was looking for a job, but didn't see anything that I wanted to do. Everything sounded so, so boring -or demeaning. There's no way I was going to push grocery carts for the rest of my life."

She took a bite of toast before continuing. "I was dancing along a trail in the park one day." Adora's eyes seemed to be going through her, like she could see her memories, see her dancing. "...a woman who works at the club was there, behind me, I guess. She stopped me and we just talked for a while. She'd asked what I did and I told her I was looking for work. She brought me in and had me dance for Rob." Adora's hand gripped her mug a bit tighter at the name. Yeah, I suppose she doesn't like him. "Next thing I know, I'm making four hundred bucks a night -cold, hard, untaxed, cash."

Adora sighs. "Yeah, I could see the appeal, I guess. That explains the car....and the apartment."

"Really, no comment about the tax-free bit? I was sure you'd have a spiel for me about doing my civic duty to pay my way, or some bullshit like that."

She shrugged. "I work for the police, not the IRS. Besides, anyone who thinks they can get YOU to follow their rules is kidding themselves."

"You're finally starting to see things my way."

Adora smiled into her coffee mug. "You're such a brat."

"Yeah, and? What're you gonna do about it? Punish me?" She gets up and brings her dishes to the sink.

Adora takes another sip from her coffee. "Eh, I've thought about it." It surprised Catra. Adora sounded so serious. But fuck that, she couldn't back down now.

"Ha! I'd like to see you try." She leaned up against the counter, trying to keep the upper hand.

Adora stood with her own dishes. "I mean, the handcuffs are upstairs." Shit. She still sounded so matter-of-fact. "I could just cuff you to a piece of furniture and leave you there for the day. You'd be a lot easier to handle that way." Catra's thoughts immediately went to the bed frame, goosebumps rising on her skin. Adora didn't seem to notice, thankfully.

She didn't know what to say back so she just quietly rinsed her dishes and put them in the dishwasher. They ended up playing a couple board games -Sorry and Trouble, and one other that Catra had never heard of. Apparently the two people Adora lived with were real game fanatics. Catra was too, just not these kinds of games. It had been years since Catra played a board game with anyone. It

was nice - just to talk and play with her . It felt simple, real. She could do stuff like this every day and be perfectly content...just probably not with anyone else…

Uno ended for the fifth time and Catra threw her cards down. "Let's play something else."

"You're just upset because you lost."

"Exactly ."

"Okay fine. What do you want to do now?" Hmm...What did she really miss? What havent they done in a long time?

"Do you still have beer?"

Adora furrows her eyebrows. "Yeah. Why?"

"Lets play the Top Gun drinking game."

Adora laughs and Catra feels it all over. "No way . I've seen that movie too many times because of you."

"It's fun!"

"There are faster ways to get drunk."

Catra lays down on the floor. "But none are oh-so-entertaining as Tom Cruise's center-tooth. C'mooooon. Pleaaaase?"

"We really dont have that much beer ."

"Well what do you have?"

She followed Adora into the kitchen. Drunk Adora was so fun. Rum, Teqila, Vodka. "Yeah, thatll do. But..." She spun around, looking for something else. "Popcorn?"

“And Isuppose you werent kidding about that ice cream either?” Catra batted her eyes. Adora sighed. “Y eah, yeah. f Igive the mouse a cookieDo you know how many calories this is gonna be?”

“Dont know , dont care.”

“W ell, not all of us have magic metabolisms.”

Catra rolled her eyes, lifting Adora’s shirt up over her flat stomach, the ridges of her abs very visible. “I think.” She let her hand back down slowly, brushing the back of it against Adora’s skin. “Y oure fine.” So, so fine. “Y oull work it of f.”

So Catra made them both drinks and Adora made popcorn, reminiscing about the last time they did this together. Surprise, surprise, Adora gets drunk first -as usual. Catra feels bubbly next to her -nervous even. “They’re so close. “The only way she can seem to express herself is by throwing popcorn or yelling, “Drink, bitch!” Then when the alcohol actually hits, she feels like her body is being pulled towards the blonde. She cant fight it -like a magnet.

Catra’s hand slowly makes its way closer to Adora’s on the couch, testing the waters. “Their pinkies touch. Adora is pretending not to notice. After a lot of strained staring at the screen and trying not to look at each other, their fingers lace together. For a moment, it feels nice -Catra’s content. But very shortly after, it’s not enough and the space between them is suffocating again. She needs Adora’s attention more than anything.

Say something. Anything. “Y ou still cant handle your alcohol for shit.” Not that. Oh well.

“I can too.”

“Y oure already like sinking into the couch.” It was true, Adora was very relaxed into her seat.

“It’ s cause Im comfy .”

"And drunk."

"So what? It's my first day off in like...forever."

Good for her. That sounded about right. It wasn't like Adora to take a break..like...ever. "And you're stuck here with me?"

Their eyes met for the first time since the morning and Catra almost moves forward to kiss her. Kissing her sounds so good right now..."Ah, you're not so bad."

"What a compliment. "Catra knows how to get what she wants. "Let me make it up to you. I'll get you another drink.

She went to the kitchen, vaguely aware of Adora's eyes following her backside. The alcohol was egging her on -push just a little bit. See if she pushes back. She returned, glass in hand, straddling Adora on the couch. "Catra...what are you." She took a big swig from the glass and brought her lips onto Adora's. She drank it and Catra pulled away, trying to keep an innocent face. "It's good right?"

Adora's eyes were relaxed and darkened just a little with unspoken desire, glued to Catra's lips. Catra wiped the single drop that escaped from Adora's mouth with her thumb and licked it off. Her voice dropped. "Do you want some more?"

"Yeah." Adora nods.

Catra repeated it, pulling away a bit slower this time. It was almost like she could FEEL Adora giving in. It was delicious. "Again?"

Adora's hands came to rest gently over her hips. She couldn't tell whether Adora was trying to push her off or hold her in place -it felt like both. With Adora, that usually was the case. She never knew what she wanted -or at least, she was never willing to vocalize it. Adora just nodded this time in response without saying anything. As she went to swallow, Catra flicked her tongue over Adora's lower lip, prompting her lips to part. Adora chases after her as she pulls away.

Keep it together, Catra. Just reel her in. She eyed the glass. "Uh, oh." She swallowed the last of its contents. "All gone."

There was only slight disappointment in Adora's eyes, but for the most part, there was struggle. Catra could tell she was debating with herself again. To kiss, or not to kiss. Just be mine, Adora. Let go. It's just us here. Ope -determination flashed across her face. Here we go, she's going to push me away-

The kiss was surprisingly relaxed -still-cold lips and tongues languidly exploring each other, reclaiming territory lost throughout time apart. Catra relaxes against Adora, letting her hands run over the muscles of her shoulders to the back of her neck. Her thigh is complaining about being stretched, but this feeling is the only thing that matters -more than breathing. Adora's hands roam her back, pinning them together. One slides lower and gropes her ass, digging her fingers into the flesh at the side of her hip. Catra loved her hands there. Adora kisses her neck, over her jaw and then down. When her tongue lulls over Catra's collar bone she inhales at the sensation in her belly. And then…

Adora stops and pushes her away. "What. Why did you stop?" Catra feels breathless. God, I'm horny . Please. Put your conscience away, Adora -whatever it's telling you. .

"We can't."

She tries to lean in again. "Oh, but we can." Adora turns her head to the side, keeping one hand on her chest to continue pushing on her, keeping them too close and too far apart at the same time. Come ON

"No. We can't."

She was so fucking irritating. "Why? Why are you so afraid to admit that you want me?

Adora looked a little hurt, which was only more frustrating. "Why are YOU?" Catra stopped. She hadn't expected that. It's obvious why she couldn't be the one to admit that.

"I'm not scared of anything."

"Bullshit."

"It's not."

"Well... I'm not scared either."

"Liar."

"Am not."

"Are too."

And in that moment they both realized how childish they sounded - like they were eight years old again, bickering about who would jump down the stairs first. They laughed, comfortable only for a moment before the tension settled back down between them, electrifying the air. Catra did still want her. Bad. So bad. But how to get Adora to say it first…

"Fine. We'll play for it."

Adora shook her head. "I don't know how."

"I thought you just said you're not afraid?"

"I'm not."

She made a chicken noise. "Then why not just humor me?"

"Because you have a sick sense of humor."

Catra could already tell she was winning. "Mm, but don't you even want to know what it is?"

Adora rolled her eyes. "Fine. What."

"It's a word game."

"A word game?"

She got off of Adora, slowly. "Yup. Whoever says the words first, loses."

"What words?"

"Do you have a pen and paper?"

"Why don't you just tell me?"

"If I say it out loud, the game will be ruined. I can't just say it."

Adora got up and returned from the kitchen with a little pen and pad, handing it over to Catra suspiciously. 'I want you'. She hands it to Adora, expecting another lengthy mental debate.

"Done." She holds out her hand for Catra to take, a very serious expression on her face. Catra tilts her head. Huh? She expected a LOT more hesitation. There was none -absolutely no hint of uncertainty.

"You haven't even heard the rules yet." She must REALLY want to hear me say those words...

"Done." She just repeats herself, doubling down. She raises her eyebrows and looks at her hand as if to say, 'are you gonna shake on it, or not?'

Catra takes it cautiously, now trying to think of how she can create rules to make this game work in her favor. "We each have five minutes to get the other person to say it."

"That's it? What's the catch?"

"We get to make our own rules for the other. No questions asked." For good measure she adds, "Youngest goes first."

"That's a stupid rule. You're the youngest."

"Exactly."

"Whatever. I'll take your bet, and raise you." She bent down and scribbled something else on the pad. "I need you.' "...this."

Catra grabs Adora's hand and they shake on it. It's done. Yes. This would be so fun -and so easy. Adora was already liquored up, inhibitions lowered. "Great." She had to admit though, Adora's blind confidence had her ever so slightly intimidated. It would pass.

Catra points to the kitchen chair. "That would be perfect. Be a doll and carry that upstairs for me?" Adora makes a confused face, but does what she's asked.

They get in the room. "Where are those handcuffs?"

Adora hesitates, now looking a bit wary. "That's right. This is MY game. Adora walks over to her desk and opens a drawer, holding the metal cuffs to her body, almost as if she were protecting them. "Why do you need these?"

Catra wagged her finger. "Ah, ah, ah. No questions asked. Hand 'em over."

"These are real, you know. They're not toys."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Yeah, yeah. We get it. You're dick is soooo big. Lemme have 'em." Adora passed them off slowly -irked. Catra admired the cool metal in her hands, increasingly more excited at the prospect of having Adora helpless and desperate to touch her. She eyed Adora and then glanced back at the chair. "Sit." Oooh, Adora did not like this. Catra smiled. "Go on, unless you're too scared to play."

Adora stepped back, easing herself down into the chair, keeping her eyes on Catra as she walked around the back of it. "Hands, please."

She made a sound of annoyance but complied again. Catra started to fasten the cuffs. "Are you sure you know what-" Oh, she knew EXACTLY what she was doing.

She finished cuffing them together behind the chair, reaching around to grab Adora's face, tilting her head back. She gave her a chaste kiss. "No talking -except, of course, if you're ready to end the game. Then you know what you have to say." She sauntered around to the front again. Adora was staring after her intently. Really? "My rules, remember? You'll get your turn -if you can hold out." Fine.'

She opened the music app on her phone and chose a playlist called "privacy." Adora was going to buckle so hard. The thought of hearing her whisper those words again was so sweet, she could hardly stand it. "And, one more: You have to keep your eyes open the whole time." No cheating. I want you to look at me when you finally let go. She sits down on top of Adora again, whispering against her cheek in the low tone she knows drives her wild. Adora's swallow is all the affirmation she needs to know she's got this in the bag. Poor baby. Adora can't stand it when she can't touch. Too bad. "5 minutes, starts...now." She hits play and turns the volume all the way up, starting to whine her hips around. Adora's already chewing on her lip. Catra laughs, feeling like she's on top of the world. As long as she's on top of Adora, she IS on top of the world.

The main beat thumps and she starts to punctuate the rhythm with her body, always on beat. Adora's entranced. Catra backbends to the floor, her bruised thigh complaining as she flexes and bends her leg, rolling onto her back and grinding up off the floor like a wave - fluid and powerful. She's throwing her legs apart, running her hands across her torso, ebbing and flowing. She was daring Adora to say the words just as much with her eyes as she did with her body -it could happen at any moment. But Adora was trying so hard to be good, clenching her jaw to keep her mouth closed. Can't have that, can we? Let's play a little...dirty. She made her way around the back

of the chair, dropping her body down against Adora's hands -a heavy breath escaped as Catra felt Adora's fingers pressing against her wetness, searching for blind contact. She immediately came back up around the chair with nothing but cruel intentions.

A little bit longer staying just out of reach, focused on the throbbing reds and purples guiding her hips, telling her when the perfect time to give a little pop was -twerk a little here, throw it back a couple times there, to the side, wind down, make her chest do circles -and the colors were never wrong. She could hear Adora's ragged breathing behind her, but whenever she glanced back, she still had that determined look. Come on. Ihave to win. Just give up already…

Fine. Iknow how to make you say it. She sits on Adora' s lap, turned away, pressing her ass back into her hips. Adora pushes up to meet her. A soft groan escapes through clenched teeth at the pressure. Catra smiles. Reverse cowgirl always turned Adora into a blubbering idiot. Her hands fall on Adora's thighs and she starts to move like she's fucking herself down on Adora's toy. She hears Adora whine. Fuck, this feels good though -it's making her wet. She does it a little harder and Adora lets out what could have been described as a growl. Oof, you want it BAD, Princess...yeah, but so do you. Come on, Adora. Just say it. Make this less painful for both of us.

She doesnt. Catra was getting a little freaked now -the timer was going to go off soon. She had to get her to say it. Thirty seconds. She turns around, grinding together with Adora, both breathing hard. "Dont you want me to ride you again?"She' s running her hands through Adora's hair, pulling her ponytail loose. Twenty. "Just tell me you want me. Ill un-cuf f you and you can take me to bed."Adora whines again. God she's so hot worked up like this. But still nothing. Shit. Fifteen. She nibbles Adora's earlobe, and moans, "Please"? Adora opens her mouth and closes it again. Goddammit!T en. "Adora, please"?Ne. Just fucking say it!Five. "T ell me what you want."

Ring. The alarm goes of f. t' s over. Shit.

Adora lets out a very long and shaky exhale. "What I.. want is for you..." her voice is strained and out of sorts. "...to stop being such... a goddamn, selfish, BRAT." Catra sat up a little straighter . Adora almost looked angry, but also so...so hungry, and very...determined to prove something. "Un-cuf f me." It was not a qestion.

Catra's confidence faltered. "I dunno. I think I kind of like you like th-"

"Un. Cuf f. Me." Heat pooled between Catra' s legs. She remembered her taunt earlier, What're you gonna do, punish me? Please. A shiver of excitement moved through her.

"Fine."

She grabbed the key off Adora's nightstand and unfastened one of the cuffs. Adora immediately brought her arms in front of her, rubbing the free wrist. "Key , please." Catra handed it to her and watched as she took the other cuff off. She looked so calm, but her cheeks were still so red and her fingers shook a little. What kind of rules would she make up? Pools of blue fell heavy on her , drowning her other thoughts.

"My turn."

Once a Brat, Always a Brat

Chapter Summary

Resolution of the game...but it's literally just porn -sorry (I really didn't mean to...but also, yes?)

Chapter Notes

I really don't know what happened. I had meant for this chapter to be so much more, but it just kind of happened this way. If they weren't so damn hot, it would be different. I guess, to be fair though, there IS some important emotional fluff mixed in there, but honestly, if you aren't all about the smut, just skip it. There will be more "pure" quality fluff later, I promise.

"Don't think that just because I couldn't get you to say it, I'll lose." Adora's eyes locked onto hers, and there was just one brief moment of 'oh shit' that flashed over Catra's face before Adora's hands were on her. They grabbed the front of her button up shirt and pulled, sending buttons flying, scattering across the room. She didn't even care. She could buy another one. What she couldn't do was let this moment, this opportunity, go. Catra gasped as Adora moved in close, putting their foreheads together, yanking the shirt down off her arms as she backed Catra against the bed, chest to chest.

Adora snaked one hand down to grab Catra's ass. "Up." She helped lift the bad side up onto the bed with ease.

She walked to her closet again and dug around the small box at the back corner. Catra's eyelids fell just a bit heavier when she saw what Adora held -a little black silk eye mask and a long scarf that Catra had been acquainted with many times years ago. She was trying to appear calm and collected, holding herself up on her hands, but Adora could tell she was excited. "So...what are the rules?" She had

such a beautiful body...lithe with a soft hourglass figure, lean but still supple in all the right ways...her nipples were already so hard…

"Put this on."Adora handed her the black mask. Catra took it gingerly.

"Kinky ."

You like it. Adora grabbed the handcuffs from the edge of the bed. "Now hold out your hands."

Catra slowly raised her arms, inhaling sharply as the cold metal clamped around her wrists. Adora watches goosebumps rise up to her shoulders, careful not to make them too loose or too tight. "Move back."She throws the key to the end of the bed.

"I can't see, dipshit, and now my hands are tied."There' s nothing but fondness in her tone, almost like spoken promises of future kisses. A slight upward curve of her mouth tells Adora she's still just hellbent on making this difficult. Fine. Adora scoops her up and moves her, pulling her up onto her knees facing away from the headboard. Catra inhales again, probably because of the stretch on her thigh. Eh, this will be good for it. Adora ties the scarf around the cuff chain and moves behind Catra, passing it between her knees and starting to pull. "Hey!Wha-"She huf fs as Adora pulls her arms down between her legs, causing her to fall face first into the bed. She turns her head to the side to be heard. "W -hat are you doing?"

"No questions, remember?"Adora ties the scarf to the slats in the head board.

"Okay but you have to at least tell me the rules."Adora is mesmerized at the sight of her like this -ass up, blindfolded, tied to the bed.

"There are no other rules, just you and me and the clock."

"T -that's it?"

"Yep." Adora got off the bed. She had no intention whatsoever of setting an alarm. This wasn't about a stupid game. This was about her and Catra. It was about making Catra acknowledge once and for all that she wanted Adora just as much as Adora wanted her. "Ready. Set. Go."

Just let her sit there for a bit in the silence and the absence of sight. Adora watched and counted to twenty as Catra slowly started losing her cool demeanor. She was fidgeting with her hands and her breathing had become uneven. "Hello?...Adora, I swear to God...if-if you just leave me here like this"...

"Relax, Catra. I'm not going anywhere."

"What, are you just gonna...stare at me the whole time?" Adora felt pleased with herself. Catra was secretly loving this. This was an excellent idea. It felt good to be in control like this - no wonder Catra liked it so much. She walked to the side of the bed so she could get a little closer.

"Maybe." Catra huffed in response. "I mean...you look REALLY good like this." She was blushing. "Why? Is there something you'd rather I do?"

She huffed again. "No. Liar. "I just...this is just a really fucking weird way to try and flex." "Maybe, but it's totally working.

Adora let her elbows touch down on the bed so she could whisper in Catra's ear. "I guess I just couldn't let you forget how big my dick is." Catra shuddered and bit her lip.

She tried to force a laugh. "You're such a f-reak, Adora."

"Says the one tied up." Adora raised her arm and let two fingers barely trace Catra's side from her ribs to her hip. Catra sort of jumped at the contact, gasping again, but then immediately melted. Adora stood and climbed in the bed behind her. "Catra, look at you." Her hands fell to Catra's calves and stroked up the back of

her thighs, feather-light, all the way up to her spandex. Catra jerked again. She's so fucking soft...She has perfect skin…

"You love this, don't you?" Then she reached forward and pet from between Catra's shoulder blades, all the way down her spine, enjoying the way her body arched under her fingertips. The hand finally came to rest firmly on the side of Catra's hip, pulling her back as she pushed her pelvis forward. Catra whined, grinding back on her in little circles. Shit. Adora pushed harder and the brunette responded again, spreading her knees wider and arching her back for more contact where she no doubt wanted it the most. Adora's other hand took hold of her waist to keep pulling her back and they just moved together like that for a bit, until the heat was undeniable and Catra's breath hitched with every thrust of her hips.

"You like that?" Catra just nodded against the bed. "I can tell. Catra, you're soaked." Another small sound escaped from her throat. Adora was starting to feel more and more like a caged animal. She just hoped her patience would hold long enough to make Catra throw her goddamn pride aside...

Her fingers played with the top of the black shorts. "You'd like it better without these though, right?" Catra hesitated but gave another small nod. Good. Adora scooted back to give her space. "Go ahead. Take them off if you want." She hesitated for a moment, making a small noise of frustration. Her hands tried to pull against the scarf but didn't get far.

"My hands."…

"What about them?"

"I can't reach." Catra's voice sounds so good like this -so desperate. "...asshole."…

"That's okay. The spandex can stay on."

"Adora smiles. She's caving. "I...I want them off...will you take them off...please?"

Adora grabs the waistband of the shorts and starts to pull as Catra brings her legs together to allow the shorts to come down. Adora stares, watching the muscles of her legs as she goes up on her toes and kicks the shorts off, settling back down into that same vulnerable position. Now she's totally naked and spread open, begging for attention. She's so. Fucking. Wet. In the light of day, Adora can really see her piercing -a short metal bar that passes through the hood of her clit. She didn't hate it...What would that feel like on my tongue?...

She catches herself just before her mouth makes contact -Catra's already moaning in anticipation of the heat. She tries to bridge the gap when she realizes it's not happening. Adora keeps that inch between them, clinging onto that last shred of control. But she smells so good. Adora's mouth waters remembering how she tastes.

"Adora." It's been too long since she heard Catra say her name like that. It muddles her insides. "Adora, please"…

"Yes Catra?" She blows air lightly and Catra pulls at the scarf more.

"Come on! Just fucking...touch me!..please."

Adora smiles again. "Okay. Roll onto your back." Catra whimpers, hesitating for a moment before throwing her legs over her head so she's laying down, hands pulled overhead. It looks like her arms are being pulled a bit too hard. "Move up a little bit."

Adora moves next to her, careful not to touch her again, and counts to twenty, letting Catra squirm. "Adora! Come on...please...."

Adora watches the heavy rise and fall of Catra's chest for a few more breaths before letting her hands wander. She draws imaginary shapes over her collar bones, up her neck, down the sides breasts and finally, down past her navel, over her hip bones. Catra's stomach twitches every time her fingers touch the crease of her thigh. She's

pulling on the scarf, whining with her mouth open, back arching off the bed to meet Adora's touch as she moves back up her torso towards her chest. Adora finally turns her attention to Catra's dusky nipples. "Yes! Fuck, yes..." Her voice is so sexy when it cracks like that...

Adora's mouth followed shortly after and turned Catra into a nearly-sobbing, mewling mess -twisting and writhing against the air. "Adora, I can't...I can't take anymore -PLEASE!"

"What do you want, Catra?"

Her hand drifted lower on Cara's abdomen, settling right on top of the small rectangular patch of trimmed hair. Catra's hips immediately rose and tilted, attempting to slide Adora's hand lower, but she didn't let it. Catra growled. "Fuckin' bitch!"

She teased two fingers just above Catra' s clit and she cried out. "What do you want Catra?"

Without warning, she easily slips two fingers inside and curls them. She knows Catra's eyes are rolling back. The groan that tears from her throat is deeply satisfying.

But she doesn't give Catra the chance to really appreciate it, immediately pulling out again. Catra kicks her legs and her hips chase after Adora's fingers -she sobs. "You can't fucking DO this!.. I hate you!..You know what I need!"

Adora rubs her now-slick fingers around Catra's nipple, watching her stomach muscles clench. She's so worked up..."You want me to do it again?"

She whimpers, nodding. "Please...Adora, please...." Adora doesn't think she's ever heard Catra say the word 'please' this many times.

She moves over her, settling between Catra's legs, which part for her to get closer -and slides down, kissing along Catra's midline as she

goes. As soon as she's low enough, Adora gives a few sweeping licks from Catra's dripping center up to her clit -her knees immediately close over Adora's head as the only way to hold her there and she cries out. Adora targets the sensitive nub, intrigued by the feel of the piercing moving against her tongue -it feels hot. Did Catra feel that heat? Adora just needed to take her to the very edge...and keep her there.

She gets an arm underneath her body and slides two fingers back into Catra, curling and pulling against that spot, continuing to flick her tongue. Adora feels her tighten immediately. "JESUS F-" Her legs shake harder and her cries escalate as she keeps Adora's head pinned between her thighs. "Adora, wait -I-" Her voice cracks as she yelps. "...you're gonna make me fucking squirt!" Not yet, I'm not. In one motion, she pulls her fingers from Catra and pushes herself out from between Catra's legs. She sobs again between heavily-breathed words. "No! Adora, cant..." She's pressing her thighs together, desperate for pressure and friction there.

Adora gets off the bed and Catra seems to panic at the loss of another body's weight. "You-you cant go! Dont l-leave me like this! Please, Adora. Please..." She seemed genuinely afraid that Adora might be leaving. For a moment, Adora felt guilty about pushing Catra so far just to pull back again. She knew that torture. After all, that's exactly what Catra did for the entirety of their teenage years… but Adora wasnt that cruel. She stripped off her clothes and went back to the closet.

Her voice was soft. "Patience." I'm not going anywhere, Catra. "Patience." She was convincing herself of the virtue just as much as Catra.

Catra whined again -her only response -still panting. Once Adora has the toy in its harness, she returns to the bed, crawling over Catra again. This strapon was a bit bigger than their old one, but she was sure Catra would enjoy it...she's definitely wet enough. Catra seemed to still at the return of Adora's weight on the mattress, spreading her legs for Adora to settle between them again. She

doesn't miss the shudder that rolls through Catra when the toy touches her stomach as she lets body down on top Catra's. Resting an arm on either side of Catra's head, she pulls the eye mask up, revealing two different, very teary, and heavy eyes. Catra really had been afraid that she was going to just walk away ...She places soft kisses all around her jaw , up her cheek to her lips to lay claim. Catra is all the more needy, whimpering and biting at Adora's lips, but she controls the pace -slow and possessive. She pulls away, resting her forehead on the brunette's. "I wanna fuck you Catra." She presses her hips against Catra's sex, and Catra presses back, moaning.

Her voice is shaking as she does. "I need you, Adora. Please...I need you."

Adora's heart throbs with her body -that's all she ever wanted to hear. One hand slides between them to line the head up with Catra's opening as her lips fall again on Catra's mouth, halfway smothering the cry she let out when Adora pushes, hilting herself inside. "Mngh! Is that okay?"

Catra's walls are resisting the motion as Adora starts to pull out again. Her eyes are shut, eyebrows furrowed. "It feels fuckin huge"…

Adora smiles against her mouth. "I told you I had a big dick."

"You're such -MMMH!" Adora pushes in again, a bit faster this time, causing Catra to lose her words. So beautiful...and that's it. That's as long as Adora's mental will power would hold out. The cage is busted and the animal is out. She NEEDS to make Catra feel like she'll never feel anything like this again -to give her the euphoria she's been dying to have. Adora increases her pace, and, in a matter of what seems like seconds, she's found that perfect rhythm. Catra's mewling again, rising to meet every thrust, and trying to stifle her cries by biting her own shoulder.

Adora uses a hand to tilt her chin so that Catra's barely-open eyes meet hers, pulling her mouth away from her arm. "It's just you and me now." Nobody expects anything of us. We don't have to hide

anymore. "I want to hear you." Almost as if the words themselves touch her, Catra's eyes close and her face twists in pleasure, another strained and throaty groan escaping. "That's it."

Adora's hand slides down over Catra's throat, her fingers squeezing gently as she starts to thrust harder. "FUCK." Soon the only noises are the sounds of their bodies slapping together, ragged breathing, and Catra's curses and prayers.

Her first orgasm is maddeningly quiet - Adora only knows it's happening because Catra goes rigid for a moment before her hips continue jerking uncharacteristically out of sync. That just won't do. She pulls out and her hand leave's Catra's throat and moves to her calf. "Put your legs over my shoulders." Catra easily does it. Adora wastes no time, practically diving back into Catra, pushing deeper with this angle - the upward curve of the toy was no double berating Catra's g-spot.

"..my god...feels so fucking good Adora." I love when you say my name. Catra's voice is almost as good as when her nails drag down Adora's back - it makes her tighter, egging her on. She feels a bead of sweat run down her temple as she rams her hips into Catra. She's panting and her thighs are burning - it's been a long time since she's really fucked somebody - but she doesn't care. The only thing that matters is that sexy fucking look on Catra's face, the way her perfect tits bounce...how goddamn hard her legs are starting to shake, the fevered pitch of her voice…

"I'm-gon-na fuck-ing cum!" That's it. Please. Every word comes out choppy, punctuated by hard thrusts. "A-dor-AHHH!" Catra throws her head back in abandon, squealing as her body starts to convulse. She squirts all over Adora's belly and thighs, dripping all over the sheets. Fuck yes. I want her . I want her completely . I want her everything.

Adora pulls out to let Catra's legs down and unlock her hands from the cuffs. Catra lets her hands sort of fall lamely to her sides, still panting, coming down from her high. Adora wipes a single tear from

her cheek and Catra starts to laugh breathlessly, bringing the back of her hand to her mouth. Adora thinks she's never seen something so beautiful -her hair strewn all over the pillows, freckles faint over flushed cheeks, lips almost swollen against the back of her hand from the intensity of their kisses…

"What' s so funny?" Adora kisses the end of her nose.

"I can't feel my toes...or my lips." Her eyes open and take hold of Adora's heart as her perfectly manicured hands move to hold the side of Adora's face. "What did you do to me?" The smile fades but the softness remains in her eyes as they both remember that first time together.

Adora's throat feels tight -all she can manage is a strained whisper. "I don't know ...but I'd like to do it again."

Her eyes are searching Catra's for the answer, even though she already knows. Catra doesn't have to say it out loud, but-

"I want you."

There is a moment' s pause and the world stops just long enough for Adora to comprehend Catra's expression. She's stricken, absolutely frozen dumb, with the realization that the tenderness there isn't saying 'I want you' at all. It' s the call back she never got; it' s a quiet whisper in the middle of the night. 'I love you too.'

Really?

Really ...What are you waiting for?

Catra's eyebrows twitch together as Adora moves in to kiss her - slower now, more carefully. Catra's arms wrap around her and their bodies melt together. I want this every night...Catra breaks away , breathless, and bites Adora's ear, moaning. "Fuck me, Adora." She rakes her nails gently down Adora's back, making her shudder.

And just like that, she feels out of control again. She rocks into Catra, but this time it's slow and full and she's determined to milk every last gasp from Catra's gorgeous lips into her ear. Adora controls the pace, pulling out so the head catches her opening and rolling all the way back in, waiting for Catra to get needy and squirmy underneath her. One hand moves to her breast to play with a stiff nipple and she cries out a little louder, grinding her hips back up to meet Adora's.

"You're so sensitive"…

"Harder , Adora." Fuck. She sounds so good. Her body obeys without thinking and Catra whimpers in her ear. "Yeah, like that...just like that."

It doesn't take long before Adora's slamming her hips against Catra's, desperate to get her off again. She can tell by the way Catra's nails are scratching at her shoulders that she's getting close again. "Cum for me."

Adora reaches her arms underneath the brunette to grab her ass and hold her in place, pulling their bodies together every time. "Adora...faster , please." Anything. Anything for you. Adora's phone starts to go off -it's her work ringtone. It was probably her casemates looking to fill her in. Fuck them. This is the only thing that matters. Catra's panting is reaching that fevered pitch again, driving Adora absolutely wild. Adora's legs try to comply with her pleas. Her phone doesn't stop. It's probably important.

"Nn -nn- mmfuuck...I'm-so-tight." Oh god. "Yes!"

Her hips move in a desperate, erratic rhythm. Please. Catra's scratching and mewling is also drifting towards madness. "Adora, I'm-" Yes. Her body quakes again, lost in the throes of pleasure. Adora watches her struggle with sanity, slowing her thrusts to let her come gently back down to earth. Her phone stops and for a moment there's just peace and they're comfortable in the intimacy . But then it starts to ring again.

"Goddammit." Adora pulls out and rolls off of Catra, who makes an upset sound and chases after her.

"No, come back! Adora. Don't answer it. Stay with me." Her pouty face is to die for right now...

She grabs the phone, doing her best to sound like she hasn't been running a very long, very dirty marathon. "Ether." Catra flops down on the bed with a grumpy hmph.

"We spoke to our person today." It was Huntara.

"And?" Catra had turned around and was face down again on the bed...doing...something so...good with her hips. Oh fuck...her pussy was still twitching from that last orgasm.

The mental fog -which hadn't quite cleared -set back in with a vengeance. Adora barely registered the voice on the other line. "...not gonna believe....didn't know anything about." Catra spread her legs into a perfect split, rolling her hips back and forth. Jesus, she was so flexible. Adora couldn't think about anything other than how Catra would look stretched around the toy like that...

Catra looked back over her shoulder, running her hands over her ass. "Yeah, yeah, hey." As if she could even spread herself any more... "Listen... I'm gonna have to call you back." Catra smiled that wicked grin, churning Adora's insides. You win, brat.

"What? Ether, you-"

"Ten minutes." Click.

Head's Up

Chapter Summary

Gotcha!

I bet those of you who are subscribed to this work were super excited when you clicked on this -sorry! I'm in the middle of life shtuff that's taking precedence right now but I am still working on this! I just wanted to give everyone a heads up about how this is all gonna go, 'cause I'm gonna be mean, but I think you'll all like it? *shrug* Eh.

It seems like people are really digging this universe and these characters (so am I, trust me) and would like it to continue. For whatever reason -probably because I'm a sucker for anxty teenage romance- I've currently got a lot of inspiration for these characters' history together. SO...I'm going to write one or two more in this as "part 1" of the series (warning: it WILL be a cliffhanger, because if you've read any of my other stuff, you know how I like my cliffhangers). Part 2 will be their childhood and teenage years which will read like a prequel. Then, part 3 will FINALLY be the end you've all been waiting for :) I make no promises that it will turn out the way you want though...*dramatic music* I'm in it for the long haul with this story sooooo if you're reading this...I hope you are too :)

What Am I Without You?

Chapter Summary

Adora goes back to work and Catra gets several phone calls.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

So many things at once -to say she was overwhelmed would be one hell of an understatement. She's both numb and painfully sensitive at the same time. All she can do is breathe and try not to stay blinded by the stars flashing wildly behind her eyelids. Her mouth feels dry from how long it's been open, gasping and panting and admitting every little feeling Adora was giving her except 'I love you'. She couldn't possibly say that now , otherwise her leaving would be for nothing -Adora would still get stuck with her when she deserved so much more. Catra wasn't sure if her chest was aching because she couldn't have Adora or because she couldn't have a turn making her fall apart.

The blonde was stepping out of the harness and setting it on the bedside table. Catra's eyes followed the flutter of muscles, licking her lips as she remembered how they felt on top of her. "My turn?"

Adora gave that apologetic look. "I have to call them back."

"And? All you need for that is your mouth." She smiled thinking about the delicious game of Don't-Moan-Into-the-Phone. "That leaves the rest of you for me."

Clipping on her bra, Adora smiled knowingly, blush rising to her already-pink cheeks. "We can play that another time."

Another time. Like...like this would happen again. Catra's heart fluttered but in her gut she felt a twinge of guilt. It shouldn't have

happened this time. She couldn't let it happen again -for both their sakes. But she can't bring herself to say anything right now . Instead, she just watches Adora get dressed, get ready to give way too much to everyone else. Catra could already see the gears working in her head, determination set in her jaw -she was thinking about fixing' something, righting the world's wrongs. Anyone else would have gotten mixed up in the corruption and stayed there, falling slaves to their own greed and gluttony, taking some bribe or other. But not Adora. She would march in the direction her moral compass pointed, no matter the terrain ahead -even if it meant walking right over a cliff.

"You know, you're probably the only good cop I've ever met."

Adora looked defensive. "I work with plenty of good people."

"I'm not saying they're shitty people. I'm saying not all of them do what they're supposed to do. Not everyone is as dedicated as you are."She takes a deep breath. "I feel like every other cop in this city somehow has their hands dirty."

Adora seems exasperated. "Catra, you can't know every cop in the city."

Tsh. "No, but I've seen enough of them in the club to know they aren't all good like you."Adora seemed to be getting annoyed, which made Catra annoyed. She was just trying to give Adora a freaking compliment, but now she felt like she had to defend herself -provide evidence. "Like your partner , the really big lady, shaved head." "Huntara?"Adora pulled on a suit jacket, furrowing her eyebrows. Catra wanted to rip her clothes off again already. Why did she look so damn good in a suit?

"Yeah."

"What about her?"

"She' s definitely been to the club more than once -spends half her time in private rooms."

"And Id spend all day with you in one of those if Icould, so what?" Catra smiles at the thought of spending all day giving Adora lapdances.

She shrugs, holding the sheet to her chest. "Nothing, Im just saying...youre one of the good ones." Adora clips her holster on her side, raising a red flag in Catras brain. "I thought you just had to call them back. Why do you need that?"

"Occupational hazard." The blonde walks over to her on the bed. "I already know theyre going to ask me to come in for something or other. Youll be safe here, so dont leave. There's plenty of food downstairs. Have whatever you want." You. Ijust want you. But she knows she cant have that. "Ill be back tonight." Adora holds Catra's cheek in her hand and Catra cant help but lean against it. Her lips plant soft kisses down her nose to Catra's mouth -she melts, wanting nothing more than to just keep Adora from leaving somehow . But soon Adora is out the door, already on the phone with somebody.

Catra flops back down on the bed, very quickly overtaken by the smell around her -it's familiar. It's Adora. Her blinks become heavier and she drifts slowly into sleep. Well, maybe not sleep, exactly. She's not awake but she's still thinking things -or, at least, she thinks she is. Thoughts are just allowed to flow freely in and out of her consciousness. She comes to some time later when her phone vibrates. Somebody is calling her. It's Rob. Nope. She puts her phone back down. A few minutes of staring silently at the ceiling later, it buzzes again. This time, from an unknown number . It could be Hordak. Her chest tightens a little. Then she remembers Stace telling her that she would call…

With a shaky finger, Catra swipes. She brings the phone to her ear but doesnt say anything, waiting for whoever is on the other line to speak. When she hears Stace's soft -and definitely female- voice, Catra lets out the air she had apparently been holding. "Catra? Honey, are you okay?"

"Stace, yeah I'm okay ." She subconsciously pat her stomach, almost assuring herself that she was okay, willing it to calm down.

"Thank God." It sounded like she was whispering. Why is she whispering? "Rob told me...well...I'm glad you got away ." Where was she? Had she gone back to work?

"I'm sure Hordak' s not happy."

"No." It was an ominous answer , flat and colt. Stace was definitely trying to keep her voice low. Catra's chest started to ache again thinking that this woman -the woman who for the last six years has stuck her neck out for Catra countless times, might be in trouble. "So that friend of yours is a cop?" How much trouble could she really be in if she's talking to me right now? But then again...what if Rob was there, listening in? What if Hordak was? She shivered at the thought.

"Y eah. Apparently she is."

"W ell stick with her."

That made her feel better , at least. If Rob was there, he'd probably be trying to get her to answer questions, get information from her . "What about you?"

"What about me?"

"Where are you?"

There was a pause. It was too long. "Don't you worry about me, baby. I'll be fine." No. That was horribly unconvincing.

"Stace-"

"I've gotta go." Click.

Goddammit! She had been so caught up in thinking about saving her own skin that she hadn't even considered what Stace might be up against if Hordak found out she'd encouraged her to run. Catra

drapes her arm over her eyes, willing them to not produce tears. No. Stace would be fine. She was scrappy and knew every trick in the book and she was resourceful... She always had a backup plan. She would be just fine. Maybe the two of them could go somewhere together and run their own place, just like they talked about. Stace always said she wanted a small club somewhere downtown -a classy place of her own where there was live music at night, maybe burlesque shows Catra didn't mind the sound of that. Still...it was going to be really hard to leave Adora again.

Even though she had only been back in Catra's life for, what...thirty-six hours? She felt more alive in the last couple days than she had in years. Sure, she was almost kidnapped, and that kind of rush tends to make people thankful to be alive and, you know, not sold into sex-slavery. But that's not why. Adora put color back in the world. She was beautiful and kind and smart and such a dork, and good. So good. Too good. And Catra was...not that. Adora deserved somebody who would be more than just a burden.

Her stomach growls and breaks the outward silence in the room, momentarily silencing the mental goodbye preparation. Oh yeah...I guess I haven't really eaten much today. She checks her phone. It's already almost five. How long did I sleep for? She gets up slowly, stretching and earning a couple pops from various joints, seeming to shock the stiffness away -everywhere except her leg. Some of it was absolutely her fault. She hadn't exactly been gentle on it today. A tingle ran up her spine remembering how desperate Adora seemed to please her. She only wished she could have returned the favor...

Catra finds what she can only assume is Adora's single casual T-shirt, and puts the spandex back on, making her way down the hall towards the stairs. She takes her time, looking at all the photos on the walls -her friends. There's a few of her with some other cops, dressed in that delicious blue uniform. As she gets lower on the stairs, the pictures are of Adora in various settings with a shorter pink-haired woman and a black guy wearing a crop top. She recognized them. They were with her at the club -they brought her

there to celebrate her promotion. Catra could tell from some of the pictures that these two liked to bring Adora out of her comfort zone. That's good. But there was still a pang of jealousy welling in her gut. That used to be Catra's job.

As she walked around the corner to look at a small black-framed photo on the adjacent wall, the jealousy mixed with some sadness and a dash of regret. It was Adora, standing in front of her university sign, holding up her diploma. That was the first milestone that Catra hadn't been there to celebrate with her. Since then, Adora's had these new people...she did just fine without me. Hell. She's been better without me.

"Uh...hi." A voice startled her, but thankfully she didn't jump. Her attention was drawn to the pink-haired girl from the photos, sitting at the counter eating some kind of taco salad.

Catra was able to keep her cool, only feeling slightly uncomfortable with the fact that she was in their house. "Hey."

"You must be Adora's." She seemed like she was struggling. How much do they know?

"Catra."

She nodded slowly. "Right, Catra. Hi. I'm Gillian, but most people just call me Glimmer."

Catra held in the comments about her name being 'Glimmer'. She slowly nodded in return. "Cool."

Silence. The other woman takes another bite and Catra contemplates just going back upstairs. It occurs to her that this woman might have heard them earlier. "We didn't know anyone else was home." Oh shit. Why did I say that?

Glimmer raises her eyebrows. She totally heard us. Yikes. "Yeah, I..I figured. I'm working from home today."

Catra just nods again. This all feels very forced and like walking on eggshells that are already broken, so there's no point. "Cute place you have here." She tries to make small talk anyways for no good reason. Part of her brain screams, just go back upstairs and wait for her to leave.

"Thanks. It's been really awesome. When college ended, we just couldn't bear the thought of going separate ways." Catra just stared. Who couldn't bear the thought? Adora? Or her and the crop-top boy? For some reason, Glimmer took her silence as a call for more explanation. "Adora and I got really close when my Mom died. She became such a strong support for me and...I know that having Bow and I there really made a difference for her too." Catra felt a twinge of jealousy - possessiveness. Fuck you. I've known her longer.

Why was this chick bringing up how close they were? What was she getting at? What do you mean? Made a difference for her, how?

"Oh well...I guess, she was just sort of a lone wolf when we first met. She didn't really talk to that many people." What? That didn't sound at all like Adora. "I think that's because she was so used to being involved in things growing up that she never really had to try to make friends on her own, so she was just a little awkward." Okay, that bit did sound like Adora. She was involved in anything and everything. "But mostly she was just burning the candle at both ends." As she always did.

"She's always done that."

"Yeah...it's just, she was training for the academy and starting her Master's program and then she was working and doing both and..." Catra hated how this girl could seem so genuine, and that she was being so...open right out the gate. "...she just...it was good for her to have somebody there to tell her to just stop and take a breath, you know?"

Oh, Catra knew. She used to be that person. How could this bitch talk to her like she didn't already know this about Adora -

HER...ex...everything. God, they were complicated. When Adora was studying for her driver's permit, she was in the middle of a difficult semester AND it was her first year as one of the captains of the track team. She was so stressed that she stopped sleeping. Catra lured her out to the old water tower by saying she needed to get picked up. Then she got Adora to chase her up to the top, where they had the most amazing view of the city. They stayed there and just talked, holding hands, until Adora fell asleep on her shoulder. Catra sat there, uncomfortable as hell for a couple hours just to let her nap. By the early morning, when Catra finally woke her so she could move her numb legs, she was able to calm her down.

"I think...she really missed you when you left." Oh. Not what she was expecting. "Sounds like it kind of turned her world upside down." Glimmer was speaking hesitantly, but Catra could still hear the accusation in her voice. It made her feel on edge.

"It wasn't exactly easy for me either."

"Then why did you do it?"

Fuck you. Mind your own goddamn business. Catra shrugged, feeling less and less in control of this conversation. She should have just gone upstairs. "I had my reasons, but that doesn't mean I didn't miss her too."

"Well you have a funny way of showing it." Okay. NOW she was really just being accusatory.

"Excuse me?"

"Leaving her on read for SEVEN YEARS." Shit. Okay. Adora told her about that? The guilt twisted in her gut again. "And then you just show up out of nowhere."

"I"

"Look." Something about her demeanor had changed. She wasn't aggressive, but confident, and so fucking obnoxious. "Over the last few years, I watched Adora grow from being closed-off and unsure to confident in who she is and proud of what she's capable of. I didn't understand why she was like that then, but I think I get it now." "You don't understand anything. "She gave you her heart and you threw it away." The room seemed to be getting just a bit smaller. "No wonder she was running herself into the ground when I met her. She was just trying to prove that she was good enough -to anyone, to herself - to YOU. She just wanted to be worth peoples' time."

Adora thought...Adora thought she left because she wasn't good enough? The pit in her stomach seemed to grow two-fold at the thought. It was the exact opposite! Adora was T OO good. Other way around. Catra was sparing her.

"But she's in a better place mentally now." Better because I've been gone. "She's not so hard on herself and she actually seems to recognize that she's worth more than just what people can get from her. So...it's great that you two have..." a flush of color warmed her cheeks. "...reconnected. I think it means a lot to her. But just... don't string her along." Catra feels her nails dig into her arm. "I don't want to see her get hurt. Again."

She was biting her tongue to keep from releasing a torrent of spiteful words onto this girl. Thankfully, the girl took her food and left without another word, just an expression that looked an awful lot like pity and Catra fucking despised that. She slides to the floor against a wall, the woman's words reverberating in her head. "No wonder she was running herself into the ground...she was trying to prove that she was good enough...she gave you her heart and you threw it away...on read for seven years'…

Did she really think that? Did Adora think Catra left because she wasn't good enough? W asn't worth it? How could she be so dumb? How could she be so completely and utterly oblivious? How could I? But...I did it for her. I left for her own good. I was trying to put her first

for once, after a lifetime of selfishness. I just wanted her to be able to be happy -to be free. She has to know that. She has to.

Catra wasn't hungry anymore. Her stomach still churned and twisted but it was out of a nauseating kind of guilt. She goes back upstairs, slowly, shrinking under the gaze of all the photographs lining the wall. Each step, a little smaller, like she was being crushed by the very weight of Adora's smile. The smile that she loved. Loves. Fuck. The smile that she apparently ruined for years. She was thankful to get away from the smiling people, closing the door safely behind her, she finally let tears fall. Another photo catches her eye though -it's a small picture on Adora's desk. It's her and Catra and Adora's mother, doing her Wonderful Madame Razbit. Catra's heart ached. Adora was so happy.
Catra put the photo face down on the desk. She felt slimy and like she needed another shower. Maybe that would work. She scrubbed her skin, which apparently she had needed, but it didn't work. All she removed was the dead skin. Shame, fear, regret, guild, and anxiety all remained -in her bones, it felt like. They made her body heavy and hard to keep upright. She leaned against the wall and let the water wash over her. This was all so messed up.

Catra numbly got out of the water when her feet started to hurt, like the tile underneath was encroaching on her somehow, still trying to compress her with the walls into a tiny little person -the person she felt like she was. Small and insignificant, and only capable of hurting people. At first she forced herself to stay, shifting back and forth from one foot to the other, almost like punishment -like she deserved at least this minor discomfort. But eventually she lets herself leave, covering herself with a towel and again sinking to the floor up against a wall. Time passes as she sits there feeling miserable. When she finally raises her head from her arms, she realizes that Adora could be home at any minute, and she absolutely can NOT see her like this. She had to snap out of it.

She stands slowly, taking note of how dark it seems outside. It must be getting late. Catra goes through the motions, hoping that

somehow itll make her feel less wretched. She scrunches her hair and lets it air dry a little, applies lotion, finds a spare toothbrush - because of course Adora has spare toothbrushes -and brushes her teeth. She walks back out to the bedroom and flops down on the bed, tossing and turning. She would have to face Adora sometime tonight. She checks her phone again. It's 9:05. Shouldnt Adora be back by now? What could she have been doing this whole time if she wasnt even on this case anymore? But tha Adora would let that stop her from doing work.

BzHer phone is ringing. Catra raises the phone over her head. Another unknown number. It's different than the one before -I think...She lets it ring, her hand falling back onto the bed. She cant risk it being one of Hordak's goons. The buzing stops and Catra notices how fast her heart is beating. Shit. She really is spooked. And why shouldnt she be? BzThey left her a voicemail. Who would do that? Catra couldnt remember the last time somebody left her a voicemail. It was...Adora. Adora leaves her voicemails.

She clicks on the icon . A transcription pops up and the first few words confuse her, startle her, make her freeze.

Hi there. My name is is _calling from Light Hope Hospital…

She didnt read the rest. She clicks play . "Hi there, my name is Rachael. Im calling you from Light Hope Hospital. W e have your sister here, Adora. She gave you as her emergency contact. She's been shot. She's in emergency surgery right now -"

Catra stops it. She restarts. That's not real. "Hi there, my name is Rachael. Im calling you from Light Hope Hospital. W e have your sister here, Adora -"

This cant be fucking happening. She' s been shot.' Tears blurred her vision as the floor crumbled out from under her feet. This was a nightmare right? She fell asleep. She stumbled of f the bed, grabbing the first pieces of clothing that looked like they would fit. Her heart felt like it was going to burst out of her chest it was beating so hard,

thrumming in her ears. She was down the stairs and throwing doors on autopilot. Finally she found Glitter. "Car keys."

She was sitting at a desk on a computer. The shorter woman just looked confused. "What?"

"I need your car. Where are your fucking keys?" She probably looked crazy with still-damn, unbrushed hair, tears still falling down her face, unnoticed. She had no idea what she was even wearing -not socks. There was no time.

"I don't-"

"Adora's in the hospital. We don't have time. I need. Your. Keys."

The pink-haired girl got up now concerned. She seemed to comprehend that something was wrong. Finally. Goddamn. "Okay. Okay."

They were already in the car on the way there when Glimmer finally spoke. "What happened?"

Catra was trying not to tear into the leather seats with her nails. Why did this bitch drive so fucking slow?

She felt her pulse in her ears. "What happened?"

"I don't know. They said she'd been shot." Another wave of ice crashed through her remembering their uncomfortable car trip. The way she said 'I would have died' as such a matter of fact. "They were taking her into emergency surgery."

"You're her emergency contact?" Catra was too scared to feel smug about the hint of defensiveness in the other woman's voice. She nodded sinking further into the seat. Please, God. If you're there, if you hear me, let her be okay. I swear I'll clean it up. I'll become a goddamn nun or a monk or whatever it is you want, but she has to be okay. I'd do literally anything. Sure, she'd planned on leaving

again -disappearing -but she never anticipated living in a world where Adora wasn't, where it wasn't even possible to ever see her again. She couldn't do it. Couldn't this car go any faster?

Chapter End Notes

This is the end of PART 1 of a 3 part series or collection, or whatever you'd like to call it. The second piece will read like a prequel, or a series of one-shots from their childhood together .

Ten Minutes

Chapter Summary

This is NOT the chapter after chapter 10. This was something that was "formally requested" of me by somebody . This is pure smut. Ipresent to you: the sexy shenanigans that happen in the ten minutes between Adora's phone calls. AKA: Chapter 9.5?

Chapter Notes

Sorry about the strange time skip on this. Ididn't want to do what Idid with the midnight chapter in Pt 2, so Ijust stuck it onto the end -Ihope that doesn't throw too many people for a loop.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora sets a time and leaves her phone on top of the dresser. Catra's eyes are darkened with want, but not so dark that the glint of mischief is gone as she's looking over her shoulder, smiling. She knows she won -she knows what she's doing. "Stay like that." Adora licks her lips as she approaches the bed again, watching intently as Catra takes hold of the bedding under her fingers, preparing herself. She looks so fucking good like this. Adora spits in her hand and rubs it over the head of the toy for good measure. The height of the bed is a bit awkward -Adora will have to angle herself just enough to be annoying, not optimal for thrusting, but shell make due.

When the toy starts to push inside, Catra whines and the sound makes Adora groan -so does the sight of her. Why had they never done this before? She slides the rest of the toy in fast, so as to not let any air in with it -she knows Catra hates that, mostly because she finds it embarrassing. Now Catra's spread open and her insides are speared, clamping down tight around the length of the toy -beautiful. She looks so concentrated. "Feel full?" Catra just nods, biting her lip and squeezing the bedding in her hand. "Good."

Then take it. That's what she wants to say. She wants to grab Catra's hip right where that butbble-butt meets the thigh and dive in, but in this position it might hurt -that's the last thing she wants. She starts to ask if Catra's comfortable enough for her to move. "Can I-"

"Ruin me."

Catra's walls resist as she pulls out, just enough to start the friction before pushing all the way back in, giving her best effort to transfer even a small portion of the fire now coursing through her veins into Catra. It must be working -right away she's biting the blanket between her teeth and crying out, begging Adora, not for anything in particular, other than that she just doesnt stop. Or maybe it is that she's begging for something -the words just keep coming out jumbled and breathless, and Adora cant get enough of her like this. Every rasped word sends another jolt of electricity through the blonde, driving her wild, which only makes her fuck Catra with more vigor, which only makes her louder. It's a glorious cycle. Adora never knew Catra could sound like this. Well...she did, but it was a treat, something she only got once in a while when the house was empty or she just didnt care enough to try and keep Catra quiet. Now she has only one thought: Iwanna hear her scream.

She slows down and Catra protests with a series of mewling noises. Adora didnt realize she herself was so out of breath until she tried to talk and the words came out in pants. "Move forward." Catra looks back at her with nothing but blissful obedience in her eyes. She brings her legs out of the splits and it occurs to Adora just how spread open she's been -she must be tired. No wonder her legs are quivering so much. The toy only pulls out for a moment while Adora's clamoring up onto the bed behind her. Then she's pushing on Catra's back, willing her to lay flat against the bed and she groans. "Adora." They've only done this twice and it's been so long...but Adora can tell she knows exactly what's about to happen.

She pulls and rotates the toy in the harness before pushing back in, trying to align the curve to put the most pressure on Catra's front wall. As it enters her, she sighs. "Yes!" Catra starts to claw at the bed

again as Adora presses her hips down into the mattress from above, ready to hold herself up. First, she leans down close to Catra's ear and breathes her in, letting herself pretend this means Catra is really hers. One thing is for certain though: even if, when all of this is over and Catra cuts her out again, Adora's going to make damn sure nobody else pleases her this way, that SHE is the only one who can give Catra pure ecstasy.

"I wanna hear you scream for me."

Catra groans, once from the words themselves, and a second time as Adora pushes herself up, forcing Catra down against the bed. She's immediately frantic trying to find something to grab onto -to squeeze the life out of. Adora smiles, feeling pride and lust swell within her at every frenized movement and every nonsensical cry that tears from those perfect open lips. Now her arms are getting tired and she's panting harder against Catra's wild mane of hair, but it's so worth it. Take it. Her mouth is closed and she looks like she's holding onto the bed for dear life -she's so desperate. "Stop fighting it, Catra." Faster . "Let go and cum for me." Catra's mouth closes again for a moment and Adora can see her gritting her teeth still. She starts to actively push down with each thrust, increasing the pressure.

"FFF-f fff--uck!" Catra's legs start to shake and every pump of Adora's hips -driven by her body weight and then some -elicits a higher and louder cry. She's so close. Adora is desperate to hear her scream for real -unabashed and unconcerned for other people hearing them. Her breaths come in short little bursts. There's only one thought in Adora's mind: keep going. Push her farther. Fuck...just a little farther . Yes. She's losing it. Just-

Catra's voice pierces the air in the room and Adora watches every movement with intention this time, committing the other woman's body's movements to memory. Maybe lack of movement would be a better descriptor. In an instant, Adora feels Catra's body go from rigid, with eyes shut tight, brow furrowed and teeth clenched, instantly to slack as her eyes roll back and her mouth falls open to let

out the scream she's been holding back so diligently. Then the only movement is her insides pulsing around the toy's length, still moving gently back and forth, slowing down, and the twitch of her hips against the bed.

Adora watches in amazement as her eyelids start to flutter and her fingers twitch, still panting. When her eyes open, she looks far away. "Catra, are you okay?" She doesn't give a verbal response, just a slow blink and one almost-nod. "That was...so hot"

The brunette's tongue presses against her teeth and she laughs. Adora beams, letting herself down onto her elbows on either side of Catra, brushing hair away from her sweaty face. Her cheeks are flushed and she looks dazed with pleasure -she looks...happy. Really happy...with me. She's so gorgeous. Catra swallows. "How loud was that?"

Adora kisses her cheek. "Loud." Catra responds with a nod. They lay there and breathe for a moment and Adora thinks to herself that this woman -this crazy, bratty, intoxicating woman is the only person she'll ever feel so drawn to. She can't imagine wanting anyone so much. And now Catra looks a bit more present and her usual mischievous glint has returned.

"Roll over."

Adora is surprised -in part because she didn't think Catra's legs would support her right now, but also because she hadn't even thought about that position this time. "Are you s-"

"Roll over!"

Adora pulls out -slowly, because she can see Catra wince a little bit - and lifts herself up. She watches Catra just lay there for a moment longer before stretching her legs. She rolls over, a languid and sensual movement starting from her hip. Adora's eyes follow the lines of her body all the way down to her ankle. "C'mon Adora. Lay down."

That controlled tone has returned and Adora knows Catra will tease her, feeling back in control now. Still, she does as she's told. She lays down slowly, the brunette's heated gaze watching her as she lets her weight down on the bed. "I don't think you-"

"Shhhh." Catra places a finger against her lips, leaning closer. Suddenly, out of nowhere she seems to have gotten her legs back and she throws herself on top of Adora straddling her hips in front of the toy. Adora runs her hands over Catra's sides and shivers under the combined weight of her wet core pressed to Adora's skin and her eyes, which are screaming one simple challenge: I'm going to ride you. We'll see how long she can last. Adora is determined to break her record and impress Catra again and again tonight, but she'll let Catra be in control -for now. After all, she's so good at -THAT.

Catra has started rolling her hips in small circles, gyrating just out of reach in a delicious pattern, until she finally does make contact again and grind down -oof. Adora's fingers squeeze possessively at the soft flesh at the side of her thighs while her eyes move higher to appraise the two pert high breasts, proudly on display as her hips wind. "See something you like, princess?"

Adora opens her mouth to say 'you' when the timer goes off. Goddammit. Why did I set it for ten minutes? She groans and Catra looks at her with disappointment. She wants nothing more than to throw her phone across the room and say 'fuck it'-she's off the case anyways. But...she really shouldn't. "I have to go."

Chapter End Notes

Go to my IG to find out how to "request" things. (Is this legal? I don't know how this works)

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